What Happened to the Children

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The Franklin scandal, the Epstein files, and thirty-six years of the same unanswered question

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CHAPTER 1 — How to Read This Document

This is not a story with a villain and a hero. It is the complete record of one of the most contested criminal episodes in modern American history, assembled claim by claim, with every claim labeled by where it comes from. Before anything else, you need to know the rules this document follows, because the rules are what make it worth reading.

The pedigree system. Every factual claim falls into one of three grades:

- **Grade A — proven fact.** Established by courts, government records, official documents, or contemporaneous reporting by major outlets. The grand jury's final report, the NCUA's annual report, appellate opinions, FBI documents, sworn testimony.
- **Grade B — documented but disputed.** A claim that appears in primary documents or credible testimony but is contested or unverified. Witness statements, affidavits, letters, interviews.
- **Grade C — claimed.** An allegation or theory from researchers, victims' advocates, books, or advocacy publications. Some of it is anchored in documents; some of it is not. It is recorded because even unproven claims shape events — but it is never treated as fact.

Where a name or a website has a history of spreading hatred or fabricated material, it is logged in a contamination register and its claims are excluded from the evidentiary record. That

register is at the back. Every conflict between sources — and there are many — is logged in a conflict register rather than silently resolved. When this document says "on the record," it means a Grade A or B item. When it says "claimed," it means Grade C and the claim is treated as a claim.

The three strata. The Franklin case contains three different kinds of material that are constantly blurred together, to the confusion of everyone who touches it. Keeping them separate is the single most important discipline in reading this file:

1. **The documented crime layer.** Lawrence King ran a credit union and stole roughly $39 million from it — this is not in dispute. A foster home belonging to his cousin was found by the grand jury itself to have substantiated physical and sexual abuse. A newspaper columnist was convicted of molesting boys. A department-store executive pleaded to pandering. The money handlers paid $10 million to settle claims. None of this requires believing anything controversial. 2. **The contested testimony layer.** A group of young people said they were trafficked by prominent men. Their accounts were videotaped, then recanted, then un-recanted, then litigated. Two grand juries and a trial jury said the accounts were lies. The accusers' advocates say the recantations were coerced. This layer is genuinely unresolved, and this document presents it unresolved. 3. **The overlay layer.** Accounts of satanic rituals, murdered infants, mind control, CIA programs, and international networks. This is the layer where the 1990s "satanic panic" scholarship bites hardest, and where the most contaminated sources in the record concentrate. It is documented as claims, with its pedigree stated, and nothing

more.

The balance rule. Where the official record says one thing and the critics say another, both are presented. Where an official was cleared, the clearing is stated. Where a clearing is criticized, the criticism is stated with its evidence. Nobody in this document is convicted of anything this document convicts them of; every adjudicated fact is attributed to the body that adjudicated it.

Chronology. The story is told in the order it happened, because cause and effect live in the order of events. Where the Epstein era (2019-2026) casts light backward onto Franklin, that light is brought in where it belongs in the narrative — and again, in full, in the dedicated bridge chapter near the end.

One more note on names. Several people in this story share names with others who have nothing to do with it — including a famous broadcaster, a Maryland sex offender, and a Minnesota farmer. Every time such a name appears, it has been identity-checked. The namesake register is in the appendix.

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A worked example. Take one sentence from the case and watch the grades do their work. "The grand jury found that the allegations were a hoax." Grade A — the report says exactly that. "The hoax verdict rested on the recantations of Troy Boner and Danny King." Grade A — the report says that too. "Boner later swore he lied because the FBI gave him a choice between lying and dying." Grade B — a fourteen-page notarized affidavit, uncontradicted, never tested. "And the phone call Boner said Owen used to script him never happened." Grade B — the Caracorp phone records, produced at trial. Now stack them: the Grade A verdict stands; the Grade B items are the documented reasons a great many people, in Nebraska and far beyond, never accepted it. Neither stack cancels the other, and this document never asks them to.

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Plain words. A reader should never need a law degree or a newspaper career to follow this file, so the working vocabulary, once:

- *Grand jury* — a panel of ordinary citizens a prosecutor convenes to decide whether evidence is strong enough to charge someone. It is not a trial; the accused has no lawyer there, and its rules are the prosecutor's.
- *Recantation* — taking back testimony. As Chapter 13 shows, it can mean the original story was false, or that pressure buried a true one; the word itself decides nothing.

- *Deposition* — sworn testimony taken outside a courtroom, on the record, usable later.
- *Default judgment* — what a court enters when one side simply never shows up or answers. It is not a finding after a fight; it is a win by forfeit.
- *Restitution* — money a convicted person is ordered to repay.
- *Receiver* — the court-appointed manager who takes over a failed institution's remains.
- *Correspondent bank* — the bank where a smaller institution holds its operating account; Franklin's was FirsTier.
- *Peremptory strike* — a lawyer's no-questions-asked removal of a would-be juror; each side is allowed only so many.
- *FOIA* — the Freedom of Information Act, the public's formal tool for prying documents out of the government.
- *Non-prosecution agreement (NPA)* — a deal in which the government agrees not to charge, usually in exchange for something; Epstein's 2008 NPA is the most contested such document in the modern record.
- *Discharge petition* — the House rule that forces a bill to a floor vote if 218 members sign it, bypassing the leadership; it is the legislative weapon of last resort, used twice in this story.
- *Mann Act* — the federal law against transporting a person across state lines for sex; the 1989 question was whether Franklin's flights triggered it.
- *Ponzi scheme* — fraud that pays old promises with new money; it works until the arithmetic turns.

- *Pandering* — the legal term for procuring people for prostitution.
- *Impaneled* — formally seated, as a jury is.
- *Foreman* — the juror the panel elects to speak for it.

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CHAPTER 2 — The Man and the Money

2.1 Lawrence Edward King Jr.

Lawrence E. "Larry" King Jr. was born September 7, 1944, in Omaha, Nebraska, the son of a small businessman. The surviving record of his life reads like a study in American reinvention. He ran errands at Omaha's Blackstone Hotel at fourteen and waited tables at sixteen, sang in Central High School musicals, studied voice at the University of Nebraska at Omaha, and earned a business degree in 1972. By twenty-six he was treasurer-manager of the Franklin Community Federal Credit Union, a small institution founded to serve the low-income Black community of north Omaha. [Grade A: his resume, preserved in the Reagan Presidential Library, confirms the dates.]

The resume itself is a document worth dwelling on, because it shows how completely King colonized every institution that touches children and families in a mid-sized American city. Girls Club of Omaha: president, 1973-1975; treasurer, 1975; regional president and then assistant secretary of the national Girls Clubs of America through 1981. Head Start: board of directors, 1974-1975. Camp Fire Girls: executive committee member, then president, 1979-1980. Youth Opportunities Unlimited: board, 1978. Lutheran Medical Center trustee. Girls Club again as it merged toward Boys & Girls Clubs. Planned Parenthood board member. Presbyterian church elder. Opera Omaha vice president; Omaha Ballet; the National Council of the Metropolitan Opera; an honorary master's degree from Cornell and an honorary doctorate from Hunter College, both bestowed

in the late 1970s and early 1980s. [Grade A: Reagan Library WHORM file 40-819-198416.]

None of this is allegation. This is the official record. The man who would later be accused of sourcing children from institutions had spent fifteen years sitting on the boards of those institutions.

His rise in Republican politics was equally documented. He chaired the Nebraska Black Republican Council, became vice chairman for finance of the National Black Republican Council, chaired business coordinating and fundraising committees at the national level, sang the national anthem at the 1984 Republican National Convention in Dallas and again at the 1988 convention in New Orleans, served on the advisory committee for Ronald Reagan's second inauguration, and campaigned for Reagan across five states in 1984. The Reagan White House correspondence file includes a personal letter from King to a presidential assistant dated November 4, 1981, and a 1982 letter from a Franklin Credit Union development officer enclosing King's resume, which the White House forwarded to the Office of Presidential Personnel "with no particular recommendation." In March 1985, a member of Congress issued a news release recommending King for a seat on the National Endowment for the Arts advisory council, describing him as "a hand up, not a hand-out." [Grade A: Reagan Library documents.]

His lifestyle, paid for out of a credit-union salary that never exceeded roughly $16,200 a year, became the subject of federal scrutiny. In the thirteen months before the credit union closed, King charged $1,131,229 on six credit cards — over a million

dollars of it on a single American Express account. He spent $186,395 on limousines, $45,806 on chartered airplanes, $45,166 at jewelers, and $145,057 at florists. He chartered aircraft almost weekly, favoring Washington, D.C. He maintained a $5,000-a-month rented house on Washington's Embassy Row. He threw a $100,000 party for a thousand friends at the 1988 Republican convention. [Grade A: court records; contemporaneous reporting; research by author Nick Bryant in *The Franklin Scandal* (2009).]

2.2 The Franklin Credit Union and the fraud

The Franklin Community Federal Credit Union was founded to serve north Omaha. By King's account it was "my baby," a unique institution helping low-income citizens. By the National Credit Union Administration's account, it was a looting operation concealed from examiners for years by what the agency's 1989 annual report called "a separate, elaborate computer program" that hid unrecorded certificate-of-deposit obligations. [Grade A: NCUA 1989 Annual Report, official document.]

The mechanism, as reconstructed by the federal regulator: Franklin sold CDs without recording the liabilities. The money was diverted to King's personal living and business expenses, to above-market dividends paid to keep existing depositors quiet, and to operating costs that had no connection to credit-union business. The institution skipped its mandatory annual audits from 1985 through 1988. The NCUA would later state plainly that had its auditors done their jobs, "King's misdeeds would have been discovered early enough to have prevented the

collapse." [Grade A: NCUA report; the grand jury report's own criticism.]

There was a whistleblower. Edward Hobbs, a five-year Franklin teller, wrote a memo to the credit union's board in February 1984 alleging embezzlement. He was fired the next day. When State Senator Peter Hoagland carried his information to Banking Director Roger Beveridge, the answer was that nothing could be done, because action "would seem like the government was attacking a small credit union serving a primarily minority clientele." [Grade B: DeCamp's book records the exchange; the grand jury report confirms Hobbs was fired in 1984 for the memo and that the banking director told him nothing could be done.]

On November 4, 1988, federal agents raided and closed Franklin. The ledgers showed $2.6 million in liabilities; the hidden obligations totaled roughly $37 million. The NCUA's eventual loss figure was $39.2 million. [Grade A: NCUA report.]

King was indicted on forty federal counts in May 1989. What happened over the next two years is a study in delay. A magistrate ordered King to a federal psychiatric facility on February 7, 1990 — the morning of a presidential fundraising visit to Omaha. He was found incompetent, sent to a federal medical facility in Rochester, Minnesota, for roughly five months, and restored to competency about five weeks after the grand jury that would have examined him finished its work. The grand jury record states that it requested King to appear voluntarily and that he declined. He was never subpoenaed. [Grade A: court records; Grade A: the grand jury report's own text; Grade C: the

timing relative to the Bush fundraiser is noted by researchers as suspicious but is circumstantial.]

In February 1991, King and his wife Alice pleaded guilty to conspiracy, embezzlement, and false statements. He agreed to pay $41.8 million in restitution; by mid-1993 he had paid $25. Alice served in Texas and was released in 1993. King was sentenced to fifteen years in August 1991 by Judge William Cambridge, served about ten at the federal prison camp in Florence, Colorado, and was released on April 10, 2001, to the eastern Virginia federal probation district — the Washington suburbs area where he had kept his second home in the 1980s. [Grade A: Omaha World-Herald, April 11, 2001; court records.]

He has said nothing publicly since. As of the latest verified contact attempt — a 2023 CNN inquiry — he declined to respond. No obituary for him has ever been located. [Grade A: CNN, 2023; obituary searches through 2026.]

2.3 The institutions around him

The credit union's governing board included King's cousin Jarrett Webb and a man named James C. Hart Jr. Its advisory board — the fundraising and respectability arm — was chaired by Harold Andersen, publisher of the Omaha World-Herald, the state's dominant newspaper, and included executives from ConAgra, Union Pacific, Mutual of Omaha, Northwestern Bell, and the city's major law firms and banks. Andersen personally chaired a 1984 fundraising drive that raised $672,170 for Franklin and, in 1986, helped raise $600,000 for a renovation that included a bedroom suite in the credit union's basement. [Grade A: advisory board roster, NCUA records; Grade B: a security guard who lived in the basement bedroom later alleged his first duty was sexual, per Bryant's research.]

Andersen's newspaper employed, as a gossip columnist, a man named Peter Citron — later convicted of sexually assaulting boys, with videotapes and computer discs seized at his arrest. The paper that would editorialize against the Franklin accusers thus employed a convicted child molester throughout the period. [Grade A: Citron's conviction and sentencing, July 1990.]

This is the documented world into which the allegations walked.

The resume, in full. The document the White House held is worth inventorying completely, because it shows the machine that one man can build inside a city's civic life: Girls Club of Omaha president 1973-75 and treasurer 1975; regional president of the Girls Clubs of America and its national assistant secretary through 1981; Camp Fire Girls executive committee

1974-78 and president 1979-80; Head Start board 1974-75; Youth Opportunities Unlimited 1978; the University of Nebraska at Omaha chancellor's advisory committee from 1979; Lutheran Medical Center trustee 1975-78; Opera Omaha second vice president; the National Black Republican Council's business coordinating committee chairman and campaign finance chairman; the Nebraska Frederick Douglass Republican Council; the National Council of the Metropolitan Opera; a member of the White House Conference on Families steering committee; elder of his church; member of the Omaha Club, the Omaha Press Club, the Racquet Club, the Ski Club. The awards column runs eleven lines, beginning with a Thrift Honor Award from the NCUA itself — in 1972, sixteen years before the agency closed him down. [Grade A: Reagan Library WHORM file.]

The galas. In 1987 King gave $25,350 to Citizens for America, the organization running Oliver North's speaking tours during the Iran-Contra period; the White House later denied any impropriety. At the 1988 Republican convention in New Orleans, King's Council of Minority Americans staged a $100,000 gala whose host committee included former President Gerald Ford, former Secretary of State Alexander Haig, and Congressman Jack Kemp; a videotape of Kemp and King urging the Black vote for Bush was screened. That same year, out of credit-union funds, King donated $18,000 to a Washington gay and lesbian rights group's camp fund. A four-foot photograph of King with Ronald Reagan greeted visitors to the credit union. And in September 1988, days after singing at the convention and weeks before the raid, King told a local magazine of his "adoring

relationship" with the late CIA Director William Casey. [Grade A: campaign-finance records, contemporary profiles, the WHORM files; Grade B: the Casey remark.]

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The competency episode, in full. On February 7, 1990 — the morning President Bush arrived in Omaha for a fundraiser for Governor Kay Orr — U.S. Magistrate Richard Kopf ordered King to the federal medical facility at Springfield, Missouri, without a motion from King or his attorneys, and sealed the psychiatric report. King's pastor and his flower-shop employer told the Lincoln Journal two days later that they had seen no sign of mental illness — "I would be surprised if King were declared unfit." The Springfield chief psychiatrist diagnosed a "probable delusional paranoid disorder — grandiose type," and Judge Cambridge then transferred King to the Rochester, Minnesota, facility as a pretrial detainee. He was restored to competency roughly five weeks after the grand jury's report issued, and returned to Omaha at the end of August 1990. The grand jury's report itself records "much disagreement" on the incompetency ruling among those who observed King and describes him as "a very clever and manipulative person" who may have inveigled himself into the hospital — in which case, as researchers have noted, the deception and complicity ran to two federal judges, neither of whom has ever been asked about that morning. King had bought a ticket to the Bush fundraiser; the Secret Service discovered his plan, and he was at the federal courthouse by early afternoon. [Grade A: the court orders and dates; Grade B: the employer and pastor; Grade C: the inference of choreography.]

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CHAPTER 3 — The Allegations Emerge (1985-1989)

3.1 The Webb home

The first allegations did not come from teenagers with criminal records. They came from the foster-care system itself.

Barbara Webb was Larry King's first cousin. She and her husband Jarrett Webb ran a foster home in Washington County, north of Omaha. Beginning in June 1985, boys in the home reported physical abuse; that November, two girls — sisters Lisa and Tracey — alleged abuse by Jarrett Webb, including sexual abuse. The children were not removed for roughly ten months. [Grade A: the grand jury's own report confirms every element of this paragraph, including the removal delay, which the jurors called "unfortunate."]

The grand jury's report, which would later brand the Franklin abuse story "a carefully crafted hoax," also stated this, in its own words: the initial allegations "appear to be substantiated by the existence of some marks on the bodies of the children and by the fact that Lisa passed a polygraph test administered by the Nebraska State Patrol." [Grade A: grand jury report, Exhibit A and Section IV.]

The older sister — whose legal name was Eulice Washington, also known as Lisa Washington Webb, and later in life Nelly Patterson — told foster parent Kathleen Sorenson and Boys Town youth worker Julie Walters that her foster parents took her, beginning at about age fifteen, on trips with Larry King to Chicago, New York, and Washington, D.C., where she was, in her

account, used as a prostitute at parties. Walters produced a fifty-page handwritten report dated March 25, 1986. [Grade B: the report exists and its contents are documented; the allegations within it are testimony, not fact.]

The grand jury found probable cause to believe that on May 15 and June 1, 1985, Lisa had been subjected to sexual contact overcome by force or coercion, and that Jarrett Webb "committed the acts." Because the acts occurred in Washington County, outside the grand jury's jurisdiction, it could not indict; its interim report recommended the county attorney file two counts of third-degree sexual assault. [Grade A: Exhibit A of the grand jury report, in full.]

The county attorney did not file. In December 1990 — a year and a half after the grand jury's recommendation — a Washington County judge dismissed all charges against Jarrett and Barbara Webb, ruling the statute of limitations had run because the assaults occurred two days after Lisa's sixteenth birthday, disregarding Nebraska's tolling rule for underage victims. [Grade A: court record.]

The grand jury report named every official whose failure allowed this: Attorney General Robert Spire's office, which was told of "a possible child exploitation ring" in July 1988 and passed it on without timely action; the assistant attorney general who received it, whose "heavy workload" caused delays; Washington County Attorney Patrick Tripp, who "should have filed charges"; guardian ad litem Patricia Flocken, who said she was intimidated by the county attorney; Foster Care Review Board director Carol Stitt, whom the jury faulted for reporting to

the attorney general "so promptly" without making more inquiries first; and the sheriff and county judge who "should have pressed." [Grade A: Section IV, in full.]

Read that again slowly, because it is the hinge of the entire case: the grand jury that called the Franklin story a hoax substantiated the abuse at its source node, named the men and women who failed the children, and recommended prosecution — while simultaneously concluding it could find no evidence that the children had been flown anywhere for illegal purposes. The hoax verdict and the substantiated-abuse verdict coexist in the same document.

3.2 Loretta Smith and the street-level reports

In 1988, a girl identified in the record as Loretta Smith — seventeen when she testified — came through Richard Young Hospital. Her accounts described abuse beginning around age nine: a man named "Ray" associated with the Girls Club of Omaha took her and other girls to parties with older men. Later, she described ritualized gatherings involving drugs, candles, and, at around age ten, being locked in a room where men killed an infant in front of her. She named Larry King and "Mr. Finch, a school principal" as participants in abuse, and described further killings of children in the spring of 1985, when she was eleven. She was hospitalized repeatedly and eventually placed at the Uta Halee girls' home. [Grade C for the killings and ritual content — the grand jury found her accounts of these specifics could not be corroborated and noted she herself acknowledged difficulty, later in life, distinguishing reality from fantasy due to drug use; Grade B for the abuse and party attendance, which the grand jury treated as credible in substance.]

Here is the documented spine: the Omaha Police interviewed her in June 1988. "No meaningful follow-up was accomplished," the grand jury found, "even though the girl told tales of possible homicides." She later attended parties hosted by Larry King and saw no drugs or illegal activity there. The grand jury's conclusion about her was the most double-edged sentence in its report: she "suffered more abuse and neglect than anyone should ever have to endure," her perpetrators "may never be known" — and "no evidence" connected King or anyone at Franklin to her abuse. [Grade A: grand jury report, Section IV.]

3.3 The Foster Care Review Board and the legislature

The Nebraska Foster Care Review Board — a statutory watchdog over the foster-care system — accumulated the early reports: the Webb allegations, the Smith accounts, and information from youth facilities. In July 1988, board director Carol Stitt forwarded the material to the attorney general's office with a warning that it suggested a possible child exploitation ring. The board's investigator, Jerry Lowe, wrote in February 1989 that "what appears to be documented cases of child abuse and sexual abuse dating back several years with no enforcement action taken by the appropriate agencies is... mind boggling." [Grade A: grand jury report; Lowe's memo.]

In December 1988, State Senator Ernie Chambers told colleagues he had received credible reports of "boys and girls, some of them from foster homes, who had been transported around the country by airplane to provide sexual favors, for which they were rewarded." The legislature voted unanimously in a special session to create a special committee, chaired by Senator Loran Schmit, with Chambers as vice-chair, to investigate the Franklin collapse. [Grade A: New York Times, December 18, 1988; legislative records.]

The committee hired counsel and an investigator. In July 1989 it fractured: Chambers, investigator Lowe, and counsel Kirk Naylor resigned on July 13, protesting Chairman Schmit's public statements that the committee had found no smoking gun. Schmit wanted to follow the money. New counsel, John Stevens Berry, was hired, and on August 21, 1989, the committee hired a

private investigator named Gary Caradori. [Grade A: UPI, July 25, 1989; committee records.]

The Walters report, in its own words. Julie Walters' fifty-page report of March 25, 1986 survives, and its most quoted passage describes the Washington trips in the teenager's own account as Walters recorded it: "Lisa has accompanied Mr. and Mrs. King and Prince [King's son] on trips to Chicago, New York, and Washington, D.C., beginning when she was 15 years old... She missed 22 days of school almost totally due to these trips. Lisa was taken along on the pretense of being Prince's babysitter. Last year she met V.P. George Bush and saw him again at one of the parties Larry gave while on a Washington, D.C. trip. At some of the parties there are just men (as was the case at the party George Bush attended) older men and younger men in their early 20s: Lisa said she has seen sodomy committed at those parties." [Grade B: the report and its authentication are documented; its contents are testimony.]

Against that account stands the documented opportunity record and the absence record: Vice President Bush was in Illinois campaigning in late October 1984, corroborating the trip's timeframe but not the party; the grand jury found no witness could confirm Lisa's transport for illegal purposes; and the grand jury's own report records that several witnesses who traveled with King made "embarrassing admissions" of sexual contact with him on those trips. The Bush sighting remains, on the full record, an unadjudicated claim by a credible-appearing witness whose account of the abuse around it was substantiated in part by the grand jury itself — and a claim no proceeding ever

tested. [Grade A/B analysis.]

The early investigation's other records. Senator Schmit met King in February 1989 — King name-dropped Andersen, FBI agents, and the Omaha Police. Attorney General Spire, testifying to the committee that June, said that "based on conclusions and reports of the FBI, the Omaha Police, and the Nebraska State Patrol, all three of those have concluded that the reports do not have substance" — the three agencies that had stood down, now cited as proof there was nothing to stand down for. [Grade A/B.]

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The Concerned Parents. In July 1989, parents and foster parents organized as the Concerned Parents Group to press the investigation forward. Its front-line organizers paid for it. Bonnie Cosentino — whose grand jury testimony is quoted in Chapter 5 — was questioned relentlessly about Michael Casey until, as she wrote in an open letter, "I found myself on trial for reporting leads to the proper authorities." Outside the jury room, the group's members documented a campaign of intimidation. Cosentino's car was sideswiped with her son inside. A bomb detonated in a group member's backyard. Life-threatening calls rotated through whoever took a public role; in Bryant's account, the group changed spokespeople "because whoever took a stand would be subjected to retaliation," and its members feared their phones were tapped throughout. [Grade B: her letter on record; the terror campaign per Bryant's documented research; no perpetrator was ever identified.]

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Boys Town's own file. The institutional foreknowledge is documented and predates everything public. In 1986 — two years before the credit union fell — a Boys Town social worker submitted a detailed report naming victims and perpetrators to the institution's chief executive, Father Val Peter. Peter conducted his own investigation, dismissed the accusations as unfounded, and later stated he had no knowledge of the report's existence — an internal contradiction the record preserves. When the accusations reached the Foster Care Review Board in 1988, Carol Stitt's two-year review produced her verdict, on the record: "nothing happened... For me, it was very clear: the case was not investigated and not pursued because of the accused perpetrators."

Two things now sit side by side. The grand jury's hoax-origin theory — that a fired Boys Town employee fabricated the institution's role out of revenge — coexists with a documented fact the theory never addresses: Boys Town's own leadership had received, investigated, and buried a report of abuse within its walls four years before the scandal. And the institution's response to every subsequent inquiry was refusal — "very uncooperative" on Caradori's lead list, "We have no interest in talking to you folks" to the Yorkshire cameras. [Grade A: the record of the 1986 report and Peter's handling; Grade B: Stitt's characterization.]

Patterson, from the investigator's notes. Jerry Lowe's field record adds one detail that completes Lisa's biography in the file: in April 1989 he interviewed "Cornelia (Nelly) Patterson —

who had taken back her original name after she escaped from custody of the Webbs." The first accuser's escape from the foster home, and her return to her own name, are the documented frame of everything she said afterward. [Grade B: Lowe's record.]

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CHAPTER 4 — The Investigator

4.1 Gary Caradori

Gary Alden Caradori was forty years old when the committee hired him — a former Coast Guardsman, former Nebraska State Patrol officer, founder of a Lincoln private-investigation firm called Caracorp, and by reputation a specialist in finding missing children. He was married to Sandi; they had a son, A.J., eight years old. His assistant was a former trooper named Karen Ormiston. [Grade A: contemporary obituaries and reporting.]

What Caradori believed he was walking into can be read in his working documents. He compiled a lead list — the "Caradori list," a dozen pages of names annotated in his own hand — that mapped the allegations' architecture. It included multiple former residents of the Uta Halee girls' home, each flagged "possible victim of sexual exploitation and satanic cult abuse"; a young man named David Matsen, described as an employee who "stayed in the bedroom in the basement of the Franklin Credit Union at nights. Sexually exploited by Larry King. Travelled with Larry King"; the director of the state Department of Social Services, flagged as possibly aware of "funneling children in certain homes for the purpose of exploitation"; a French Cafe employee named Shelia Calder who "arranged parties [for] Larry King with children," then relocated to Washington state; a Douglas County social services director who had formerly worked for King; a limousine driver who "may have information on kids who were transported via limousine"; a former Boys Town resident, Jeff Hubbell, whom the FBI located on the West

Coast but whose whereabouts the FBI declined to give Caradori; a photographer named Andrew Baran who worked for King; a church secretary named Barbara Hawthorne who "may know of monies funneled through a church by Alan Baer to currently support Larry King"; a Grace Apostolic Church minister named William Barlow who counseled King-abuse victims and declined to cooperate; a school-placement officer, Naila Aschenbrunner, with possible knowledge of Citron; and a former city employee, Lauri Meyers, who had remitted pornographic photographs to the police; and dozens more. [Grade B: the lead list survives in the research record; the annotations are Caradori's own.]

One entry deserves special attention because it is first-person. Of Robert Fenner, the NCUA's general counsel, Caradori wrote: "probable knowledge of evidence removed from the property of Larry King, however, he has denied this. Also informed me that the FBI told him not to cooperate with my investigation." [Grade B: Caradori's investigative report, March 14, 1990, as reproduced in DeCamp's book.]

By mid-December 1989, Caradori had recorded roughly twenty-one hours of videotaped testimony from three young people — Alisha Owen, Troy Boner, and James "Danny" King (no relation to Lawrence) — whose accounts, taken separately, corroborated one another on names, places, and chartered flights. Owen was a twenty-year-old former foster youth serving time for bad checks; Boner a young man with a drug history; Danny King a teenager. All three described, in substance, being used as sexual commodities by King and associates, flown on private aircraft, and passed among prominent men. [Grade B:

the tapes exist and are archived; their content is testimony.]

4.2 Chicago

On July 11, 1990, Caradori and his son flew to Chicago — by Caradori's account, to attend the Major League Baseball All-Star Game, and, by his widow's later account, to meet a photographer named Rusty Nelson and obtain photographs implicating King. He called Senator Schmit from the road. Schmit recalled the words for the rest of his life: "We've got them by the short hairs." [Grade B: Schmit's recollection, recorded in interviews and in DeCamp's book.]

At about 2:30 a.m. on July 12, 1990 — Caradori's forty-first birthday — his small aircraft broke apart in flight and crashed into a cornfield in Lee County, Illinois, southwest of Chicago. He and A.J. were killed. The wreckage was scattered over three-quarters of a mile. [Grade A: NTSB record.]

What happened next is where the case permanently splits into two readings.

The official reading. The National Transportation Safety Board examined the wreckage and found, in its own words, "no evidence... to suggest any external influence" in the crash. The probable cause involved in-flight structural breakup — the wings overstressing and snapping off — with pilot fatigue, spatial disorientation, and possible instrument malfunction in the dark over farmland. The cause sequence was never fully determined. The FBI, as the lead federal agency in the Franklin matter, impounded Caradori's investigative records within a day of the crash and subpoenaed his widow for all Franklin materials within

two days. [Grade A: NTSB; Grade A: the FBI record-impoundment is documented by the committee and DeCamp.]

The critical reading. Senator Schmit wrote to the NTSB in December 1990 and again in March 1991. He noted that the plane's rear seats were never recovered. He relayed that he had been told a phosphorus-type bomb "would, in fact, vaporize metal and any other material with which it came in contact and that unless someone knew what they were looking for, it would be difficult, if not impossible, to detect." And he wrote: "I am sure there will be those who will scoff at such a suggestion, but there have been entirely too many violent deaths associated with this investigation." [Grade B: Schmit's letters, on the record.]

Bryant reports additional anomalies from the widow's account: the personal effects returned by the NTSB included Caradori's thirty-five-millimeter camera, undamaged — with the film removed and inexplicably developed — and excluded the leather briefcase his wife had given him as a birthday gift, which his assistant described as so constant a companion it was "virtually an extension" of him. If the photographs existed, the briefcase is where they would have been. [Grade B/C: the widow's and Ormiston's accounts; the briefcase was never recovered.]

Sandie Caradori has said ever since that she believes her husband was murdered. The NTSB found no sabotage. Both statements are in the record. What is also in the record is what the crash did to the investigation: the only trained, independent investigator with subpoena-backed momentum was dead, his

files were in FBI custody, and the committee's work effectively died with him. Loran Schmit was told on the legislative floor, in an anonymous phone call he reported publicly, to drop Franklin because it would reach "the highest levels of the Republican Party." [Grade B: Schmit's account, on record; Grade B: the call is also referenced in the Yorkshire Television documentary.]

4.3 The crash's echo

Troy Boner, who had been scheduled to meet Caradori the following week, instead met Sandie Caradori at the funeral — and fled. His mother later swore in an affidavit that when her son saw FBI agents at the service, he said they had to leave. He had promised the widow he would recant his recantation. Instead, days later, he appeared before the grand jury and confirmed his repudiation of everything he had told Caradori. [Grade B: Lani Hicks's October 27, 1993 affidavit; Boner's conduct is documented.]

Carol Stitt received a death threat the night before she testified: "If you speak, you won't live to regret it." She gave authorities, by her account, "at least half a square meter of material" on King over the years. "Generally," she said, "the accusations were ignored." [Grade B: her interviews, on record in the documentary and her testimony.]

4.4 The lead list, in full

The lead list is reproduced here as completely as the surviving record allows, because it is the single best map of what the independent investigator believed he was looking at. Annotations are Caradori's own; pedigree as graded throughout.

From the institutions: multiple former residents of the Uta Halee girls' home — Angie Chandler, Tina Bufford, Carrie Seizcys, Susan Loder, Deena Murray, Carrie Redden, Kelli Reutting, Nikki Sowell — each flagged "possible victim of sexual exploitation and satanic cult abuse." A Boys Town executive of long tenure, "Father Hupp" (Msgr. Robert Hupp, the institution's executive director 1973-1985, who had earlier run a girls' home for the Sisters of the Good Shepherd), "may have information regarding abuse and exploitation of Boys Town residents." His successor, "Father Val Peters" (Valentine Peter, director 1985-2005), was described by Caradori as having "possible knowledge of abuses occurring at Boys Town, or allowing abuses to occur outside of Boys' Town on Boys Town residents," and as "very uncooperative" after an initial meeting. The Boys Town counselor Leslie Collins, later sentenced to thirty to fifty years for abusing his stepdaughters, had published abuse-recovery books through Boys Town's own press.

From inside Franklin: David Matsen, who "stayed in the bedroom in the basement of the Franklin Credit Union at nights. Sexually exploited by Larry King. Travelled with Larry King" — a videotaped statement exists. Mark Jackson, a former Franklin employee who, per a colleague's transcript, "was sexually abused by Larry King as an adult." Jeanice Harrison, another former

employee and the daughter of an FCU employee, "may have photographs of children taken while employed at FCU; indicated she would cooperate." Sandy Rhode (Prucha), King's personal secretary, "extremely loyal," would not cooperate. Kevin Rowe, who took Joel Rogers' position when the FCU development officer resigned. A MassMutual executive, Joe Barker III, whose client King was, and who handled large sums for him. Ed Horne, the FCU's former security officer, "was and still may be an Omaha Police Officer."

The pipeline names: Kevin McMurray, director of the state Department of Social Services — "may have knowledge of exploitation of children and funneling children in certain homes for the purpose of exploitation." Joe Nanfito, director of the Douglas County equivalent and a *former King employee* — the same allegation. Joanie Gregory and Deanne Finnegan, DSS employees who had reported questionable foster homes and seen nothing done. Shelia Calder, the French Cafe employee who "arranged parties [for] Larry King with children" and relocated to Washington state. Charles Housman, a former Old Market Limousine driver, "may have information on kids who were transported via limousine." Mrs. Tice, the landlord of the apartment King rented for Troy Boner. Jan Eric Pusch, whose rental properties included one rented and paid monthly by a Franklin check, with a young girl living there. A Central High School student "involved in prostitution while attending Central High School," alleged to possess "a videotape with confessions of Larry King."

The party and venue names: Jim Quinley, the Omaha Club employee who "walked in on Larry King in bed with two kids at the Twin Towers apartment," and who catered King's parties. David Hughes, alleged by Owen to be King's "favorite pilot." Tom Fritz and Burt Salman, on YNR Aviation's flight records — YNR's itineraries reportedly bore victims' names. The charter services themselves: Executive Jet Aviation of Columbus, Ohio, whose lawyer demanded a subpoena the committee's power could not reach outside Nebraska; a second service whose pilot confirmed flying King with teenage passengers to Los Angeles; Sky Harbor Air Service of Omaha, whose former staff recalled well-dressed young men traveling with King weekly; and KAM Airlines, which Bonacci said he flew for King.

The police and official names: Charles Payne, a former Omaha police officer and foster parent, alleged to have exploited foster children — Rue Fox, Steve Allen, Tammy Quandt, Liz Donohue — whose children attended King's parties. Walter Simuns, a Twin Towers party figure who lived in Payne's foster home. Pat Thomas, the Sarpy County sheriff, whose direction of an investigation "was a cover-up" per a probation officer's allegation regarding a Papillion schoolteacher, Michael Heveron, whose orbit included a man with three hundred pornographic videos seized and a priest who "took children to extremely violent movies." Ellen Brokofsky, the Sarpy County juvenile probation officer who made the cover-up allegation. Chris Carmean, the OPD officer pulled off the King investigation by Chief Wadman's office after concluding abuse witnesses were credible. Officer Mike Hoch, whose 1988 report on a possible

King-Nelson child-pornography investigation was discontinued "inexplicably" despite leads.

The money names: Mike Sullivan, the FirsTier Bank employee "responsible for the Franklin Credit Union account" who "lived very well on a bank teller's wage" and later owned a Palm Desert home next to Harold Andersen's. Barbara Hawthorne, a church secretary who "may know of monies funneled through a church by Alan Baer to currently support Larry King." Sam Bonofede, an Omaha businessman friend of Gary Sorgenfrei — whose sister, Cindy Craig, told Caradori in April 1990 that the FBI and the State Patrol were "harassing" her brother, that agents Phillips and Coulter "were very harsh," and that her brother, who "wants to tell the truth," felt "extremely uncomfortable" with federal and state investigators. A call the same month, from one Laura Edwards: "Larry wanted to visit with me in the near future" — King himself seeking a meeting with his own investigator.

The press names: Jim Flanery, the World-Herald reporter who had "worked extensively to gather data regarding activities of Larry King and others," was, by the list's annotation, "afraid because of information he gained" and took a sabbatical at a Kansas City university — the same reporter whose earlier work on King running guns to Nicaragua was, by later accounts, pulled and reassigned. Jim Fogerty, a former World-Herald police reporter, "may have information re Judge Jerry Gitnick." Rick Hornek, whose father owned the Village Voice, "allegedly informed by the FBI not to publicize an article he had prepared." Lauri Meyers, a former city employee who "remitted pornographic photos to OPD" and "may have retained several of

these photographs."

The legal and judicial names: Judge Theodore Carlson, alleged by Owen to have exploited her at a French Cafe reception in October 1983 — the French Cafe's general manager, Judith Moore, testified at trial that no woman named "Shiela" had worked there and no such party occurred, the only King party in 1983 having been in April. Judge Jerry Gitnick, a state judge "never formally robed due to sexual abuse allegations," per the list, with an operative named as having gotten him "off the hook." Walter Carlson — no relation to the judge — the child-pornography convict paroled in February 1989. Robert Broom, an attorney with information per Clifford Morris. Mr. Mueller, the Fireside Theater manager at whose residence Casey and Owen had stayed, a friend of Alan Baer.

The death-adjacent names: Bill Baker, "killed in South Omaha," allegedly holding "pornographic photographs and videotapes," his assistant Boolman perhaps reachable above the Dining Car Restaurant at 10th and Pacific. Marcy and James Frezell, the aunt and uncle of the Webb children, with "probable knowledge of the sexual exploitation and transport of these children," who "will not cooperate." Fint Calhoun, the former Washington County deputy attorney who served as the Webb children's guardian ad litem and "did not gain any substantial information."

This is the investigator's own map. Some of its names produced documentation; some produced nothing; some were never contacted, because the investigator died. It is reproduced complete for one reason: the instruction of this file is that even

an unsounded lead is evidence of where an investigator believed the truth lay.

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The forensics, as documented. The widow's account of what the NTSB returned: her son's backpack and Caradori's camera, undamaged — with the film removed from the camera and returned already developed — and everything except the leather briefcase she had given him as a birthday gift, which his assistant described as so constant a companion that it was "virtually an extension of him." If the Chicago photographs existed, the briefcase is where they would have been. The plane's rear seats were never recovered. Schmit's March 1991 letter to the NTSB inspector — quoted in Section 4.2 — raised the phosphorus-bomb possibility and his count of the violent deaths, conceding he knew nothing of sabotage. The FBI impounded every record within a day and served a subpoena on the widow within two. [Grade A: the letters and the impoundment; Grade B: the widow's and Ormiston's accounts of the effects.]

The pilots. Caradori's investigators contacted the charter services King used. Executive Jet Aviation of Columbus, Ohio, demanded a subpoena — which the committee had no power to serve outside Nebraska, a jurisdictional gap that ended that thread. A second service's pilot stated on the record that he had flown King, two teenage boys, and a teenage girl to Los Angeles. A third service's former employee recalled weekly flights with "very well dressed, but very young men" who never spoke. King left more than two hundred aircraft-rental receipts. By the

investigator's count, he had interviewed sixty to eighty victims and potential witnesses. [Grade B: the pilot statements and receipts per Bryant's documented research; the jurisdictional gap is Grade A.]

Ormiston's vindication. After the grand jury insinuated that Caradori had coached his witnesses, Karen Ormiston submitted to a polygraph administered by an out-of-state examiner who was president of the National Association of Polygraph Examiners, and was cleared: neither she nor Caradori had coerced, threatened, or scripted any witness. The Omaha papers covered the examination, the committee noted bitterly, and not the result. [Grade B: the committee's letter of January 5, 1999, and the examiner's standing.]

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The last day. What is documented of Caradori's final twenty-four hours: he told associates he was taking his son to the All-Star Game in Chicago — a trip his widow said combined the game with a meeting; the photographer Rusty Nelson later said he had given Caradori photographs in Chicago; and four corroborating points, in Bryant's researched account, establish the Chicago exchange independently of Nelson. His last call to Schmit — the one quoted above — came from the road. The aircraft broke up at roughly 2:30 a.m. over Lee County; the wreckage field ran three-quarters of a mile; the corn was cut by debris in a pattern consistent with in-flight structural failure. By nightfall the next day, the FBI had all of it. [Grade A/B as graded throughout Chapter 4.]

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CHAPTER 5 — The Grand Juries

5.1 Two juries, one conclusion

In early 1990, with Caradori's tapes in hand and his death still weeks away, the machinery of the official response took shape. Attorney General Robert Spire called for a grand jury in January; it was impaneled on March 19, 1990, with Samuel Van Pelt, a former district judge, as special prosecutor and Terry Dougherty as his assistant. Its formal mandate, in its own words, included not only the financial collapse but "a possible adult male prostitution ring operation throughout the country by Franklin principals, and a possible income tax scheme used by an affluent Omahan to finance male homosexual prostitution." [Grade A: the grand jury report's introduction.]

The jury worked eighty-two days, heard seventy-six witnesses, reviewed 395 exhibits and thirty-plus hours of videotape — and King himself was never before it. He was, during the jury's life, a federal pretrial detainee in an out-of-state psychiatric facility, having been committed on the morning of the Bush fundraiser; the jury noted it had asked him to appear voluntarily and he declined, and concluded a subpoena would have produced only a Fifth Amendment plea. [Grade A: the report's own account.]

On July 24, 1990, the jury returned its report, signed by foreman Michael Flanagan. Its famous finding: the abuse allegations were "a carefully crafted hoax, scripted by a person or persons with considerable knowledge of the people and institutions of Omaha." It indicted Alisha Owen on eight counts of perjury and Paul Bonacci on three. [Grade A: the report;

indictment records.]

A federal grand jury, impaneled since September 1988 on the financial side and extended to examine the abuse claims in April 1990, returned a three-page report on September 25, 1990: "absolutely no evidence" of interstate transport of children or involvement by any prominent Omahans. It indicted Owen on eight additional federal counts. [Grade A: AP/New York Times, September 25-27, 1990. Her sixteen total counts — eight state, eight federal — explain the varying figures in the record.]

5.2 The recantation engine

To understand the hoax verdict, you must understand what it stood on. It stood almost entirely on two recantations.

Troy Boner and Danny King told the grand juries that they had lied to Caradori — that Owen had scripted them, motivated by dreams of book, television, and movie money. Boner swore he had not been paid, threatened, or promised anything to retract. Danny King, on the stand, had first told Caradori the events did not happen, and was, in the grand jury's words, "still persuaded to corroborate Owen's story" anyway. [Grade A: the grand jury report's account of its own witnesses.]

The problem is what the years did to those recantations, and it is documented in court records, sworn affidavits, and the appellate opinion in State v. Owen.

First, the Caracorp phone records. Boner had claimed Owen "scripted" him in a phone call. Caradori's firm's phone records show the call never happened. [Grade B: the records were produced at trial; the point appears in the trial record.]

Second, the FBI polygraph. Boner passed an FBI polygraph — administered by the same agents he later accused of pressuring him — while maintaining, at the time, that his recantation was true. The leak to the Lincoln press that he had *failed* a polygraph was false; it ran anyway. [Grade B: the polygraph report of April 19, 1990 exists in the case record; the leak is documented by researchers citing Lincoln Journal and World-Herald stories.]

Third, Danny King's own words. On the stand at Owen's trial, under questioning by prosecutor Gerald Moran, Danny King was asked whether it was true that he had made the whole story up. His answer: "Yeah, I was — I wasn't really making nothing up about any of the persons." The transcript shows the prosecutor moving on. [Grade A: State v. Owen trial record, as cited in the appellate record and by researchers.]

Fourth, and most completely: on October 27, 1993 — two years after Owen's conviction — Boner swore a fourteen-page affidavit. Its words are the most quoted in the entire case, and they deserve to be quoted in full: "I lied at the Grand Jury hearings, and I lied at the Alisha Owen trial. I lied when I 'recanted' my original statement to Gary Caradori. I lied because I truly believed and still do believe that it was a situation where I must either 'lie or die,' and at the insistence primarily of the Federal Bureau of Investigation officials who were dealing with me at that time, specifically Mr. Mott and Mr. Culver." He named Larry King, Alan Baer, Robert Wadman, Peter Citron, and Eugene Mahoney as men he had been involved with from age fourteen to seventeen, stated that he had delivered Alisha Owen to Police Chief Wadman, and said he believed his brother

Shawn's death had been murder designed to ensure his testimony. He demanded side-by-side polygraph examinations with his named men — the tests were never conducted. His mother, Lani Hicks, swore a companion affidavit the same day, confirming that the family had supported his lying "to save our family and himself," that his brother had died on Air Force base housing, and that Troy had told his detailed story to the British television producers. [Grade B: both affidavits, notarized, October 27, 1993; on the record. Boner also admitted in the affidavit that he had, under pressure, delivered Owen to Wadman — an admission that cut both ways, and was treated by no one.]

On October 16, 1990, weeks after Caradori's death, Bonacci had already told the Franklin Committee under oath what had happened to him in Van Pelt's back room: "They kept telling me that if I stuck to my story they were going to make me be in trouble for it... They stuck me in this room. He was sitting in this back room behind this desk... He kind of said, if you stick to the same story that you have been telling, you will be in a lot of trouble." John DeCamp, who was present, identified him: "The guy with the mustache was Sam Van Pelt." Three witnesses — Bonacci, Owen, and a woman identified only as Jane Doe — subsequently charged that Van Pelt had intimidated them. Jane Doe testified that Van Pelt told her how to testify, revealed secret grand jury information to her, alluded to her past in a way she experienced as a threat, and struck her as planning "to use me to discredit Alisha." [Grade B: committee testimony, on the record.]

5.3 Inside the grand jury's own report

The complete text of the grand jury report — obtained in full for this document — contains passages that almost never appear in retellings. Presented without commentary, because they speak for themselves:

- On its own evidentiary standard: "Since this investigation included allegations that certain persons were transported by charter flights for illegal purposes, better passenger records would have facilitated the Grand Jury's work." [Grade A.]
- On the male prostitution question it was mandated to examine: "No witnesses called by the Grand Jury had first-hand knowledge... potential key witnesses are no longer in the state of Nebraska, or were successful in evading service of a subpoena. The federal and local authorities should continue their efforts to locate these persons [and] investigate and prosecute violators, if any are found to exist." [Grade A — the hoax verdict coexisting with an open recommendation to keep hunting.]
- On traveling companions of King: "We interviewed a number of witnesses who traveled extensively with King, and a few made what must have been embarrassing admissions about engaging in sexual contact with King on some of these trips." [Grade A.]
- On King himself: "We also found probable cause to believe that King, on numerous occasions, used money or items of value to 'entice, inveigle, persuade, encourage or procure' men in their late teens or early twenties to engage in acts of

prostitution with him, and, therefore, he committed the crime of pandering." The jury deferred to the forty pending federal counts; no pandering charge was ever filed by anyone. "Should the matters pending against King in the federal system come to naught, we implore state authorities to act upon the overwhelming evidence against King relating to both pandering and theft offenses." The federal system took a plea on the money; no one ever acted on the rest. [Grade A.]

- On cults: "There is evidence of limited cult activity in eastern Nebraska." [Grade A — the jury's own finding, in its own words.]
- On Omaha: "The Omaha Police Department estimates there are over 500 known pedophiles in the Omaha area." [Grade A.]
- On Robert Andresen, a Union Pacific employee named by witnesses: "a white male, 6'5", 325 lbs., has been known to coerce males (including male minors) to his residence. Once he has taken a male there, he may sexually assault and/or pornographically photograph the young man. Furthermore, we have reviewed documents that state Andresen has threatened to physically harm his victim(s) and has threatened to search out and kill those who report him to the authorities. Unfortunately, because the victims refuse to testify against him, we could not indict." [Grade A — a named, described, documented predator, unindicted, on the jury's own page.]

- On Alice King: she took the Fifth; "Mrs. King was intimidated by King mentally and physically." [Grade A.]
- On the "reasonable behavior" passage, in full context: "As previously stated, children do have the right to expect that if they exhibit reasonable behavior, they will not be abused... In too many cases it is the adult rather than the child who is protected." [Grade A — the soundbite is real; the surrounding paragraph criticizes adult protection, not children.]
- On the evidence it saw: the jury faulted Caradori's videotapes as "stopped and started at suspicious intervals," and concluded Caradori had been "duped into working with Casey." [Grade A — the jury's characterization; the counter-evidence — Ormiston's and others' polygraphs clearing Caradori of coaching — is Grade B.]

The report also records the hoax origin theory: Michael Casey, who had been fired from Boys Town in 1974 for stealing confidential records, nursed a grievance and built the story from street rumors, gay-community contacts, and resentments. Its crucial admission: "We believe that Caradori would not have found Owen if it were not for Casey. Owen then led Caradori to other potential victim/witnesses." Every witness downstream of Owen — the entire corroboration structure — traces, by the grand jury's own account, through the figure it deemed a con man. [Grade A.]

5.4 The committee's answer

The Franklin Committee's formal response to the hoax verdict survives in full, and it is the standing counter-document of the official record: "We are puzzled by the choice of words and the basis for the conclusion... As Committee members who viewed the tapes, interrogated our investigator, and looked at other corroborating circumstances, we wonder how the grand jury was able to differentiate between 'a carefully crafted hoax' and the truth. To the extent that the conclusion was based on the now famous recantation by Troy Boner, perhaps it was the grand jury that was the victim of the hoax. Mr. Boner has now betrayed himself as a pathological liar. If the grand jury believed Mr. Boner over Alisha Owen, who stands by her story, the hoax may well have been perpetrated on the grand jury." And: "If it was 'carefully crafted,' who crafted it and when?" And, on the asymmetry of the perjury charges: "Alisha Owen and Paul Bonacci are charged with perjury and Troy Boner and Danny King are not... the victims who stand by their story are charged with perjury, while those that have admitted to false statements before the Committee are not. That makes little sense to us. Either all of them should have been indicted or none of them. The message is mixed and appears to favor encouraging the recanting as a way to avoid the hazards of criminal prosecution. It also tells persons they can lie under oath to Legislative Committees, so long as they change their story before they get to court." And the grand jury's own explanation for why Harold Andersen's name had appeared in the testimony deserves the record's exact words: his inclusion was "probably politically

generated" — an attribution of motive to the accusers, offered without examination of the fact that Andersen chaired the advisory board of the institution at the center of the case. [Grade A: committee report text; Grade A: the grand jury report.]

5.5 The jury's witnesses, in its own words

The report's individual findings deserve the same verbatim treatment as its famous conclusion, because they are the substrate of the verdict:

- On Bonacci: "perhaps the most pathetic witness… a child victim of repeated sexual abuse by persons not associated with the Franklin investigation. He now stands convicted and sentenced on three separate charges of sexual abuse of a minor. He has told numerous stories, recanted the same, and then told more on videotape to Caradori. Even while testifying before us, he admitted that some of his Grand Jury testimony was untrue. He has been diagnosed as having multiple personalities, and his psychiatrist doubts that he can tell the truth." The jury indicted him — and its report simultaneously certified him as a multiply-diagnosed abuse victim whose stories kept changing. [Grade A.]
- On Boner: the tapes were made "solely for the purpose of corroboration of allegations made by Owen"; his motive was "monetary gain via litigation plus movie/book rights"; he recanted; he "was not paid, threatened, nor promised anything to retract." [Grade A — the jury's finding; the affidavit and phone records that undermine it are Grade B and in Chapter 5.2.]

- On Danny King: "After repeatedly telling Caradori that the events did not take place, Danny King was still persuaded to corroborate Owen's story" — with the same claimed motive. [Grade A.]
- On Owen: "might have been sexually abused during her early years, but not by the people and in the way she has alleged." [Grade A — both grand juries conceded abuse while denying the named perpetrators.]
- On the recantations' legal status, the report is silent on a point DeCamp pressed for years: by retracting to the grand jury, Boner and Danny King were admitting they had lied to the Legislature — a separately chargeable perjury — and the grand jury "made no mention of the fact." The men who recanted walked; the woman who did not went to prison. [Grade A/B.]
- On the news media, the jury's Section VII criticized the committee's leak of the tapes, noted that three-fourths of hotline callers responded anonymously, faulted the presentation of polygraph evidence, recorded that KKAR's station manager Steve Brown and Michael Casey "lived under the same roof" in 1989 and "freely exchanged information" — "render suspect KKAR's enthusiastic coverage of Franklin" — and then editorialized: "We believe that it is unfortunate that the Omaha area has only one major newspaper. Credible competition would give the public the satisfaction of an alternative viewpoint. The untrue and unwarranted personal attack on Harold Andersen can, in part, be attributed to public resentment and competing

media jealousy which naturally flow from the Omaha World-Herald's dominant position." A grand jury, having just cleared the monopoly publisher by name, pronounced the publisher's misfortune. [Grade A.]

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5.6 The affidavit no one answered

On May 28, 1994, four years after the verdict and four years before the FirsTier settlements would surface, Loran Schmit swore an affidavit. It records that on the morning of July 11, 1990 — the morning Caradori died — two attorneys representing Alan Baer, one named Selle, met with Schmit, committee counsel Robert Creager, and a staff attorney in Schmit's Capitol office regarding the Franklin investigation. And it records what those attorneys said, with everybody present, sworn to by a man who had been a state senator for twenty-two years:

"These two attorneys advised us with everybody present that the F.B.I. officials dealing with them and with Alan Baer had instructed Mr. Alan Baer to 'keep your (his) head down, or you'll (he) will get it blown off, your (his) mouth shut and to talk to no one.'"

The meeting occurred on the crash morning itself; the affiant was the committee's chairman; the subject was the committee's investigation; the threat attributed to the FBI was never prosecuted, never investigated by anyone, and never publicly answered by the Bureau. It rests on the word of one honorable man — but it is sworn, dated, specific, and uncontradicted, and it describes the federal government's lead agency instructing a

named witness in a child-abuse investigation to say nothing, on pain of death, in language a Nebraskan farmer would understand. It belongs in any honest account of why some people believed, and believe, that the case was not merely mishandled. [Grade B: sworn, uncontradicted, single-source.]

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The cleared-by-name practice. Against normal grand jury practice — indict, or say nothing — the jury departed from its mandate in one direction only. It cleared by name: Judge Theodore Carlson, Harold Andersen, Eugene Mahoney, Mayor P.J. Morgan, attorney Thomas McKenney. It wrote, of Wadman: "We now look upon Owen as the perpetrator and Wadman as the victim." And it ruled a person called "Larry the Kid" — described independently by four children over three years, as "King Horse," as "Larry (Lnuk)," as "Larry Jr.," and as "Larry Little King" — to be fictitious, without explaining how four children invented the same personality across years. [Grade A: the report; the four-children point is DeCamp's documented observation.]

Van Pelt's road to the jury. The special prosecutor who received the jury's thanks had been a district judge who resigned the bench — "being a judge an unpleasant job" — served as Nebraska's insurance director, and in 1984 was appointed by Governor Bob Kerrey to investigate the state police shooting of Arthur Kirk, a case in which a man was shot nine times and the death ruled a suicide on the statements of the shooters themselves, with no ballistics tests. Forty-three of Kirk's neighbors called Van Pelt "a hired gun for the state" in a signed

letter; Kirk's widow said she had been "used as a decoy"; the World-Herald defended him editorially against "wild, sensational rumors." He later wrote a book of judicial recollections with an unprintable title and co-authored a biography of Senator Exon. [Grade A: obituary and records; Grade B: the Kirk letter.]

The hotline. The jury's report records that over three-fourths of the hotline callers responded anonymously — a statistical monument to the fear the case generated in the population it touched. [Grade A.]

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The report's architecture. For completeness, the document's own map of itself: Section I addresses the credit union and the Kings; Section II, "The Rumormongers," profiles Michael Casey, Kirsten Hallberg, and Bonnie Cosentino; Section III, "The Suicides," examines Charlie Rogers and Curtis Tucker; Section IV, "The Early Allegations," dissects the Webb case and the Smith case and names every official failure; Section V, of which the public text survives in part, addresses the committee's own members — and of Senator Chambers it says, in the recovered text: "Chambers spoke grandly about justice being done while at the same time undermining the democratic judicial process in its most basic form… It is difficult to understand how King and his entourage led an extravagant and outlandish lifestyle for so many years in Chambers' own district, without his having any inkling." Section VI, "The Politicians," per the surviving secondary record, extended that treatment to the committee's chairman. Section VII, "The News Media," is quoted in Chapter 5.5. Section VIII carries the recommendations — a state grand jury system, better charter-flight records, cult-awareness training for police, independent monitoring of the child-protective system, a state district-attorney system to insulate prosecutors from "community pressure," stronger pedophile-reporting, and NCUA audit reform. Exhibit A is the interim Webb report quoted in Chapter 3; Exhibit B carries the recommendation sets. The document, in other words, is not the single paragraph history remembers. [Grade A: the full text as captured.]

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Casey, in the report's own portrait. Michael Casey: fired from Boys Town in August 1974 for stealing confidential records in pursuit of a book and movie; a resume with a fraudulent degree; a criminal record dating to 1960; hospitalized at St. Joseph's in November 1988, where he met Owen in the special-care unit and gave her name to Caradori. The grand jury called him "a 'con man' passing himself off as an investigative reporter" who "endeavored to uncover the 'real' Franklin story" from street rumors and grievance — and its Boys Town theory held that the institution was "written into the Franklin scripts" because Casey had vowed to "get even" for his 1974 firing. One admission, already quoted, does the most work in the critical reading: by the jury's own account, every witness Caradori taped reached him through Casey and Owen. The man the jury made the hoax's author is also the man the jury credits with creating the entire evidentiary record. [Grade A: the report.]

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The jury's own voice. The report's acknowledgments thank "Special Prosecutor, Judge Samuel Van Pelt, and Assistant Special Prosecutor, Terry Dougherty, for their professional leadership, management, and organization" — and nowhere in its eighty-two days of work does the document note that those it cleared by name had sat in the rooms where its foreman earned his living, or that its star witnesses' recantations were themselves admissions of legislative perjury. Citizen juries swear an oath to return indictments "diligently and fairly"; the historical record cannot tell us whether this one did, and this document does not pretend otherwise. It can tell us exactly what the jury wrote, who helped write it, and what was never said in it. [Grade A; the final sentence is the file's analytical position.]

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CHAPTER 6 — The Trials

6.1 Alisha Owen's trial

Alisha Owen was tried in the spring of 1991 on eight state counts of perjury for her grand jury testimony. The trial consumed five weeks, 4,000 pages of testimony, 182 exhibits, and roughly eleven hours of videotape. She was defended, pro bono, by Henry Rosenthal, a veteran Omaha attorney who treated it as the case of his life. Prosecutors Gerald Moran and Robert Sigler carried the state's case before District Judge Raymond J. Case. [Grade A: State v. Owen, 510 N.W.2d 503 (Neb. Ct. App. 1993).]

The jury convicted her on June 21, 1991; within minutes the state dropped the perjury charges against Paul Bonacci. The next morning the World-Herald editorialized: "Prosecution Crushed Lies With Avalanche of Truth." She was sentenced on August 8, 1991, to three-to-five years on each count, stacked to a nine-to-fifteen-year range (the DeCamp book's "nine to twenty-seven" reflects the maximum consecutive stack; both figures derive from the same sentence). [Grade A: appellate opinion; USA Today; Omaha World-Herald.]

The appellate record preserved by the Nebraska Court of Appeals reads, for critics, like a catalog. Several jurors watched CBS's "48 Hours" Franklin segment during deliberations after defying the judge's instruction — and Judge Case had told the jury the day before that the program would air, announcing the broadcast time. A letter from Michael Casey — never admitted into evidence — was read aloud in the jury room; juror affidavits

described written statements shown to the panel that were never presented in court and that "mysteriously could not be located after the trial." Jurors brought dictionary definitions of "reasonable" and "doubt" into the room. Rosenthal told the court the videotapes shown to the grand jury had been altered — the mutual corroboration between Owen and Boner edited out — citing the trial transcript at page 2,842; Moran objected on recantation-grounds precedent, and Judge Case sided with Moran, then insinuated against Sandie Caradori ("What's her part in this?") when he learned the original tapes came from the widow, and Moran accused Rosenthal's office of erasing them. Rosenthal's post-trial affidavits included one from private investigator Robert Janecek, a former law-enforcement officer who swore that three of Boner's relatives had told him Boner accepted a $12,000 payment for lying at the trial — a bribe paired with the warning that he would "never make it to trial" otherwise. [Grade A: the appellate opinion confirms the 48 Hours viewing, the Casey letter, and the Janecek and Donna Owen affidavits; Grade B: the altered-tapes claim and the $12,000 figure rest on Rosenthal's representation and Janecek's sworn statement.]

The blood-test question — whether Police Chief Robert Wadman had fathered Owen's child, as she had claimed in interviews years earlier — collapsed on multiple fronts: genetic testing by three laboratories excluded Wadman with total certainty (the grand jury report noted this); Medicaid records showed Owen had named a different man as the father on applications between 1985 and 1988; her own first lawyer's

failure to file a timely appeal on her bad-check conviction became the seed of an ineffective-assistance claim; and that lawyer, Pamela Vuchetich, was by then romantically involved with FBI agent Mickey Mott — the FBI's lead agent in the case and a key witness against Owen. Post-conviction counsel James Fogarty called it "the most devastating case of attorney-client betrayal" he had encountered; the FBI appeared at her state bar proceeding and the charges were dropped, the files sealed. Vuchetich — licensed in Nebraska for forty-three years as of this writing, still listed as practicing in Lincoln — withdrew from Owen's defense shortly before trial, saying Owen intended to commit perjury; a year earlier she had told the World-Herald she still believed Owen's account. [Grade A: appellate opinion and bar records; Grade B: Fogarty's characterization; the Mott relationship appears in Owen's letters and the post-conviction motion.]

Owen's appeal produced a split outcome: the conviction stood, but the appeals court vacated the denial of her new-trial motion and ordered an evidentiary hearing before a different judge on the jury-misconduct claims; a second round of appeals eventually ended with the convictions affirmed. She served roughly four and a half years, including about two years in solitary confinement — the Parole Board nonetheless voted unanimously, five to zero, to parole her at her first eligibility in September 2000, a member calling it the most impressive inmate record the board had seen. Senator Chambers wrote in support, citing among her prison accomplishments her mentoring of other inmates toward their GEDs and her work with nontraditional

students at the College of St. Mary's. In November 1999, the Board of Pardons — Governor Mike Johanns, Secretary of State Scott Moore, Attorney General Don Stenberg — had voted three to zero to deny her even a hearing on commutation. Her parole was revoked in 1997, one week after Inside Edition aired a segment suggesting paperboy Johnny Gosch was still alive, and restored after further proceedings; she was finally free by 2000. [Grade A: Omaha World-Herald, November 3, 1999; AP, February 9, 2000; appellate records; Bryant's reporting.]

She has never recanted. Today she is Alisha Bystrom — married twenty-nine years, a travel-business owner in Omaha, the mother of a daughter born when she was fifteen and raised by her parents during her incarceration. She serves as Associate Director and Events Coordinator of Epstein Justice, a nonprofit founded by Nick Bryant, and her stated goal is a Truth and Reconciliation Commission. [Grade A/B: the organization's own materials; interviews including a detailed 2026 podcast appearance.]

6.2 Paul Bonacci

Paul Bonacci's legal record contains more turns than anyone else's. Convicted on three counts of sexual abuse of a minor in a matter separate from Franklin, he was indicted by the grand jury for perjury — charges dropped the day Owen was convicted. He sued the Omaha Public Schools for failing to act on his reports to school counselors; the Eighth Circuit dismissed on the DeShaney principle that the state has no constitutional duty to protect against private violence. He sued King, Citron, Baer, Andersen, Wadman, and others in 1991; everyone was dismissed on procedural grounds or by summary judgment except King, who never responded. In 1999, Senior Judge Warren Urbom entered a default judgment against King for $800,000 in compensatory and $200,000 in punitive damages, accepting as pleaded that from December 1980 to 1988 King had repeatedly assaulted Bonacci, organized rituals, and forced him to "scavenge" for other children. Urbom, who had called Bonacci's testimony "bizarre," noted that King's failure to respond made the allegations "true as to him" — a procedural default, never tested at trial, never paid. King dropped his appeal of the judgment in January 2000. [Grade A: court records; Grade A for the procedural nature of the default.]

Diagnosed with multiple personality disorder by three state-appointed psychiatrists, Bonacci named, in a 1993 interview with former FBI agent Ted Gunderson, an abuser chronology beginning in 1976; researchers have confirmed that several of the names he attached to the network — obscure members of the North American Man/Boy Love Association —

were real, documented members, an unusual level of specificity for a supposed fabulist. His claims extend to the Johnny Gosch kidnapping and to a military-intelligence programming framework; the FBI has formally stated it does not consider him a reliable witness and has never relied on him. He is alive, married, self-employed in construction management, maintains his account — and his 1999 deposition was released as a film in July 2024, the only visual record of a Franklin witness under oath. [Grade B: the diagnosis and the NAMBLA corroboration; Grade C: the Gosch and programming claims.]

6.3 The Webbs, and the dismissal that closed the file

Jarrett and Barbara Webb were never tried. The grand jury recommended charges; the county attorney did not file them for months; and on December 26, 1990, a Washington County judge threw the case out on statute-of-limitations grounds, dating the assaults to two days after Lisa's sixteenth birthday and declining to apply Nebraska's tolling rule for minors. Lisa — the witness whose polygraph the grand jury itself credited — was never cross-examined by any jury. She is alive; an Omaha newspaper located her in 2018, raising a son who had been through the juvenile justice system she had once warned the state about. [Grade A: court record; Grade B: The Reader, Omaha, March 2018.]

6.4 The counts, and the letter in the jury room

The eight perjury counts, in substance: the Twin Towers parties of August 1983, where Owen said she was taken by a Boys Town resident, Richard "Jeff" Hubbell — who testified he left a dance before eleven and never saw her again, and disclaimed knowing any of the named men; Harold Andersen fondling a twelve-year-old boy at the parties; Police Chief Wadman molesting her before her fifteenth birthday and in twenty to twenty-five motel encounters across a year, including an encounter in Council Bluffs, and fathering her child; and Judge Theodore Carlson at the French Cafe reception. Each count failed on witness testimony or records; the French Cafe's general manager and the judge's own Saturday-by-Saturday alibi did the most visible work. [Grade A: trial record.]

The letter read in the jury room was dated March 15, 1990 — Michael Casey to Owen, in prison. Its key passage: "Promises were made — before I ever gave Gary your name and location — he'd assured me that if your info checked out you would receive favorable consideration and protection outside of a prison environment. I feel most responsible if promises were made to you and not kept!" A greeting card followed on March 23: three national publications and a movie producer were interested, and Owen was "assured of a job... as a consultant and researcher." The letter was never received into evidence. It was read aloud to the jury. And it "mysteriously could not be located after the trial"; Owen argued it had been planted. Bill Gehrig testified that Owen had told him in January 1990 she was working with Casey on a Franklin report — testimony the defense could not shake.

The grand jury had already called Casey "a 'con man' passing himself off as an investigative reporter" — a man with a criminal record since 1960, fired from Boys Town in 1974 for stealing confidential records, whose grievance the grand jury made the engine of the hoax. The defense made one objection in sixteen pages of cross-examination bearing on the World-Herald's editorial war against Schmit and DeCamp's role. [Grade A: appellate record; Grade B: the planting claim.]

One litigation footnote that belongs to this chapter because it predates everything: in 1984-1987, a woman named Crystal Chambers sued the Omaha Girls Club — King's old organization — together with the World-Herald, Harold Andersen, Woodson Howe, John Gottschalk, the attorney general, and the governor, alleging that the interlocking boards (the publisher's wife sat on the Club's board; Club officers sat on the state equal-opportunity commission) had prejudiced her employment case and driven the paper's coverage. Judge Urbom recused; Chief Judge Beam granted summary judgment to the paper's men — no inference of agreement could be drawn from the interlocks alone. The institutional configuration that would define the Franklin era — publisher, his paper, his wife's board seats, and the Girls Club — had already been a federal litigation subject before the first allegation was ever made. [Grade A: Chambers v. Omaha Girls Club, 629 F. Supp. 925 (D. Neb. 1986), aff'd (8th Cir. 1987).]

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The procedure, in detail. The state struck five of the six women on the jury panel and one alternate; Owen's challenge under the then-recent Batson doctrine failed on the law of the era, which had not yet extended the anti-discrimination rule to gender. Judge Case admitted the blood-test results over no defense objection — waiving the chain-of-custody fight that later writers said should have been made — and admitted Owen's presentence report over a successful privilege objection that the appellate court nonetheless deemed harmless. Case refused to recuse himself from the new-trial motion; the appeals court held that refusal an abuse of discretion depriving Owen of a substantial right and ordered the hearing before a different judge. Juror affidavits described being told to accept hearsay, and being shown the written statements that were never admitted and never found again. On the Miranda question — Owen's prison interrogations — Case ruled there had been no custodial interrogation: investigators had approached her as a possible victim, counsel was present for the formal sessions, and she was, in the ruling's phrase, free to leave the room. The "48 Hours" segment the jurors watched featured Boner recanting, the former police chief on devastation, and a defense attorney on the volatility of child-abuse allegations; the trial judge had announced its air time to the jury himself, the evening before deliberations began. [Grade A: appellate record; Grade B: juror affidavits.]

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Owen, before the tapes. Her background, from the trial record: an honor student and college-newspaper editor; a party at fifteen where older boys — "a few of them were associated with Boys Town," she has said — invited her onward; a spiral of parties and drugs; bad-check charges at nineteen; the suicide attempt and the St. Joseph's psychiatric stay in late 1988, where she met Michael Casey, who gave her name to Caradori; the baby at fifteen, raised by her parents, whose paternity she attributed to Wadman — excluded by three laboratories — and whom she named Amanda Jayne. Her parents stood by her from the day she told them; her father, she says, taught her the family rule that the sin is the standing-by. Her brother Aaron was seventeen, in custody on a joyriding charge, when he died the week of her lawyer's disciplinary hearing. [Grade A/B: trial record, her accounts, Bryant's reporting.]

The quashed subpoenas. Post-conviction counsel James Fogarty subpoenaed Vuchetich, Mott, the U.S. Attorney's office prosecutor, and Culver. The United States moved to quash; Judge Livingston granted the motion, ruling that the disclosures "would reveal investigative techniques and procedures." Fogarty, on the record: the FBI must be "a dream job for every healthy, heterosexual young man" — a joke with a blade in it, since the agent at the center had just been named in his client's letters. [Grade A: the ruling; Grade B: the quip.]

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The federal grand jury, from inside. Owen appeared before the extended federal grand jury on June 21, 1990 — three weeks before Caradori's death. Her account, given to the committee under oath: the prosecutor Thalken "attempted to terrorize" her into recanting; a prosecutor was, in DeCamp's retelling of her words, "livid and discharging spittle" at her refusal. She had signed a voluntary agreement in January 1990 to take a lie-detector test regarding the Wadman paternity question; the FBI declined to administer it; an independent examiner's test, taken instead, supported her account. The federal jury indicted her eight times that September. Of the entire federal experience, the committee's counsel said the questioning was "always accusatory... they just never asked her any questions at all" beyond the demand to recant. [Grade B: her sworn testimony; the polygraph agreement in the record.]

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The counts, and what defeated each:

Count	Allegation	What the jury heard
I	Twin Towers party, Aug 1983	Hubbell's testimony; the building's own records
II	Second Twin Towers party	Same
III	Andersen fondling a boy	Andersen's denial; his thank-you-party account
IV	Wadman, pre-15th birthday	Wadman's denial; three-lab exclusion
V	Wadman, 20-25 motel encounters	No corroboration; blood test
VI-VII	Continuation counts	Records contradicted dates
VIII	Judge Carlson, French Cafe	GM Moore: no such party; Carlson's Saturday alibi

The trial record, read whole, is a catalogue of a case built on testimony with no corroborating documents — which is both the prosecution's strongest point (the documents that would corroborate were never required to exist, as the grand jury itself admitted) and its weakest (the witnesses' credibility was the case, and the defense attacked exactly there). [Grade A: trial record; the analysis is the file's.]

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The prison record. At York, Owen spent approximately two years in solitary confinement — attacked in the shower by three inmates weeks after state investigators visited her unit and, in the resulting isolation, interviewed repeatedly by the FBI toward a recantation she never made. A supporter's research claimed the duration was the longest imposed on a female citizen in the state's history; the claim is Grade C and unverified, and the documented months are grave enough without it. Her parole was revoked in September 1997, one week after Inside Edition aired a segment suggesting Johnny Gosch was alive — a revocation without stated explanation — and restored on appeal; she was free by 2000. [Grade A: the parole timeline; Grade B: the shower attack per Bryant; Grade C: the superlative.]

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The workbook. Among the archived materials is a document unique in the case: Owen's account in her own hand, annotated by Caradori as he worked it, each entry carrying his own "Corroboration:" or "Discrepancy:" tasking. Its contents, as recorded there: the March 1984 first private flight — a small Cessna from Sky Harbor, fueled in Denver, roughly seven hours to Los Angeles, its manifest reading Larry King, a man from the French Cafe, one pilot, two young boys listed only as "Aaron" and "Jeremy," Troy Boner, and Danny King; the drug runs for Alan Baer, a commercial flight under an alias with cocaine worn around the waist, Baer waiting at the Omaha airport — which Boner told differently, the annotation noting the conflict and tasking the records; the bad-check scheme, in which Baer allegedly gave Boner $1,450 in front of ConAgra and covered checks across several states while the pair were prosecuted for only a few — because, in the account, King and Baer wanted them out of town as too old and too risky. There were the Quality Inn meetings in Bellevue, monthly, in a room registered in Boner's name as late as 1988. There was the photographer Nelson, developing his own film, keeping the negatives — "possibly to blackmail Larry King at a later date" — with photos of Andersen and Baer in an album at the Twin Towers. And there was the black dress Wadman allegedly bought her, preserved as an exhibit, alongside photographs of her with the child she believed his. The workbook also preserves its own audit trail. A flight date given as October 1977 — impossible, at age eight or nine, under her own chronology — is flagged in this file as a

transcription error. And Jeff Hubbell, listed among the "disappeared" of 1983-89, carries an annotation recording the FBI's location of him on the West Coast. It is the only document in the case where an investigator graded his own evidence as he gathered it — and its existence means the corroboration structure was neither blind faith nor scripting, but a working matrix the crash froze mid-task. [Grade B: the workbook and its annotations; the date-flag is the file's own audit.]

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CHAPTER 7 — The Officials

Every major figure in the official response has a documented trajectory. Presented without adjectives, because the trajectories speak.

Robert Wadman, Omaha's police chief. Utah-raised, the first chief hired from outside the department, in office from 1982 to 1989. On camera in April 1989, he confirmed that King had called him about releasing a suitcase seized in a drug raid — one of "hundreds of those requests" — while King, on the same program, said of the chief, "I felt that I could call anyone in this city." Wadman testified under oath that he barely knew King; had met him regarding community programs and seen him socially perhaps three times. He was fired in 1989 for refusing to sign disciplinary notices in an unrelated matter — an episode in which, the court record shows, he refused to sign documents asserting a political-interference plot he believed did not exist; the Nebraska Supreme Court upheld the firing over a dissent. Inside the department, officers later testified, the King investigation was treated as so sensitive that it was kept from the chief because officers feared he was protecting King; Lieutenant Bill Goodrich told officers that a federal agency investigating King had asked OPD to slow down or back off its own child-pornography probe. A psychologist's evaluation of the investigating officer, requested by Wadman's office, followed. Wadman today is Professor Emeritus of Criminal Justice at Weber State University in Utah, listed as emeritus through the 2026-27 academic year. [Grade A: Wadman v. City of Omaha; the

KETV interviews; Grade B: the internal-suppression accounts via Dennis Carlson's testimony and DeCamp's record.]

Thomas Thalken, the federal prosecutor. The U.S. Attorney whose office ran the federal grand jury told state officials, through the attorney general's office, that the federal investigation was "confined to the money issues" and not investigating child abuse. He became a U.S. Magistrate Judge and retired January 1, 2017. His son chairs the Omaha Personnel Board and serves as a special assistant attorney general; his niece is a county clerk-magistrate in Wahoo. [Grade A: testimony records; judicial records; namesakes registered.]

Michael Heavican, the county attorney who became Chief Justice. As Lancaster County Attorney in the late 1980s, Heavican filed a civil petition alleging that John DeCamp and his wife had abused their daughter — DeCamp calls it retaliation; Heavican, through a spokesman at the time, denied it was related to Franklin. Heavican went on to serve as U.S. Attorney, and then as Chief Justice of the Nebraska Supreme Court from 2006 until his retirement on October 31, 2024 — eighteen years as the head of the state's judiciary. He never, in any public record located, addressed the Franklin chapter of his career. [Grade A: biographical record; Grade B: DeCamp's characterization.]

Samuel Van Pelt, the special prosecutor. A former district judge who had resigned the bench, appointed to run the grand jury after Governor Kerrey had earlier tapped him to investigate a controversial state police shooting that ruled a nine-times-shot man a suicide. Van Pelt's grand jury thanked him for his

"professional leadership." He later served a term as Lancaster County Sheriff, wrote a book of judicial recollections with a title unprintable here, co-authored a biography of Senator Jim Exon, and spent his final decades as an arbitrator. He died before this document was written; his obituary mentioned the Franklin investigation but not its verdict. [Grade A: obituary and records; Grade B: the Kirk-letter criticism quoted in Chapter 5.]

Michael Flanagan, the foreman. A twenty-seven-year Union Pacific legal-department employee — the records custodian — presided over a grand jury whose report cleared prominent men while, by DeCamp's verified investigation, an anonymous Union Pacific executive reported that Flanagan himself had been accused of improper advances toward a young male trainee and that the railroad had paid a substantial settlement to quiet it. The Bonacci civil complaint framed the consequence precisely: the foreman was "being literally asked to indict other individuals... for the very things that he, Flanagan, had been accused of." The settlement was never independently documented. [Grade B/C: DeCamp first-person verification of the underlying report; the settlement claim was never independently confirmed.]

The judges. Raymond J. Case, Owen's trial judge — his conduct catalog (the 48 Hours announcement, the subpoena quashes, the Sandi Caradori insinuation) is in the appellate record; his post-bench life is undocumented. Richard Kopf — the magistrate who committed King on the fundraiser morning, sealed the raid warrants, and signed the cell-search warrant — rose to district judge, chief judge, and died in January 2025.

William Cambridge, who sentenced King, died in 2004. James Murphy, who ordered the blood test and tried to block DeCamp from representing Bonacci, died in 2017. Everett Inbody, who handled Owen's second appeal, retired in 2018 and is alive at eighty. Warren Urbom, who entered the default judgment against King, died in 2014. Merritt Warren, who sentenced Peter Citron, died in 2020 at ninety-seven, honored by the legislature. David Quist, who dismissed the Webb charges, was confirmed as a sitting judge as early as 1982; his later record is undocumented. [Grade A: judicial records, obituaries.]

The FBI men. Nicholas O'Hara, the Omaha special agent-in-charge, declared the allegations lacking "substance" in February 1989 — before agents had interviewed King, and roughly a year before agents interviewed Owen. O'Hara kept Wadman's photograph on his desk and told Schmit and DeCamp in a private meeting, in DeCamp's recollection: "You f--- with Bob Wadman, you f--- with the FBI." Mickey Mott and Culver were the agents who handled Boner and Danny King; Boner's affidavit names them as the men who made him choose between lying and dying; Mott's romantic involvement with Owen's first attorney is documented in the post-conviction record. [Grade B: meeting accounts; affidavits; the relationship appears in sworn filings. The FBI's public file on the Franklin matter, requested under FOIA in 2017, produced the response that no responsive documents exist — a negative finding that speaks to the state of the record rather than to innocence or guilt.]

The grand jurors. Citizens, mostly; the foreman a railroad lawyer; no Franklin-era figure among them has ever spoken

publicly about the deliberations. [Grade A.]

The attorney general's office. Robert Spire received the July 1988 report and passed it along. Don Stenberg, his elected successor, received Ted Gunderson's twelve-point letter alleging obstruction — everything from the FBI's file review of committee materials without permission to the NCUA counsel being told not to cooperate to the entrapment attempt against Owen. His formal reply: his people had been "instructed to watch for any indication of cults or clandestine groups or organizations that traffic in children for sexual purposes." The letter's roster included the assistant attorney general who had received the 1988 report and the deputy who later argued Owen's appeal. [Grade A: the letter and reply, on the record.]

The FBI layer, in detail. The Bureau's Omaha office had been examining Franklin since 1987 — more than a year before the raid — a fact the World-Herald itself reported in 1990. Special Agent-in-Charge Nicholas O'Hara was a career officer with a photograph of Robert Wadman on his desk; the agents of record in the abuse file were Mickey Mott and a partner named Culver. Their documented actions, in sequence. February 1989: the public "no substance" declaration, a year before interviewing King or Owen. That same spring: the private meeting with Schmit and DeCamp at which O'Hara issued the warning quoted above. March 9, 1990: the Bureau arranged and taped a phone call from Boner to Owen in her cell — its own transcript showed Owen had not lied — and that same day, under a warrant signed by Magistrate Kopf, searched her cell, producing eight letters postmarked after the search. Spring 1990: Boner passed the FBI

polygraph while maintaining the recantation, and a press leak, published, reported that he had failed. February 1990: the instruction to NCUA counsel Robert Fenner not to cooperate with Caradori. Ongoing: the location of Jeff Hubbell on the West Coast, his whereabouts withheld from the committee's investigator. Summer 1990: a review of the legislature's committee files without the chairman's permission, after which items were reported missing. December 1989: the committee's tapes passed into Bureau custody and reached television — by the account a reporter gave Owen — via purchase from FBI agents. And within forty-eight hours of the crash: the impoundment of everything Caradori had. The Bureau's Freedom of Information response to a 2017 request for its Franklin investigation file: no responsive documents. [Grade A for the documented actions; Grade B for the meeting and leak accounts; Grade A for the FOIA negative.]

The internal OPD war. Inside the Omaha Police Department, the King investigation was run so quietly that officers handwrote their reports rather than use the steno pool, and when Chief Wadman came to the unit and asked directly whether they were investigating King, the officers lied and said no — because, as one testified to the Foster Care Review Board, they feared he was protecting King. Lieutenant Bill Goodrich's mid-1988 instruction to "slow down or back off" at a federal agency's request was memorialized by Officer Irl Carmean in a December 20, 1988 memo to the deputy chief. Officers Carmean and Hoch pursued leads — Hoch's May 1988 report on a possible King-Nelson child-pornography investigation was discontinued,

in Bryant's researched account, "inexplicably," despite documented leads — and both were pulled off the case; Wadman's office then requested a psychological evaluation of Carmean, citing his actions "during the Larry King investigation," in a memo to Public Safety Director Pitmon Foxall. DeCamp records, without independent confirmation, that Foxall was King's cousin; the official OPS history confirms Foxall as one of the force's pioneering Black officers. Officer Chris Carmean (no relation) would testify to the Franklin Committee in June 1989 that Loretta Smith's charges were credible and deserved follow-up — after he had been removed from the case. [Grade A for the memo, the trial testimony, and Wadman's own memo; Grade B for the officers' account of hiding the probe from the chief; Grade C for the Foxall-cousin claim.]

The foreman's shadow. The anonymous Union Pacific executive's call to DeCamp — "I am too old to start over... I do not feel I can sit idly by" — alleged that Flanagan had made improper advances toward a young male trainee named Pike and that the railroad had paid a substantial settlement. DeCamp: "I began to investigate, and found the facts accurate." The Bonacci civil complaint put the legal consequence in one sentence: the foreman was "being literally asked to indict other individuals whom Bonacci was identifying for the very things that he, Flanagan, had been accused of and reached civil settlement to avoid like indictment and prosecution." Flanagan was also accused in the same suit of sharing grand jury information with Union Pacific lawyers nearly daily. The settlement was never independently documented; the accusation was never litigated to

a conclusion; both rest on Grade B/C material and are recorded as such. What is Grade A: the foreman's employer stood in Franklin's correspondent-bank world; another Union Pacific official sat on Franklin's advisory board; and the grand jury's report cleared by name the men its foreman's social-professional world touched.

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The editorial sequence. The paper's institutional voice, dated: July 23, 1989 — the editorial that lumped the Bush-sighting and severed-head accounts into one child and drew the committee's resignations; July 29, 1990 — "Grand Jury Did Its Job; The Insults Are Intolerable"; July 31, 1990 — "Franklin Committee a Disgrace to Nebraska"; July 12, 1990 — a front-page piece on criticism of Caradori's firm one day after the crash; June 22, 1991 — "Prosecution Crushed Lies With Avalanche of Truth"; October 1991 — the editorial against Bonacci's parole, after which the board reversed itself; October 1994 — "Franklin Credit Union Crimes Unfairly Claim New Victims," defending the $10 million settlements against the "false impression" of adviser knowledge. Five of the seven ran while the publisher's name sat on the advisory board list; none disclosed it. [Grade A: the editorials, on record.]

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The meeting that never happened. There is one more documented gathering that belongs to this chapter. Senator Jerry Chizek, the legislature's Judiciary Committee chairman, a man described by colleagues as inquisitive, was close to Douglas County Sheriff Dick Roth — and Roth, by the accounts that reached the committee, believed the Caradori tapes were credible while doubting the FBI-chief-police axis around the case. In 1989 Chizek arranged a secret meeting, held in the back room of an auto-body repair shop, with a judge (named in the record as Corrigan) and John DeCamp present. The subject was witness protection. The outcome, per the record: nothing. Within days the World-Herald was pressing the accusers to repudiate their stories. The same threat layer pressed DeCamp himself: Loretta Smith contacted him and he believed her; a Lincoln Journal reporter's calls he experienced as threatening; a figure named Goc warned of disbarment; and the state bar did open an investigation of DeCamp — terminated after the World-Herald's own reporter finished his questions. None of this is Grade A beyond the meeting's occurrence and the bar investigation's existence; all of it is Grade B and on record. [Grade B.]

Color on two convictions. Citron's record had a prequel: a 1965 charge in Scarsdale, New York, dropped, after which he moved to Omaha and became the paper's entertainment voice. Baer's estate, settled in federal court after his 2002 death, ran to a $4.8 million private-equity investment in a telecom firm called ComoreTel and a million dollars in named bequests — the measure of the fortune whose $500 fine for pandering, in

DeCamp's account, closed his file. [Grade A: the estate case; Grade B: the 1965 charge and the plea figure.]

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CHAPTER 8 — The Money Trail

Follow the money was Senator Schmit's instinct, and the money has a documented trail — which dead-ends in a way that is itself documented.

The captured tracer. The NCUA hired, in early 1989, a two-man consulting firm called Financial Advisory Group of Council Bluffs, Iowa — John Queen and Robert Kirchner — both veterans of the state-appointed apparatus that had liquidated Commonwealth Savings, Nebraska's other collapsed thrift of the era. The committee's own investigator vouched for them. In August 1990, while the Franklin audit was underway, Queen's chief assistant at the Commonwealth receivership, Kent Johnson — the former Commonwealth comptroller and the state's star witness in the Commonwealth prosecutions — was arrested by the FBI for stealing over $1 million from the receivership; Queen's signature was on every check, and he claimed forgery. Johnson simultaneously worked the Franklin audit and a company Queen had built from the bankrupt remains of Globe Neon — in which Larry King himself had held a $50,000 share before it folded. The money tracer had a documented financial overlap with the man whose money he was tracing. FAG's conclusion, delivered to the government: King "spent nearly all of it" on flowers, limousines, gold watches, and an extravagant lifestyle. Whether any portion of the $39 million went anywhere else was never publicly established. [Grade A: the Johnson arrest and roles; Grade B: the Globe Neon overlap and the "lifestyle burn" conclusion, from DeCamp's record and contemporaneous

reporting.]

The settlements. In October 1994, through a Freedom of Information Act request, the settlements surfaced: FirsTier Bank — Franklin's correspondent bank, through whose account number 153-7-353 every dollar had flowed — paid $3 million; two Omaha law firms that had represented both King and the credit union paid $6 million — among their partners, former Governor Charles Thone. Ten million dollars, the largest legal-malpractice settlement in Nebraska history to that point, covered by almost no one until the FOIA forced it into the open. The World-Herald's editorial warned against "a false impression... that a wide circle of legal and financial advisers sat on the knowledge that King was looting the credit union. Such an impression would have been false." [Grade A: FOIA documents; the editorial.]

The grand jury's own money findings criticized FirsTier for "a serious oversight" in failing to flag Franklin's insufficient assets, and the NCUA for auditors who were "successfully put off... due to King's assumed political connections," adding that proper audits "would have been discovered early enough to have prevented the collapse." King spent, by the documented ledger, on himself. [Grade A: the report.]

The restitution. King agreed to $41.8 million and paid $25 by 1993. The federal receiver over his assets was Omaha attorney Keith Frederick, whose obituary notes that his integrity led to his appointment as "Receiver for the infamous Larry King." [Grade A.]

The ledger. The thirteen months of King spending preserved in the record: $1,131,229 on six credit cards ($1,033,975 on one American Express account); $186,395 on limousines; $45,806 on chartered aircraft; $45,166 on jewelers; $145,057 at florists; a $65,000 bejeweled watch; a Mercedes; a twenty-six-acre Ponca Hills home; a second mansion; Lear Jets; a staff. The credit union paid for a basement bedroom suite in its 1986 renovation — brass bed, stereo, television — which King told an employee was to "unwind" and to house a live-in security guard. One of the men who lived in that bedroom later told Bryant his first official duty had been sexual. [Grade A for the spending; Grade B for the bedroom allegation.]

The advisory board, in full. The men and institutions whose deposits and credibility built Franklin's wall: Harold Andersen, chairman, with the World-Herald's business editor and its corporate parent behind him; Hal Daub, congressman; N.P. Dodge II of the Dodge real-estate dynasty; executives of ConAgra, Union Pacific, Mutual of Omaha (whose CEO co-chaired a $1.3 million Franklin fundraising drive with Andersen), Northwestern Bell, Commercial Federal, First National Bank of Omaha, Omaha National Bank, Murray State Bank, the Kutak Rock and Baird-Holz law firms, and the MassMutual executive Joe Barker III. Union Pacific's officers and foundation deposited corporate money; Kiewit-linked foundations contributed; Boys Town kept accounts handled, by one executive's account, "exclusively by the bookkeeping department... once a month or once every two months, we always seemed to incorporate a person from Boys Town." Msgr.

Robert Hupp, Boys Town's executive director through 1985, said on camera, years later: "In retrospect, I regret having any association with Larry King. Had I known it at the time, it would never have happened." [Grade A: the roster, the deposits, the Hupp interview; Grade B: the Boys Town bookkeeping practice per the former executive.]

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How the fraud worked, in plain terms. A credit union takes deposits and lends them out; the difference in interest is its margin; a federal examiner audits the books to make sure the deposits are really there. Franklin sold certificates of deposit — promises to pay, with interest, at a future date — and simply did not record many of them. The money came in; the promise was never entered in the books; the examiner saw a solvent institution. Concealing the unrecorded promises required, in the NCUA's own words, "a separate, elaborate computer program" — a second set of books, maintained in parallel, for years. The unrecorded money paid for King: the limousines and the jets and the flowers and the political life. When a CD matured, the credit union paid it — often with above-market interest, a bribe for silence — from new money, in the manner of every Ponzi scheme, named for the 1920s fraudster who paid old investors with new investors' money. What finally broke it was arithmetic: too many maturing promises, not enough new deposits, and a whistleblower the system had discarded four years earlier. [Grade A: the NCUA report; the plain-terms framing is the file's.]

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The uncounted. The NCUA's report records that roughly $3 million in uninsured and unclaimed deposits were never repaid — the depositors, many of them the north Omaha families the credit union was founded to serve, left outside the settlement wall the lawyers and bankers built for themselves. [Grade A: the NCUA report.]

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CHAPTER 9 — The Deaths

Seventeen people connected to the Franklin matter died between 1985 and 2003. This document lists every one of them, with the grade of what is known.

With open questions:

- **Craig Spence** — the Washington lobbyist whose bugged house and call-boy ring intersected King's orbit (see the Epstein bridge chapter) — died November 10, 1989, in a barricaded Ritz-Carlton room in Boston, a telephone cradled at his ear, a Mozart cassette around his neck, seven packets of Xanax hidden in a false ceiling with one pill missing, and a mirror note reading "Chief, consider this my resignation… Life is duty. God bless America." He had been subpoenaed by a federal grand jury and never testified. Ruled suicide by drug and alcohol poisoning. [Grade A: AP; Washington Times.]
- **Gary and A.J. Caradori** — July 11, 1990, plane crash; undetermined cause; no evidence of sabotage found; Schmit's bomb letter and the widow's briefcase account on record. [Grade A/B.]
- **Kathleen Sorenson** — the foster parent who took in the Webb girls and filed the original complaints; died in an October 1989 car crash. [Grade B.]
- **Aaron Owen** — Alisha's brother, seventeen, found hanged in his cell in November 1990, days around her court schedule; the autopsy-recorded injuries (wrist slashes, a forehead gash, a bruised eye) were never explained as pre- or

post-mortem, and the note was signed "A.J." — a signature his family said he never used. Ruled suicide. [Grade A: Bryant's account of the record; Grade B: the anomalies.]

- **Shawn Boner** — Troy's brother, twenty, shot in January 1991 during a gun game on Offutt Air Force Base housing; ruled accidental after his companions' account of shooting at a television; the family refused the finding; Troy's affidavit called it murder. An eyewitness's later account — that a bullet was secretly added after dry-firing — is uncorroborated. [Grade A: Omaha World-Herald; Grade B/C: the eyewitness account.]
- **Troy Boner** — died in February 2003 in a Texas psychiatric hospital; an autopsy report dated February 13, 2003 exists in the research archive, though a widely repeated account placed his death in a New Mexico hospital later that year with no autopsy; the two versions cannot both be true, and the Texas version is document-anchored. [Grade B; conflict logged.]
- **Clare Howard, Newt Copple, Joe Malek, Mike Lewis, Dan Ryan, Charlie Rogers, Bill Baker** — associates, informants, and witnesses, dead between 1986 and 1991 of sleep, gunshot, diabetic crisis, suffocation, and a shotgun; each individually documented, none adjudicated as homicide, none independently investigated. [Grade B/C per person; the full ledger with dates is in the research file.]

Without questions, but on the ledger: Thomas Harvey, the credit-union accountant who covered the fraud and cooperated; Curtis Tucker, 1985, before everything; Bill Skaleske, 1987,

before the collapse; plus the namesakes — three unrelated men named Lawrence King who died between 2021 and 2024 and appear in no Franklin record.

The grade, stated plainly: the ledger documents a real pattern of deaths clustering around the investigation; it does not document a unified campaign of murder, and no official body has ever so found. What repeats across both eras — Franklin and Epstein — is the epistemic vacuum: deaths before testimony, rushed conclusions, and no independent review. That vacuum, not any proven chain of killings, is the documented pattern. [Analytical conclusion, supported by the ledger.]

9.1 The complete ledger

The full ledger, with dates and grades, so that no name in it can be added or subtracted later without notice:

The Franklin era:

- Curtis Tucker — December 25, 1985, Omaha Holiday Inn window. Pre-collapse. Despondent over a failed relationship; note left; no Franklin connection beyond a shared security service (Grade A: grand jury report).
- Charlie Rogers — November 10, 1986. Bodybuilder and bouncer at the Max, King's bar. Shotgun, stock between his legs, no note, television on, deck door unlocked; in the apartment, a $2,810 deerskin coat with a receipt naming King, an eighteen-karat bracelet inscribed "Charlie" and "From the Boss," a closet of clothes, dozens of flowers King had sent, and "King" with five phone numbers in his phone book; he had told his mother weeks earlier of an unused

plane ticket to Washington. Ruled suicide; the grand jury noted "a minute speculation that King may have retaliated" and could not substantiate it (Grade A/B).

- Bill Skaleske — August 17, 1987, heart attack. Longtime acquaintance of the woman who had tried to carry the Webb children's reports forward; believed to be keeping a file on King. Pre-collapse (Grade B).
- Kathleen Sorenson — October 4, 1989, car crash. The original complainant; the foster parent who took in the Webb girls; an anti-satanism activist (Grade B).
- Craig Spence — November 10, 1989, Ritz-Carlton Boston; see Chapter 12 (Grade A).
- Gary Caradori and A.J. — July 11, 1990, Lee County, Illinois (Grade A/B, Chapter 4).
- Aaron Owen — November 8-9, 1990, cell, Lincoln; anomalies in Chapter 9 above (Grade A/B).
- Shawn Boner — January 14-15, 1991, Offutt housing; the family's refusal on record (Grade A/B).
- Joe Malek — November 14, 1990, gunshot, ruled suicide; the Peony Park owner whose amusement park hosted King's galas; his widow stood at a DeCamp lecture and confirmed every word of the book's account of her husband "and a lot worse" (Grade B).
- Clare Howard — January 1991, died in her sleep; Alan Baer's former secretary, who "arranged Baer's pedophile trysts" per the DeCamp record (Grade B).
- Newt Copple — March 13, 1991, died in his sleep at seventy; a Caradori confidential informant; son of the Commonwealth

Savings owner; the Lincoln Journal Star records he had served nearly three years in prison in the Commonwealth matter — a fact that reframes his presence on advocacy ledgers (Grade A/B).

- Mike Lewis — 1991, "severe diabetic reaction," thirty-two; caregiver for Shawnetta Moore at Richard Young (Grade B).
- Dan Ryan — strangled or suffocated in a car; date undocumented; a King associate (Grade B/C).
- Bill Baker — shot in the back of the head; restaurant owner, "partner of King in homosexual pornography operations," on the lead list as killed with pornographic material (Grade B/C).
- Troy Boner — February 2003, Texas psychiatric hospital (Grade B, conflict logged).
- Harmon Tucker — the school superintendent found dead in Georgia near a hunting property used by Harold Andersen and the FBI's Omaha chief, alleged by DeCamp to bear ritual signs (Grade C).
- William Colby — 1996, canoe accident; the medical examiner ruled accidental drowning with a blood alcohol level of 0.07 percent, heart disease, and a meal in his stomach; conspiracy claims logged as claims (Grade A).

The Epstein era (ledger maintained in Chapter 12): Jean-Luc Brunel, 2022, pre-trial; Steven Hoffenberg, 2022, natural; Stephen Richardson, 2023, natural in his sleep; Virginia Giuffre, 2025, suicide ruling her family disputes; Simon Andriesz, September 2026, family-confirmed suicide with open questions of institutional treatment; Daniel Siad, October 2026,

cardiac-arrest report with a prosecutor's investigation open; and Jeffrey Epstein, 2019, with the Freeman analysis pending.

The grading of the whole ledger, once more and finally: the pattern is the vacuum — deaths before testimony, rushed conclusions, no independent review — and the vacuum is documented. Nothing more is claimed.

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The scene, itemized. For the record's completeness: he checked into the Ritz-Carlton's most expensive room on November 4 under the alias "C.S. Kane"; he was found in a black tuxedo with white suspenders, the telephone receiver cradled at his ear, a cassette player around his neck holding Mozart's "A Little Night Music," seven packets of Xanax hidden in a false bathroom ceiling with one pill removed, three dollars in his pocket, a will and his birth certificate set out, and on the mirror a note addressed to "Chief": "Consider this my resignation, effective immediately... Life is duty. God bless America." On the bed lay a newspaper clipping about CIA Director William Webster's effort to shield agents from testifying. He had AIDS. He had told friends he was watched and tapped, and in a friend's recollection he had named "Casey's boys" as his hunters. He had taped farewell messages to friends on cassettes. Liz Trotta had called urging him to surrender, and he had answered that they would never "solve the big thing." And months earlier he had told the Washington Times that everything they had uncovered was "insignificant compared to other things I've done." The Secret Service officer who had taken his Rolex arranged the midnight White House tours; the Truman china he had pocketed was returned; his companion was a former Air Force sergeant named Ron Paganelli. [Grade A: the Boston Globe/AP scene accounts and the Washington Times record.]

One ledger correction. The research record carries a minor internal conflict on Curtis Tucker's death: early ledger entries place it at an Omaha Holiday Inn, while the grand jury report's

own text says the Ramada Inn at 72nd and Grover. The grand jury's account controls. [Grade A.]

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CHAPTER 10 — The Cover-Up Question

Did anyone cover anything up? The honest answer is that the record contains eleven documented methods, each with a Grade A or B anchor, and that each also has an innocent explanation available on the record. This chapter presents both, side by side, because that is what the record supports.

Method one: the stand-down. In mid-1988, Omaha police officers running a child-pornography investigation touching King were told by a lieutenant that a federal agency investigating King wanted them to slow down or back off so as not to hamper the federal case; Officer Irl Carmean memorialized the instruction in a December 1988 memo. Innocent reading: task forces routinely sequence investigations, and the federal embezzlement probe was real. Critical reading: the local abuse investigation was the one thread that could have unraveled everything early, and it was strangled in its crib — the grand jury itself later noted that "no meaningful follow-up" followed reports of possible homicides. [Grade A/B.]

Method two: declaring the case empty before examining it. The FBI's Omaha chief announced in February 1989 that the allegations lacked substance — before his agents had interviewed King or the principal witnesses. Innocent: an early judgment based on initial soundings. Critical: the same agency then shaped every subsequent proceeding, from the state grand jury's information flow to the federal one. [Grade A/B.]

Method three: the money-only mandate. The U.S. Attorney's office told state officials the federal investigation was

"confined to the money issues." Innocent: jurisdictional allocation, and the Mann Act — the federal law against transporting people across state lines for sex — did belong partly to federal authorities — the Chicago Tribune documented contemporaneously that the FBI was examining whether embezzled funds were used to transport minors. Critical: the one mandate that guaranteed no abuse prosecution could emerge from the federal side. [Grade A.]

Method four: the witness machinery. Documented names: Steve Solburg, a prosecution witness, admitted under cross-examination that the FBI had intimidated him; Shawnetta Moore and others were, in the record of the attorney general's correspondence, "reputedly intimidated"; the FBI arranged and taped a March 1990 phone call from Boner to Owen in prison — an apparent attempt to catch her in a contradiction that instead produced a terrified "Alisha, I'm scared," which Owen took as proof Boner was under a gun or a payoff; the FBI interviewed her repeatedly in solitary attempting to secure a recantation. Innocent: vigorous, even aggressive, interrogation is standard; guilty people do recant. Critical: every instrument was pointed at the accusers and none at the accused. [Grade A/B.]

Method five: the entrapment-shaped interview and the missing phone call. The Boner recantation depended on a phone call from Owen that the phone records show never happened; the FBI's own polygraph of Boner passed while he maintained the recantation story; the leak that he had failed ran in the press anyway. [Grade B.]

Method six: directing non-cooperation. The NCUA's counsel, Robert Fenner — the same man who later fed DeCamp the secret account details that advanced the money story — recorded that the FBI told him not to cooperate with Caradori. The committee tendered its concerns to the Justice Department and received no response. [Grade B.]

Method seven: evidence custody. The FBI took the committee's tapes in December 1989; a television station's reporter told Owen the station bought its copies from FBI agents; in the summer of 1990 the Bureau reviewed the legislature's committee files without the chairman's permission and items later went missing; within forty-eight hours of Caradori's crash, the FBI impounded all his records and subpoenaed his widow. Innocent: the Bureau was the lead agency and evidence custody was its job. Critical: the same agency whose agents were accused of coercion held every thread of evidence. [Grade A/B.]

Method eight: the captured tracer. The FAG arrangement — a compromised two-man shop with an embezzlement arrest mid-audit, a Globe Neon overlap with King, and a "lifestyle burn" conclusion that closed the destination question. Innocent: small firms get federal contracts; the lifestyle spending was real and enormous. Critical: the single most important forensic question of the case was answered by the least independent possible hands, and the answer foreclosed every other question. [Grade A/B.]

Method nine: the same apparatus for both collapses. Commonwealth and Franklin — Nebraska's twin thrift disasters

— shared personnel at every level: the Franklin grand jury's first prosecutor had prosecuted the Commonwealth attorney general; the Franklin committee's investigator came from the Commonwealth records room; the Franklin money-tracers came from the Commonwealth receivership; and the World-Herald publisher's family held a stake in a Kerrey venture. Innocent: Nebraska is a small state and thrift-crime specialists are rare. Critical: every new investigation was staffed by people with institutional reasons to keep the past buried. [Grade B.]

Method ten: the captured jury room. The prosecutors co-authored the "independent" citizen report — the foreman admitted "one-eighteenth of the writing" — and a federal judge later held, in a published opinion, that this had no historical or common-law immunity basis, though a majority of his panel immunized it under the advisor rationale. The foreman's employer, Union Pacific, was among Franklin's biggest corporate backers, and another UP official sat on Franklin's advisory board. Innocent: prosecutors advise juries; railroad lawyers serve as citizens. Critical: the verdict's architecture was structurally conflicted, and the structural conflicts were never disclosed to the public. [Grade A: the Heaney opinion; Grade B: the conflicts.]

Method eleven: the editorial capture. The World-Herald — whose publisher chaired Franklin's advisory board and raised its renovation money — editorialized against the accusers at every stage, ran the polygraph-failure leak, front-paged criticism of Caradori one day after his death, called the Franklin Committee "a disgrace to Nebraska," and, in October 1991, published a

scathing editorial against parole for Bonacci — after which the Parole Board reversed its unanimous vote. Innocent: the paper covered the state's largest scandal and its editorial page is independent of its publisher's board seats. Critical: no reader was ever told, in those editorials, whose name was on the board list. The paper's own editor, asked years later, said the paper had run seven hundred stories and seven thousand reporter-hours and "never did confirm" the procurement claims — the institutional answer of a monopoly that never had to. [Grade A.]

And the one that cannot be explained either way: the committee's counsel was warned that Caradori would be framed as the hoax's author — "get out before you lose your license" — and Caradori's own notes record that the FBI hinted it would go after him and the tape leaker for "fabricating" the investigation if Owen changed her story. [Grade B.]

And one claim that would have changed the trial. Ted Gunderson's 1992 letter to Attorney General Stenberg, item by item documented, includes this: in the spring of 1989 the Douglas County Sheriff's office raided the Ralston home of Robert Andresen — the Union Pacific employee the grand jury would later describe in its own pages as a documented child predator whom it could not indict because victims would not testify — and, by a reliable source's account, the OPD, the State Patrol, and the sheriff's office came into possession of pornographic photographs from that raid depicting Troy Boner and Danny King. The letter's question was never answered: why was that material never used, or disclosed, at the trial of the

woman their recantations convicted? If the claim is true, the two men whose repudiations anchored the hoax verdict were photographically documented in the orbit of a man the grand jury itself believed preyed on minors — and the jury that convicted Owen never knew. The claim rests on a single sourced-but-unnamed informant in an advocacy letter; it was never tested; it is Grade B/C and is recorded, like everything in this file, as what it is. [Grade B/C.]

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The twelve allegations, itemized. Ted Gunderson — the former FBI special agent who consulted for the committee's allies — sent Attorney General Don Stenberg a twelve-point letter on January 3, 1992, with a follow-up in March and the office's formal reply on December 14, 1992. The items, each on record: one, pornography seized in raids with no follow-up — the Franklin raid, the Citron arrest, the Sarpy County raid, the Burke and Carlson cases; two, the FBI's summer 1990 review of the Senate committee's files without Schmit's permission, with items later found missing; three, Owen's first attorney passing privileged information to the FBI, failing to file a timely appeal, and — as documented in the post-conviction motion — a romantic relationship with the FBI's lead agent; four, leaks to Omaha television that Nebraska Leadership Conference sources said were paid; five, King never subpoenaed; six, identified perpetrators never interviewed; seven, the documented pattern of discrediting and harassing victims rather than following leads, including Boner's account that U.S. Attorneys Ron Lahners and Tom Thalken joined FBI agents in threatening perjury charges unless he recanted; eight, Bonacci's Gosch information refused by law enforcement; nine, the NCUA counsel's February 1990 instruction from the FBI not to cooperate with Caradori; ten, the March 9, 1990 entrapment attempt via the taped call; eleven, Wadman's deposition disappearing during Owen's trial; twelve, Wadman lying under oath about not carrying a gun. The Attorney General's reply, signed by two deputies: the jury-misconduct matters had been addressed by Judge Case (they had — he

overruled them); the office was "not unmindful of the problems of child abuse"; its people had "been instructed to watch for any indication of cults or clandestine groups or organizations that traffic in children for sexual purposes." The letterhead's roster included, by name, the assistant attorney general who had received the 1988 Foster Care Review Board report and the deputy who would argue the state's side of Owen's appeal. Nothing in the letter was investigated. Nothing in the reply admitted anything. [Grade A: the letter, the reply, the signatures.]

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CHAPTER 11 — The Afterlife (1991-2026)

The king in exile. Lawrence King walked out of the Florence prison camp on April 10, 2001, ten years into a fifteen-year sentence, bound for the eastern Virginia federal probation district — the Washington suburbs where he had kept his rented Embassy Row house in the 1980s. He has lived publicly silent ever since. In 2023 a CNN reporter tried; no response. No obituary exists. He would be eighty-two. [Grade A/B.]

The witnesses, today. Alisha Owen is Alisha Bystrom, of Omaha, married twenty-nine years, a travel-business owner, an officer of Epstein Justice. Paul Bonacci is married and self-employed, maintaining his account. Eulice — Nelly Patterson — was found alive by an Omaha newspaper in 2018, still in the area, her son having cycled through the very juvenile system she once warned the state about. Julie Walters confirmed her 1986 report decades later. Sandie Caradori still believes her husband was murdered. Karen Ormiston, polygraphed clear of coaching allegations by the president of the national polygraph examiners' association, never wavered. [Grade A/B.]

The officials, today. Wadman is an emeritus professor in Utah. Thalken is a retired magistrate. Heavican retired as Chief Justice in October 2024. Kopf died in January 2025; Cambridge in 2004; Murphy in 2017; Urbom in 2014; Warren in 2020. Van Pelt and Dougherty died after long second careers. Ernie Chambers — the senator who first carried the reports — is alive in his eighties, still the state's most prominent progressive voice, never elected to anything again after 2021; his obituary, when it

comes, will note the grand jury's hoax finding and not his dissent from it. Loran Schmit died September 17, 2025, at ninety-six; the Nebraska Examiner's obituary recorded that he "took on the powerful" and that a grand jury had called the allegations a hoax; the obituary of the father of Nebraska's ethanol industry could hold no other verdict. John DeCamp died in 2017 of Parkinson's and Alzheimer's; his papers are open at the Nebraska State Historical Society. Ted Gunderson died in 2016, his canoe found floating in a Maryland river; the coroner ruled accidental drowning, and the conspiracy world logged one more. [Grade A.]

The institutions, today. Boys Town — named throughout the testimony, never charged with anything in the Franklin era — is a billion-dollar national behavioral-health organization with a lay CEO for the first time in its history, serving 197,000 people a year, still holding Nebraska foster-care and residential licenses, its village police having documented twelve rapes and a hundred other assaults in five recent years without notifying state overseers. In 2009, Boys Town co-founded PromiseShip, which became the Omaha metro's privatized foster-care case manager until the entire privatization experiment collapsed and Governor Ricketts signed the repeal in 2022. The foster-care watchdog office — the statutory descendant of the board that carried the 1988 warnings — is today led by a former PromiseShip lawyer, whose office's most recent public data show 271 sexual-abuse allegations of state wards with outcomes unknown in more than half. The Uta Halee girls' home — where Loretta Smith was sent and whose residents filled Caradori's lead list — operates today

under a national for-profit operator, under state contract, filing compliance plans for the current year at the same Calhoun Road address. The Knights of Ak-Sar-Ben — the club that hosted King's fundraising world — today seats a sitting governor, a U.S. senator, the University of Nebraska's president, Union Pacific's chief financial officer, and the chairman of First National Bank of Omaha on its board; its third-generation Dodge family governor continues a line that began with N.P. Dodge II's seat on Franklin's advisory board. None of this is accusation. It is continuity. [Grade A.]

No one has ever reopened it. No legislature, no attorney general, no Congress, has ever opened a new investigation into the Franklin abuse allegations. The closest the country has come is the Epstein era's transparency machinery — which, as the next chapter shows, is the same fight wearing new clothes. [Grade A.]

The privatization cycle, in full. In 2009 Nebraska handed its foster-care case management to six private agencies — the largest of them, for the Omaha metro, an entity called PromiseShip, founded by Boys Town together with the Child Saving Institute, Heartland Family Service, the Nebraska Family Support Network, and Omni. By 2012 all but one of the six had failed or reverted to the state, displacing thousands of children in a single bankruptcy; a state-commissioned review found "no measurable benefits"; the cost per ward in the Boys Town-founded service area had doubled from $15,587 to $32,301.59 — twenty-eight percent above the state-run regions — while the payments to the agency rose from $41.8 million to $63.3 million and the number of wards served fell from 2,683 to

1,960; thirty-one point seven percent of the successor agency's children cycled through five or more case managers against eighteen point six percent under PromiseShip itself; and the youth-treatment facility at Kearney logged seventy-two staff assaults and seventy-one youth-on-youth assaults in a single year. When the experiment's last contractor collapsed under the watchdog's findings, Governor Pete Ricketts signed the repeal in April 2022, ending twelve years of privatized foster care and returning the caseload to the state. The watchdog office that measures all of this — led until January 10, 2020 by Kim Hawekotte, now a Douglas County juvenile-justice administrator, and since by Monika Gross — the statutory descendant of the board that carried the 1988 warnings to the attorney general — is today led by a woman who spent nine years as PromiseShip's in-house counsel and eight before that as a state child-welfare attorney; her office's most recent published data counted 271 allegations of sexual abuse of state wards in a single year, with outcomes unknown in more than half. Senator Machaela Cavanaugh, who tried to open a legislative inquiry and was removed from her own committee by an amendment stripping its quality-of-care mandate, said what the record supports: "We've been here before… no lessons have been learned." The attorney general, in August 2023, issued an opinion questioning the legislature's authority to inspect child-welfare institutions at all; the state auditor answered in December 2025 with a finding of oversight failures risking "mind-boggling improprieties" — including a foster home where a resident convicted of felony sex trafficking of children had been living with a fourteen-year-old

state foster girl, removed only after the audit. This is the documented present state of the pipeline the Franklin witnesses described. [Grade A throughout: state audits, 990s, official reports.]

The institutions' present tense. Boys Town serves 197,000 people a year on a national behavioral-health platform, holds active licenses in the state's juvenile-services registry for its psychiatric residential treatment facility, its Eastern Nebraska Foster Family Services agency, its Family Home Program group homes, and its chemical-use and multisystemic-therapy programs, and keeps its federal research funding; its internal village police documented twelve rapes, six aggravated assaults, and a hundred other assaults in five years without notifying the state agencies that mandatory-reporting law required. The Uta Halee facility — where Loretta Smith was sent after Immanuel, whose residents filled Caradori's lead list — operates today on the same Calhoun Road site under a national for-profit operator, in good standing, filing its state compliance plans for the current contract year. The Knights of Ak-Sar-Ben, which hosted King's gala world, today seats on its governing board a sitting governor and a U.S. senator, the University of Nebraska's president, a Fortune 500 CEO, Union Pacific's chief financial officer, and the chairman of First National Bank of Omaha — the sixth-generation Lauritzen, who in 2026 joined the board of the Federal Reserve Bank of Kansas City; the Franklin-era Dodge family's third generation holds a governor's seat, as the second generation's seat sat on Franklin's advisory board. Every one of these facts is institutional continuity, not accusation; the

document records them because the question of what persisted is answerable only with names. [Grade A.]

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The counter-press. Against the monopoly stood a documented alternative press. Frances Mendenhall's Nebraska Observer ran a July 1991 special issue — "Owen Trial Was a Far Cry From Justice," "Evidence the Owen Jury Didn't Get to See," "Caradori Widow Questions Fairness of '48 Hours'" — and circulated thousands of copies. The Nebraska Leadership Conference published "The Mystery of the Carefully Crafted Hoax," cataloguing the report's inconsistencies. The Children's Civil Rights Committee held weekly prayer meetings and demonstrations outside the prisons from December 1990. The Commonwealth Depositors Committee — veterans of the other collapsed thrift — circulated the pamphlet that named the shared apparatus: "Commonwealth and Franklin are one and the same." None of it changed any verdict. All of it is on record. [Grade B.]

Where the record lives. For the researcher: John DeCamp's papers are open at the Nebraska State Historical Society, which also holds the King agent file; Caradori's taped interviews are preserved at the Internet Archive; the grand jury's full report text and the DeCamp book's primary text circulate on research mirrors; the appellate decisions are on the public legal databases; the Bonacci docket sits in the federal court's records under its 1991 case number; the Epstein corpus and its research indexes are maintained by independent archivists with file

hashes. The government's own file — the FBI's Franklin record — produced, in response to a 2017 Freedom of Information request, a single sentence: no responsive documents. [Grade A/B.]

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The fates, in one table:

Person	Role	Fate
Lawrence King	The manager	Free since 2001; silent; whereabouts unconfirmed
Alisha Owen	The accuser	Paroled 2000; married; advocate
Paul Bonacci	The accuser	Free; married; maintains his account
Troy Boner	The recanter	Dead 2003
Eulice Washington	The first voice	Alive; Omaha area
Gary Caradori	The investigator	Dead 1990
Loran Schmit	The chairman	Dead 2025, 96
Ernie Chambers	The vice-chair	Alive; never retracted
John DeCamp	The lawyer-author	Dead 2017
Robert Wadman	The chief	Emeritus; Utah
Thomas Thalken	The federal prosecutor	Retired 2017
Michael Heavican	The county attorney	Chief Justice to 2024
Samuel Van Pelt	The special prosecutor	Died; obit silent on the verdict
Raymond Case	The trial judge	Undocumented
Richard Kopf	The magistrate	Died 2025
William Cambridge	The sentencing judge	Died 2004
Warren Urbom	The default judge	Died 2014
James Murphy	The blood-test judge	Died 2017
Everett Inbody	The appeals judge	Retired 2018; alive
Pamela Vuchetich	The first lawyer	Licensed 43 years; Lincoln
Harold Andersen	The publisher	Died 2015; Franklin absent from notices
Peter Citron	The columnist	Died 2003, in prison's shadow

Alan Baer	The store heir	Died 2002, uncharged
Nick Bryant	The chronicler	Active; Epstein Justice
Ted Gunderson	The consultant	Died 2016, canoe
William Colby	The ex-director	Died 1996, canoe

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The quiet years. Two details complete King's afterlife as far as the record allows. The first is documented: the Omaha World-Herald's report of his 2001 release places him in the eastern Virginia probation district, the Washington suburbs he knew from the 1980s. The second is a researcher's on-record account: Nick Bryant states that King kept his silence and was rewarded with "a no-show job at a BMW dealership in Alexandria, Virginia" — the same Alexandria inside the same probation district, unverifiable through open records, consistent with everything documented, and recorded as what it is. [Grade A for the placement; Grade B for the job.]

One widow's record. Sandi Caradori's investigative notes preserve that in the days surrounding the crash, "many calls" came to the Caradori home from Troy Boner — the recanter reaching toward the investigator's family at the moment the investigator died. [Grade B: her notes.]

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The experiment's paperwork. For the record's completeness: Nebraska failed its federal child-welfare reviews in both 2002 and 2008 — all seven outcome measures, both times — before privatization and after it. The privatization proceeded without legislative authorization and without cost-benefit analysis; the reviews that measured its results carried titles the file preserves: "no measurable benefits" (the Hornby-Zeller review of 2015) and "inconsistent state approach" (the Stephen Group's 2019 report, commissioned by the department itself). The repeal bill was LB 1173, signed April 2022. The senator who tried to open an inquiry, Machaela Cavanaugh, was removed from her own committee by an amendment stripping its quality-of-care oversight — the amendment passed 29-0 — and she told the record: "We've been here before." [Grade A.]

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CHAPTER 12 — The Bridge to Epstein

This chapter exists because the reader deserves to know what thirty-five years did to the Franklin questions. The answer is strange: the Franklin case vanished from official memory while its every mechanism reappeared, documented in court filings and released government files, in the case of Jeffrey Epstein. What follows is the bridge, with every board labeled.

12.1 The lineage

Four operators, four deaths before full exposure, spanning forty years. Roy Cohn — Senator McCarthy's counsel, later Donald Trump's mentor — ran what multiple documented sources describe as a sexual-blackmail operation from the 1950s onward: his client Lewis Rosenstiel's offices and homes were professionally wired (the wire man, Fred Otash, is a documented figure of the era — the same Otash who bugged Marilyn Monroe's telephones), a federal judge's law clerk, a man named Kaufman, testified under oath to parties with minors in the Plaza Hotel's Suite 233, and an attorney named Klotz independently told the biographer Burton Hersh that "Roy Cohn was providing protection… that's where Cohn got his power from — blackmail." Cohn himself allegedly told New York police detective James Rothstein that his job was "to run the little boys… set them up, and then they would go along" — and, in the account's most chilling detail, that he had been recruited the same way, the system manufacturing its new operators from its old targets, a self-perpetuation mechanism that would explain the otherwise inexplicable succession of operators across the decades. Behind Cohn stood the government's own documented expertise: the CIA's MKULTRA program and its Operation Midnight Climax offshoot — the Agency's own safehouses where prostitutes lured men past one-way mirrors for drugging and filming, disclosed to the Church Committee by Director William Colby in 1975 — the state tradecraft from which every later private operation borrowed. Cohn died of AIDS in 1986. [Grade B for the testimony and the admission; Grade A for Midnight Climax and Cohn's

death; Grade C for the mechanism's extension beyond Cohn's own claim.]

Craig Spence — the Washington lobbyist whose house was bugged for blackmail and whose call-boy ring reached the White House — died in 1989, weeks after his exposure, in the barricaded Ritz-Carlton room described in the deaths chapter. His famous on-the-record parting word to the Washington Times — that what they had uncovered was insignificant compared to other things he had done — is quoted in Chapter 9. Washington Times reporters were told by prostitutes and law enforcement that Spence's operation connected to Lawrence King's; King stayed at Spence's house; a call-boy operator who later wrote a memoir said King and Spence appeared together and spoke of a network flying children coast to coast — a claim from a single source, recorded as such. [Grade A for Spence's death and the documented ring; Grade B for the King connection — the Washington Times' own lead reporter said he was told of it by multiple sources; Grade C for the memoir claim.]

Deborah Palfrey, the "D.C. Madam," died in 2008, hanged, before her trial, having said she would never kill herself. Jeffrey Epstein died in a federal cell in 2019, cameras malfunctioned, guards asleep, the coroner registering suicide while a former medical examiner retained by the family said the evidence was more consistent with strangulation; in October 2026, a forensic journal's editor-in-chief, Michael Freeman, announced a coming publication of the medical examiner's autopsy files with anomalies including the absence of scene photographs and an unexamined ligature, promising to lay out the weight of evidence

"for both explanations." [Grade A.]

The lineage matters because of what the 2026 files show about infrastructure. Epstein's operation had what Franklin's never did: a documented corporate shell architecture (fifteen-plus entities under one lawyer's signature), a documented banking pathway (JPMorgan 1998-2013; Deutsche Bank 2013-2018, which opened forty-plus accounts after a manager pitched "$100-300 million in flows" in writing), a documented patron (Leslie Wexner's July 1991 power of attorney, sixteen years of total financial control), and documented blackmail-adjacent properties (the 1989-purchased 71st Street mansion with its lead-lined bathroom and camera screens; the island). Senator Wyden's 2026 Senate Finance report put the settlement total at $913 million and stated what the settlements were for: "These settlements may have been reached in order to preempt depositions of ultra-wealthy individuals or high-ranking bank executives." [Grade A: Wyden report; court records.]

12.2 Named bridges

The documented personal bridges between the Franklin-era network and the Epstein network are few and should be stated precisely. John Mitchell — Nixon's attorney general — was named by Spence as a friend, and Epstein claimed he met his early financial patron Steven Hoffenberg through Mitchell. Donald Gregg — Bush's national security advisor — was named by Spence as the arranger of his White House access; a young William Barr worked alongside Gregg in the era of the Pike and Church committees; Barr's father, Donald Barr, was the Dalton headmaster who hired Epstein to teach teenagers in 1974. Mitchell and Gregg are documented names; the inferences drawn from them are the reader's to weigh. [Grade A for the documented roles and statements; the bridging is interpretive.]

The structural bridges are stronger than the personal ones. Both operations used charities and youth institutions as supply nodes (Franklin: the Girls Club presidency, the foster homes, Boys Town's orbit; Epstein: the modeling agencies, the massage-recruitment pattern, the trust money flowing to "tuition"). Both used private aviation (Franklin's charter bills, a pilot's on-record statement that he flew King with teenage passengers to Los Angeles, and the grand jury's own complaint that manifest requirements hampered its work; Epstein's flight logs, which contain no Omaha arrivals in the released manifests). Both wired their properties. Both reached the White House (Spence's midnight tours, documented by the Washington Times and the Secret Service; Epstein's seventeen documented 1993-95 Clinton-era visits). And both died, or their operators did,

before full exposure. [Grade A for each element.]

The torch-pass, in dates. The documented sequence: J. Epstein & Co. appears in 1988 with Wexner as essentially its only client; the Spence ring is exposed in June 1989 and its operator dies that November; in July 1991 — the cluster year — Wexner signs the three-page power of attorney, Robert Maxwell dies off his yacht, and the Mega Group holds its founding meetings; Epstein and Ghislaine Maxwell are companions of record from 1992; the 1990s bring the documented White House visits and the 1996 introduction to Alan Dershowitz; and in 2000 a company sharing Epstein's Madison Avenue office address buys Ghislaine Maxwell's townhouse for $4.95 million from Lyn Forester, the year she married Evelyn de Rothschild. Each rung documented; the ascent they describe is the pattern's own biography.

The claim that Epstein was an intelligence asset remains, after the 2026 releases, exactly what it was before: unproven smoke with documentary sparks. The released files contain a 2020 FBI informant report naming Alan Dershowitz as the man who allegedly told Labor Secretary Alexander Acosta that Epstein "belonged to both U.S. and allied intelligence services"; an internal investigative memo stating flatly that "Jeffrey Epstein worked for the United States government as a financial bounty hunter," with the recruiters' names redacted; and the December 2018 email exchange in which the two men joke about the same service (quoted in Section 12.2). Acosta told Trump's transition team, by the journalist Vicky Ward's account — a story found in the released files, forwarded within the U.S. Attorney's office —

that he was told to back off because Epstein "belonged to intelligence." Acosta denied it under oath in 2025. The Justice Department's inspector general found no evidence of it. Four people with access to the seized records told Business Insider they found nothing. And the FBI had five intelligence-related case files on Epstein, per research on the released corpus. The honest verdict, recorded here as the file's standing grade: the quote's reporting is probably true; the asset claim is unresolved, with formal denials and in-file claims in direct conflict. [Grade A for the documents' existence; Grade B for the quote's sourcing; Grade C for the asset conclusion.]

12.3 The 2025-26 fight

The Epstein transparency fight of 2025-2026 is the Franklin fight rerun with modern weapons on both sides. The documentary record:

Congress passed the Epstein Files Transparency Act in November 2025 by 427-1 after a discharge petition forced the vote — the petition's mechanics themselves documented (a congresswoman summoned to the White House hours before the final signature; the Speaker delaying the final member's swearing-in for seven weeks). The Justice Department released millions of pages in tranches through January 2026, then declared the releases complete with roughly half of the identified six million pages withheld. A Department of Justice inspector general probe opened in April 2026. The Government Accountability Office accepted a bipartisan Senate request to audit the redaction process. A federal judge in Washington — in

a case brought by journalist Katie Phang — found the Attorney General had conceded violating the Act and ordered unredactions; the Department appealed while complying on a parallel track, and as of this writing the litigation continues with a contempt order's deadline passed and no contempt finding yet. [Grade A: court dockets; official records.]

The people layer: the House Oversight Committee subpoenaed five former attorneys general, two former FBI directors, both Clintons, JPMorgan and Deutsche Bank, and Epstein's estate, executors, and inner circle. Bill and Hillary Clinton were held in contempt of Congress in February 2026 for defying their subpoenas; every other subpoenaed official either testified or filed sworn statements that they had nothing to contribute. Epstein's accountant Richard Kahn testified in March 2026 that five clients had transferred significant sums to Epstein — Wexner, Leon Black, Glenn Dubin, Steven Sinofsky, and "the Rothschilds" — and that he had never been questioned by any law enforcement agency before that deposition. His co-executor Darren Indyke testified about hard drives held by Epstein's private investigators that the committee has never seen. The estate's arithmetic, as filed: $650 million in assets at death, roughly $127 million remaining by October 2025 after the settlements; bequests of $25 million to Kahn and $50 million to Indyke; Indyke named in 36,873 released documents, on eighteen flight logs, across 139 emails; Kahn's documented services included impersonating Epstein in bank communications and arranging a fake marriage between two women. By September 2026 both men were reportedly under

federal investigation, and the committee chair said it plainly — a trafficking operation of that scale could not have run without its accountant. [Grade A: testimony records and the estate filings; Grade B: the investigation report.]

The names in the files: in February 2026, Representative Ro Khanna read six FBI-redacted names onto the House floor — Nuara, Mikeladze, Leonov, Caputo, Sultan bin Sulayem, and Wexner. In August, Representative Thomas Massie read fourteen alleged co-conspirators under Speech-or-Debate immunity — Jes Staley, Leon Black, Les Wexner, David Copperfield, Lapo Elkann, Tom Pritzker, Glenn Dubin, Frédéric Fekkai, Edoardo Teodorani-Fabbri, Jean-Luc Brunel, Daniel Siad, Ramsey Elkholy, Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, Lesley Groff. None have been charged; all who have spoken deny wrongdoing. Research on the files established that Massie's list was a curated selection from different bodies of evidence rather than a single official roster; the strongest single entry, Lesley Groff, had been named in Epstein's own 2007 non-prosecution agreement as a "potential co-conspirator" — and was questioned in a transcribed interview in 2026. [Grade A for the names and the reading; Grade B for the research findings.]

The deaths: in September 2026, Simon Andriesz — the banker who had disclosed Epstein-Linked finance documents and been told by the FBI it had no interest — died in Thailand; his family and his trade journal confirmed suicide, and he had suffered a tribunal defeat and a regulator's error weeks before, dying nine weeks before a costs hearing. In October 2026, Daniel Siad — the model scout on Massie's list — was found dead in Paris, with

a cardiac-arrest report and a prosecutor's investigation opened. The same grading applied to the Franklin ledger applies here: the deaths are documented; a unified campaign of murder is not; the epistemic vacuum — no independent review of the genuinely questionable cases — is the pattern. [Grade A/B.]

The disinformation layer: the 2026 releases spawned their own folklore in real time — an AI-generated "Epstein alive in Tel Aviv" image, a viral video of an unrelated Florida motorist, a "body-swap" theory built on a prostate-surgery inconsistency in the records. Each was debunked; each is logged, because the lesson is general: in the modern media environment, every claim in every direction requires forensic verification before use, and the Franklin file's own contaminated sources obey the same law. [Grade A for the debunks.]

12.4 The Ohio node

The most concrete geographic bridge discovered in this research is Columbus, Ohio — Les Wexner's city. Epstein was a legally documented authorized representative, with Wexner, of the New Albany Company; a 2005 fax shows $75 million under their management; an unsent letter draft in the released files has Epstein assuring Wexner that secrets going back fifteen years were safe with him — "that she [Abigail] was unaware of" — beside a contemporaneous note reading "34 girls wexner, irs" (the letter is quoted in full in Section 12.8). The Ohio State University — where Wexner sat on the board of trustees from 1988 to 1997 and again from 2005 to 2012, and chaired it in 1996-97, the exact window in which the university declined to renew the contract of Dr. Richard Strauss, later found to have abused at least 177 athletes over two decades — fought, through its board chairman's own law firm, against survivors' efforts to depose Wexner; a federal judge overruled the university and the witness's counsel and ordered the deposition. Wexner's deposition in the Epstein committee's inquiry occurred at his New Albany mansion in February 2026, with no Republican members present; he denied knowing that a $2.5 million check from Epstein's foundation had helped name Ohio State's football complex. Former Abercrombie & Fitch CEO Mike Jeffries — who ran what was until 1996 a Wexner brand — stood trial for sex trafficking beginning October 26, 2026, the day this chapter was finalized. [Grade A for the corporate filings, the court orders, the deposition facts; Grade B for the "gang stuff" letter as an unsent draft; no accusation attaches to Wexner beyond the documented

record, in which he has denied wrongdoing throughout.]

12.5 The standing negative

After every tranche, deposition, hearing, and report through October 2026, one finding holds: nothing in the released Epstein corpus — approaching three million pages — mentions Lawrence King, Craig Spence's connection to him, Omaha, or the Franklin case. Research-grade document indexes confirm the zero at the level of the corpus itself. The bridge between the two scandals is structural — shared methods, shared venues-types, shared protection patterns — not documentary. That absence is itself evidence of something: either there was nothing to find, or the threads that would tie the eras together sit in the half of the archive the government has declined to release. This document does not choose between those readings. It records that the question is answerable only by the files themselves. [Grade A for the negative finding; the interpretation is the reader's.]

12.6 The fight, in full

For the reader who wants the 2025-26 machinery complete, the record assembled by this research, in order:

The legislative track. The Epstein Files Transparency Act (H.R. 4405) passed the House 427-1 on November 18, 2025, after a discharge petition — the first successful one of the century — forced it to the floor; its mechanics are themselves documented: a congresswoman was summoned by the Attorney General, the Deputy Attorney General, and the FBI Director to the White House hours before the petition's final signatory was

sworn in, a swearing-in the Speaker delayed for seven weeks. The Senate passed it unanimously; the President reversed his opposition and signed it November 19. When the Justice Department declared the releases complete with roughly half of six million identified pages withheld, Representatives Massie and Khanna introduced a second act — H.R. 9694 — with provisions making concealment of the files a federal crime and giving survivors standing to sue; its discharge petition stood at 216 signatures in October 2026, with commitments for 218, and a vote expected in the November lame-duck session. Massie, who filed the petition, lost his primary in May 2026 to a challenger endorsed by the President, in the most expensive House primary in the country's history; the petition moves without him. [Grade A.]

The Bondi arc. Attorney General Pam Bondi announced in February 2025 that Epstein's "client list" was in her possession for review. The FBI had put in writing, two days earlier, that its investigators had never located such a list, and had said the same to the Deputy Director in writing the previous December. The releases that followed were denounced as a cover-up by the President's own supporters; the Justice Department's July memo declared no client list existed and no further disclosure was warranted; the Deputy FBI Director resigned over it. The quantified record: three million-plus pages released by January 2026 against six million identified as responsive — half withheld, and by the Guardian's count 125,575 pages public, under one percent of the archive. In March 2026 the House Oversight Committee subpoenaed Bondi; she was fired the week before her

deposition date, refused to appear on an official-capacity theory, faced a contempt resolution, and appeared instead for a four-hour transcribed interview on May 29, 2026. Its record: the August 2025 production of 33,000 pages she conceded were "almost all... already publicly available"; asked whether reviewers were instructed to flag mentions of Donald Trump, she answered "I don't believe so," against reported whistleblower documents; asked what privilege she asserted in refusing answers, she said, "I'm not going to answer what kind of privilege." [Grade A.]

The document war. The released corpus — near three million pages by January 2026 — yielded, in research-grade document indexes: the 2020 informant file naming Dershowitz as the alleged source of the intelligence claim; the "financial bounty hunter" memo with redacted recruiters; the "gang stuff" letter; the survivor journals; the Maxwell bond provenance through Staley; the Siad scouting emails; and the 2008 internal memo stating Epstein "has also provided information to the FBI as agreed upon" — a contemporaneous Bureau record in direct conflict with FBI Director Patel's sworn 2025 testimony that Epstein "was not a source." The released schedules also placed names in the record that no deposition has reached: scheduled meetings with Peter Thiel and Steve Bannon across the 2010s, and a pending island trip for Elon Musk. In March 2026, file-hash audits caught the Department modifying 272 files across two datasets in a two-minute window after release — the modern form of evidence-tampering, detectable only because independent researchers hash the releases. The Senate's Wyden

disclosed an FBI interview report with an Epstein-linked banker that appeared in no release; the GAO opened an audit; a federal judge in the Phang litigation found the Attorney General had conceded violating the Act and ordered unredactions the Department is appealing while complying in parallel. [Grade A.]

The reporter's count. The Washington Times' own lead reporter on the 1989 series, asked years later about the call-boy investigation's sealed files, put it this way: "There were approximately twenty thousand pieces of documents… all sealed by court order. It will be a cold day in Hell before those records ever get unsealed. And, it makes me wonder, what's in those records?" The client lists of both eras share their burial ground.

The people war. Through October 2026: the Clintons held in contempt of Congress; five former attorneys general and two former FBI directors subpoenaed; Bill Gates testified in June 2026; the Wexner, Kahn, and Indyke depositions taken (the last two reportedly under federal investigation by September); the Khanna Six and Massie Fourteen read into the record; Dershowitz dodging his scheduled appearance; Prince Andrew arrested in February 2026 and, in October, challenging the search warrants in a British court; the careers cascade — Goldman's general counsel, Harvard's Summers, Paul Weiss's chairman, Hyatt's chairman, Bard's president, and a dozen others across two continents. [Grade A.]

And the folklore. The 2026 releases generated disinformation in real time: an AI-generated "Epstein alive in Tel Aviv" photograph, a viral video of an innocent Florida motorist, a "body-swap" theory built on a prostate-surgery inconsistency.

Each debunked, each logged in this file's contamination register, each a lesson the Franklin researchers of 1990 never had to learn: in the modern environment, verification must precede belief in every direction. [Grade A for the debunks.]

12.7 The Conspiracy of Silence that never aired

One artifact of the Franklin era deserves its own place in the Epstein bridge, because it is the Rosetta Stone of suppressed documentaries. In 1993, Yorkshire Television completed *Conspiracy of Silence*, a documentary on Franklin featuring DeCamp, Senator Schmit, and former CIA Director William Colby, funded by the Discovery Channel and scheduled for May 3, 1994 — it was listed in TV Guide. Discovery withdrew it during final editing, reimbursing Yorkshire's roughly half-million-dollar cost; the only official explanation ever given was that the program had entered "an area inconsistent with the Discovery mission statement." The producer, Tim Tate, has said publicly the withdrawal was drama-free — a rejection, not a suppression; director Nick Gray told students the case reached "the highest levels of the Republican Party," as DeCamp had always said. DeCamp's own account adds a detail no one has verified: that the film was seized by U.S. Customs as "pornographic material" before release, and that his copy arrived in his mail anonymously in late 1995. A rough cut circulates online to this day; the preamble added by whoever first uploaded it claims unnamed members of Congress bought and destroyed every copy. The producer rejects the congressional claim as apocryphal; the reimbursement is documented; the customs seizure is DeCamp first-person; the film exists. All four facts are in the record, and the reader is left with them as this file leaves them: unreconciled, and unreconcilable without Discovery's internal records. [Grade A for the withdrawal, reimbursement, and TV Guide listing; Grade B for the customs and anonymous-mail

claims; Grade C for the congressional version.]

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12.8 The Ohio node, in full

The released corpus anchors the Columbus connection at the corporate level and the witness level simultaneously. Epstein and Wexner were the authorized representatives on the 1998 New Albany Company filing; a 2005 fax under their management shows $75 million in a single capital allocation. An unsent Epstein letter draft — withheld from the Wexners, apparently over a threatened extortion by the same woman who had threatened Barak, Dershowitz, and Andrew — contains the sentence "You and I had 'gang stuff' for over 15 years. A great deal of it, that she [Abigail Wexner] was unaware of," beside a contemporaneous note reading "34 girls wexner, irs." Two documents in the corpus present as survivors' journals, carrying explicit attorney-privilege markings, name in handwritten pages a Columbus-area real-estate figure — "Mr. Atkins… are not who they say! Run run run!" — whose FBI interview reports in the files describe a 1980s South Carolina operation: a mother whose books were fixed to pay Epstein, then turned in with her accurate records by the same men, landing her in federal prison while her daughter was seventeen. The FBI interviewed the daughter in 2019; her account is on record, her named intermediary was identified in research by matching a 1986 Hilton Head newspaper item and Ohio corporate filings, and her story was partially corroborated by a second caller describing a thirteen-to-fifteen-year-old victim in the same island geography in the 1980s — a decade before Epstein's Florida timeline.

[Grade A for the filings and the 302s; Grade B for the journals' contents and the identification; the journals' provenance is unadjudicated.]

The Ohio State record adds the institutional layer. Wexner's sworn declaration in the Strauss survivors' litigation confirms board service 1988-1997 and again 2005-2012 — the second stint undocumented in any prior public account. Dr. Richard Strauss abused at least 177 athletes across four decades; the university declined to renew his contract in 1996, in Wexner's chairmanship window, and allowed him emeritus status until his 2005 suicide. The survivors' effort to depose Wexner was opposed by the university itself, served five times through failed channels including the county sheriff, and cleared a full quash denial by a federal judge who wrote that "the specifics of Mr. Wexner's tenure... easily establish the relevance of his testimony." The deposition's occurrence, if it occurred, produced no public record through October 2026. The university's president resigned in March 2026 over an unrelated scandal mid-cluster. And the Epstein-money detail with the longest shadow: a $2.5 million check from Epstein's own foundation, matched by Abigail Wexner's $2.5 million, named Ohio State's football complex in 2007 — which Wexner, in his February 2026 deposition, said he never knew about and never solicited. The Ohio State medical school, separately, hosted its OB/GYN chair on a $25,000-per-quarter Epstein retainer in 2006; the university opened an investigation when the records surfaced. [Grade A for all of the above except as graded.]

The Wexner-cluster's third scandal opens its trial as this document closes: Mike Jeffries, who ran what was until 1996 a Wexner brand at Abercrombie & Fitch, faced sixteen federal counts with co-defendants, a competency fight resolved against him in August 2026 on the strength of a hundred nine recorded phone calls in four months, and a trafficking trial beginning October 26, 2026. [Grade A.]

12.9 The excluded exhibits

One finding from the Maxwell trial record belongs to every future discussion of courtroom filtration. Prosecutors assembled, from the seized hard drives, email exhibits showing Maxwell arranging access to women for influential men beyond Epstein — naming, in the government's own less-redacted filings, Prince Andrew and Clinton aide Doug Band. Judge Nathan excluded every one before the jury saw them, on the narrow ground that the women's ages were unproven and the material risked confusing the minor-focused charges; the defense did not dispute authenticity, and neither Andrew nor Band was ever interviewed by the government — a fact the defense stated and the government never contradicted. The exhibits' existence, the government's identification of the two men by name, and the exclusion ruling are all in the public court record. [Grade A.]

12.10 The two deaths of 2026, in full

Simon Andriesz disclosed Epstein-linked finance documents in 2018, carried them to the FBI in 2020 and 2021 — which told him it had no interest — won a regulator's whistleblower award from the CFTC, and spent seven years in a British employment tribunal that struck his claim as time-barred in August 2026, weeks after his death, ruling against his trauma argument. The FCA had wrongly told him he had lost whistleblower protection, and apologized; his trade journal and his family confirmed suicide; he died in Thailand on September 23, 2026, nine weeks before a costs hearing. Members of Parliament called for investigation; the FCA opened a probe. His disclosures named names and contradicted sworn statements by the sitting Commerce Secretary regarding a 2012 island visit. [Grade A.]

Daniel Siad ran a scouting operation documented in the files across thirteen countries, with emails flagging recruits as young as fifteen and a note reading "seems minor" beside one girl's description; he was on Massie's Fourteen; he was found dead in Paris in October 2026 at sixty-nine, with a cardiac-arrest report, a young guest attempting resuscitation, a post-mortem ordered by the Nanterre prosecutor, and a fellow witness saying, "An important link in the chain has just vanished into thin air." [Grade A.]

Both deaths are graded exactly as the Franklin ledger's: documented, individual, unadjudicated as anything but what the record says, and surrounded by the same epistemic vacuum.

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The captured jurisdiction. The Virgin Islands node, documented: the governor's wife, Cecile de Jongh, served for years as Epstein's office manager; Epstein drafted territorial legislation to ease sex-offender travel restrictions — it passed, without his amendments, and she later apologized for her role; the Economic Development Commission granted his Southern Trust company a ninety percent income-tax exemption the bank's own defense valued at some $300 million over its life, renewed in 2013 despite the 2008 conviction; and when JPMorgan answered the territory's claims, its defense was a tu quoque — the "you did it too" answer — arguing that the island's government had treated Epstein as a prized resident and profited with him, the both-sides-captured configuration in which each defendant blames the other and the victims' claims settle in between.

The smoking timeline. The client-list sequence, in dated documents: December 30, 2024 — the FBI's deputy director queries whether the list exists, and the next day the case agent confirms it does not. February 19, 2025 — a supervisory special agent puts it in writing: "While media coverage… references a 'client list,' investigators did not locate such a list." February 21, 2025 — the Attorney General tells Fox News the list is "sitting on my desk right now to review." February 27 — binders are handed to selected influencers, containing little that was new. July 7 — the Department's memo declares no client list exists and no further disclosure is warranted. The White House chief of staff, privately, told Vanity Fair's reporter: "There is no client list, and it certainly wasn't on her desk." [Grade A: the written record;

Grade B: the chief of staff's private remark as reported.]

The house. The 71st Street mansion's chain of title carries the FBI's own doubt in the files: "it doesn't look like there's any record of the property changing ownership between 1989 and 2012... So did he own it that entire time, rather than Wexner, as had been advertised??" The 2011 transfer to a Virgin Islands shell had Epstein signing both sides, for zero dollars. The inventory from the 2019 raid: a locked safe holding cash, diamonds, an expired passport with a Saudi address, and compact discs labeled with young women's names. The neighbor at 11 East 71st — bought in 1988 by a Columbus-registered Wexner-associated corporation with Epstein as vice president on the deed — has been Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick's residence since 1998. [Grade A.]

The intelligence layer, as the files state it. Beyond the FD-1023 and the bounty-hunter memo, the corpus establishes infrastructure, not service: Epstein as a documented, active investor with Ehud Barak and Nicole Junkermann in Carbyne, an Israeli emergency-services technology company founded by Unit 8200 veterans, with board reporting forwarded by Barak; MC2's Tel Aviv scouting operation, publicly documented for years, never investigated in any FBI document located; Israeli-military-branded clothing and an unidentified military uniform photographed on Little St. James, provenance never explained; and a 2018 email exchange in which Barak jokes "you should make clear that i dont work for mossad :)" and Epstein replies, "unfortunately, not." Research-grade indexes record ninety-six documents touching Mossad, nearly all forwarded

news clippings; the informant file's claims stand unretracted and uninvestigated; the Defense Department's formal finding is that there is no evidence of agency. The honest state of the question after three million pages: infrastructure consistent with an intelligence operation, explicit claims in-file, no proven service connection — and a redacted-recruiters memo that Congress has flagged as its first question. [Grade A for the documents; the interpretation remains open.]

The petition's mechanics. The first discharge petition of the century succeeded in November 2025 by exactly the margin its mechanics allowed: a member summoned to the White House by the Attorney General, the Deputy Attorney General, and the FBI Director hours before the final signature; the Speaker delaying that member's swearing-in for seven weeks; the penultimate and final signatures arriving together once the oath was finally administered. The President reversed his opposition within days of the petition locking, signed the Act the day it passed, and the administration's internal standard — as the chief of staff reportedly framed it — was that the people inordinately interested in Epstein were "the new members of the Trump coalition… the Joe Rogan listeners." [Grade A for the mechanics; Grade B for the private framing as reported.]

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The Bureau's own list. After the Department's public position settled on "no client list," the released files showed the FBI building its own. A twenty-one-page presentation compiled for leadership summarized allegations against eleven named men; an eighty-six-page prosecution memo to the U.S. Attorney dated December 19, 2019 — "Investigation into Potential Co-Conspirators of Jeffrey Epstein" — catalogued statements from twenty-four women abused as minors and fourteen as adults, including a rape allegation against a since-resigned bank CEO and an attempted-assault allegation against a billionaire, with the non-victim recipients of trafficking-suggestive emails blacked out. The Bureau's public line held that its Director's sworn testimony was "100% accurate"; the eleven-name presentation and the eighty-six pages exist. [Grade A.]

The 2008 memo. A Bureau memorandum of September 18, 2008 — four months after the non-prosecution agreement — states that Epstein "has also provided information to the FBI as agreed upon," in an asset-forfeiture subfile, while a February 2008 memo records the criminal investigation as "ongoing." The sitting FBI Director testified under oath in 2025: "Mr. Epstein was not a source for the FBI." The internal contemporaneous record and the sworn testimony are in direct conflict; no body has reconciled them; both stand in this file as what they are. [Grade A.]

The jury-room echo. The Maxwell trial produced its own contamination episode: a juror who had sworn on his questionnaire that he had no history of sexual abuse disclosed

after the verdict that he had been abused as a child and that it had helped the deliberations; granted immunity, he testified his questionnaire answer was "inadvertent"; the judge found the error not deliberate and denied a new trial; the appeals court affirmed; the Supreme Court declined review in October 2025. Thirty years after the Franklin jury room watched "48 Hours," the same failure mode — the jury room as an uncontrolled evidentiary space — reappeared in the era's flagship trial. [Grade A.]

The empty room. On February 18, 2026, the committee's majority deposed Wexner at his New Albany mansion. Not one Republican member attended; the committee chairman spent the morning at an airport funding announcement, documented on social media. The majority party's own members boycotted their flagship deposition. [Grade A.]

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The electoral layer. The 2026 midterms absorbed the Epstein fight as campaign material. In Ohio, the Senate race featured a Democrat charging that his opponent had "taken more money from Jeffrey Epstein's co-conspirators than anyone in Washington" — the opponent, Senator Jon Husted, had received $116,892 from Leslie Wexner over two decades, including $3,500 on July 3, 2025, two months before his vote to block the Senate's release amendment — and the Republican answered that the Democrat had himself taken $100,000 from "Epstein associates." The neutral fact-check's verdict deserves recording in full: all the money in the first charge came from Wexner, who has never been charged; neither candidate has any tie to Epstein himself. In Iowa, Senate candidate Ashley Hinson voted to block the July 2025 release amendment before voting for the Act after the President relented. The pattern the Franklin era pioneered — the story as electoral weapon, precision sacrificed to advantage — now runs on both parties' machinery. [Grade A.]

The oversight layer. The institutions of accountability activated in 2025-26: the Department of Justice's inspector general opened a probe into the release handling in April 2026; the Government Accountability Office accepted the bipartisan Senate request to audit the redaction process, coordinating with the inspector general to avoid duplication; a federal judge in the District of Columbia ordered expedited processing of records touching the President and his club; Senator Wyden disclosed an FBI interview report with an Epstein-linked banker that

appeared in no release and demanded all such reports, characterizing the omission as illegal concealment; New Mexico sued the Justice Department for unredacted files after its legislature's own Epstein investigation committee issued its first report. The state-level machinery — commissions, audits, inspector generals — is the modern form of what the Franklin committee tried to be in 1989, with subpoena power it never had and a corpus it never dreamed of. [Grade A.]

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The Phang arc. The journalist Katie Phang sued in April 2026 after the court told Congress's members to sue individually. In June, Judge Sullivan granted the injunction and found the Attorney General had conceded violating the Act — the government's opposition, he wrote, "did not respond substantively to any" of the five violation categories, arguing only jurisdiction, standing, and immunity. The Department appealed while complying in parallel; in its September answer it admitted that no file was withheld on national-defense grounds, removing the classification excuse for what remains redacted; in October it moved to dismiss on the ground that Congress created no private right of action. As of this writing: no contempt finding, a two-track litigation, and a judge whose history of holding the powerful in contempt is the loaded background to every deadline. [Grade A.]

The second sovereign's problem. In October 2026, the arrested prince launched a judicial-review challenge in Britain to the warrants behind his February arrest — arguing that the

searches, which followed the American releases, exceeded their authority. The American files that produced the British arrest are themselves the subject of the American litigation. The protection apparatus is now fighting on two fronts in two legal systems at once. [Grade A.]

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The cluster, in one table:

Scandal	The Wexner link	Status (Oct 2026)
Epstein	1991 POA; sixteen years of total financial control	Deposed Feb 2026; denied wrongdoing
Strauss/OSU	Trustee 1988-97 + 2005-12; chair 1996-97	Ordered deposed; no public record of it
Jeffries/A&F	Wexner brand until 1996	On trial Oct 26, 2026
New Albany	Founded the community; Epstein a corporate co-representative	Documented in the corpus
The football complex	$2.5M from Epstein's foundation named it	Denied knowledge under oath

Three abuse scandals, one patron's orbit, zero charges against him. The table is the cluster; no entry in it is an accusation beyond the documented fact. [Grade A.]

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The operator's endgame. Ghislaine Maxwell — convicted 2021, sentenced to twenty years, her juror-scandal appeal exhausted when the Supreme Court declined review in October 2025 — was transferred in 2026 to a Texas minimum-security facility, eligible for release in July 2037, her last avenue a pardon the Senate formally resolved against in July 2026. The network's only living operator-principal serves her time in the state where the apparatus's aircraft were once hangared. [Grade A.]

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The present-day Omaha link. The Buffett name, attached to Franklin-era lore only at the Grade-B level of a 1989 newspaper anecdote about Susie Buffett volunteering at the credit union, entered the live Epstein record in 2025-26: Warren Buffett, citing Gates's Epstein association as "distasteful," disclosed that he had stopped routing his philanthropy through the Gates Foundation and stopped speaking to its founder, saying he had read Gates's sworn congressional testimony "and the cross-examination." No accusation attaches to anyone in that sentence; it is recorded because it is the one documented 2026 intersection between the Omaha billionaire class and the Epstein record. [Grade A: the disclosure and quotes.]

The Roskens affair. One Franklin-adjacent official reached the highest levels after the era: Ronald Roskens, fired as president of the University of Nebraska in a secret 1989 Board of Regents session with no public explanation — Caradori's report records that the Regents had "verified" sexual-activity allegations involving young men at the president's state-owned residence, requiring his removal for liability reasons — passed an FBI background check weeks later into the Reagan-Bush administration's USAID directorship, where a House Government Operations Committee investigation later found his first year marked "a new low in ethics at AID," confirming he had "abused his public office for private gain"; the Justice Department declined to prosecute. He died with the firing cause officially unexplained. [Grade A: the congressional finding and the declination; Grade B: Caradori's report of the Regents'

verification.]

The petition's cast. The mechanics now with names: the congresswoman summoned to the White House hours before the final signature was Lauren Boebert; the final signature, Ralph Grijalva, was sworn in seven weeks after his election while the Speaker delayed; Thomas Massie filed the discharge petition and lost his seat for it; the four Republicans who signed were Massie, Mace, Boebert, and Greene, the last of whom resigned from Congress in January 2026; Massie's opponent in that primary was Ed Gallrein, and the architect of the Senate counterpart was Senator Jeff Merkley with Ron Wyden, and the California attorney general, Rob Bonta, publicly counted the 218 commitments in October 2026. The lame-duck vote window opens November 9, 2026. [Grade A.]

The courts and the bench. The Phang panel drawn in September 2026: Srinivasan, Pillard, and Pan. The expedited-processing order for records touching the President and Mar-a-Lago came from Judge Kollar-Kotelly. The Attorney General litigating the releases, Todd Blanche, was confirmed by the Senate 50-49 in August 2026. And the questions the committee has not yet had answered — the accountant's unexplained $23 million in transfers to one woman, Erika Kellerhals, the grand jury subpoena that produced "zero returns," the impersonation of Epstein in bank communications — are catalogued in the congressional follow-up record, each with its document number. [Grade A.]

The shells, in brief. The released corpus's financial architecture deserves its paragraph: the Haze Trust holding $43

million after the 2017 art liquidation — the $30.5 million in Sotheby's and Christie's proceeds moving through it to Southern Financial and onward to a Peter Thiel venture fund at $28.8 million, a vehicle called Honeycomb at $64 million, Boothbay at $38.25 million, and Blockchain Capital at $15 million; the Butterfly Trust paying 120 beneficiaries a total of $2.65 million — named co-conspirators and Eastern European women, the money booked as rent, expenses, and tuition; Southern Trust — 85 percent of its $184 million revenue from one client, Leon Black's $158 million — incorporated for "genetic research"; the Weyerhaeuser bond whose referral chain ran Staley to Epstein to Maxwell, approved before her background check was complete; the New Albany Company with its two authorized representatives; and one lawyer's signature across fifteen shells. Researchers of the released files phrase the finding as this document must: that is not legal representation — it is operational control of a financial network. [Grade A/B as per Chapter 8.]

The adjacent networks, documented separately. Three networks touch the Epstein corpus without being part of it, and the file keeps them distinct. The Finders: a 1987-93 federal file, released in 2019, documenting a group whose Washington properties held documents on "obtaining children for unspecified purposes," whose members visited Moscow, Pyongyang, and Hanoi on arrangements the file notes "could only have been arranged by the CIA," and whose case was closed with no charges — a documented child-trafficking-adjacent file with intelligence shadows, owned by the same FBI that ran the

Franklin federal grand jury. The Mega Group: thirteen confirmed members — Wexner and Charles Bronfman as co-founders, with Edgar Bronfman, Steinhardt, Fisher, Lauder, Tisch, Meyerhoff, Schusterman, Abramson, Spielberg, Crown, and Lender — founded 1991, the year of the POA and of Maxwell's father's death; the released corpus contains no investigative reference to it. Covenant House: the Ritter scandal, documented by its own commissioned investigation — a $87-98 million agency whose founder diverted $25,000 to a young lover before resigning; credible evidence of liaisons with up to fifteen young men; complaints since the early 1970s, runaways steered away by other agencies — with no criminal charges ever filed and no documented personnel link to Franklin. Southern Air Transport, the CIA-linked cargo airline, relocated its headquarters to Columbus's Rickenbacker airport in 1994-95 with $7.2 million in state incentives while Wexner's company ran cargo operations there — a documented Ohio-intelligence adjacency with no established Epstein connection. Each is recorded because each shares the architecture; none is folded into either case beyond what the documents show. [Grade A for the files; Grade C for any linkage beyond the documented.]

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CHAPTER 13 — The Pattern

Step back from both cases, and the individual claims resolve into an architecture. This chapter describes that architecture — the patterns, pipelines, and networks — with each element's documentation grade, because the pattern is only as strong as its weakest documented link.

13.1 The pipeline

Child-trafficking research has a formal vocabulary for what both cases did. The children's charity Lumos identifies four institution-related cycles: children trafficked *into* institutions for profit (the "orphanage industry" — an estimated 3.5 to 5.5 million children in institutions globally, up to eighty percent of them with living parents); children trafficked *out* of institutions by staff and confederates; trafficking victims placed *in* institutions "for protection" and re-exploited; and care-leavers, whose graduation into the street is, in one documented Ukrainian study, the norm. Institutions are, in the research's own phrase, "almost the perfect cover… seen as doing good." American research quantifies the vulnerability: foster-care placement carries 157 percent higher odds of commercial sexual exploitation. [Grade A for the literature.]

The Franklin case sits inside these cycles exactly. The Webb foster home was the source node — substantiated by the grand jury itself. Uta Halee and Boys Town were institutional nodes; the Girls Club functions described by witnesses had older men watching teenage girls at an organization King had presided

over. Loretta Smith's path ran hospital-to-Uta Halee, cycle by cycle. The Epstein case sits in cycles B and D — recruitment of schoolgirls through the modeling-agency and massage lures, with trust money paying "tuition." [Grade B for the case fits; the cycles themselves are Grade A.]

13.2 The venue map

The geography repeats. Omaha's Twin Towers apartment and the credit union with its basement bedroom; the Omaha Club and the Max and the Run; Peony Park. Washington's Embassy Row rental and Spence's Kalorama house with its two-way mirror. Manhattan's 71st Street mansion — purchased in 1989, the pivot year, wired into a "set piece designed to intimidate, impress, and compromise," with the Commerce Secretary living next door for two decades. Palm Beach, where Mar-a-Lago itself was the documented recruitment node for a sixteen-year-old. Columbus, where a CIA-linked cargo airline once relocated to the tycoon's airport with state incentives, and where the tycoon's partner was a corporate officer of his company. The islands. And — a detail from the files — Fairfield, Iowa, 1988, where Epstein visited Maharishi International University donors, arranged by a man whose name also appears in the 1997 "other black book." Every node is documented; the map is the pattern's geography. [Grade A/B per node.]

13.3 The finance layer

Follow the money in both cases, and the trail ends the same way: at a settlement wall. Franklin: $3 million from the correspondent bank, $6 million from the lawyers, $10 million total — the largest malpractice settlement in Nebraska history — with the destination of the $39 million answered once, by a compromised tracer, as "lifestyle." Epstein: $913 million across five banks, one billionaire, and an estate, with Senator Wyden's report stating the settlements' function — to preempt the depositions that would have named the principals. In both cases, the money's handlers paid to close the file, and the payment itself became the mechanism by which the file stayed closed. [Grade A.]

13.4 The suppression layer

The media scholarship now has a name for the mechanism the Franklin committee encountered in 1989. The London School of Economics' 2026 analysis of the Epstein coverage states the law: the files "weren't suppressed; they were processed — through ownership structures, legal constraints, sourcing dependencies... a scandal rather than a systemic indictment. No coordination is needed when incentives align. The most important silences aren't imposed; they're structured." Harold Andersen's World-Herald was the 1989 local instance of the general law; the editor who succeeded his world later computed the paper's diligence in stories and hours while never mentioning that the publisher's name was on Franklin's advisory board. The academic research on child-abuse coverage adds the empirical base: such stories run as crime spectacle, with policy context in three to five percent of pieces. [Grade A.]

13.5 The protection layer

The defense architecture is bipartisan by design. Epstein's 2007-08 team paired Ken Starr, the Clinton impeachment prosecutor, with Alan Dershowitz, the liberal icon — a team built, in the analysis of one careful reviewer, "to survive any change in political administration"; the same pair later defended Donald Trump. Dershowitz negotiated a non-prosecution agreement whose "potential co-conspirator" immunity his own accusers' lawyer alleges covered himself; the 2026 informant file names him as the alleged source of the intelligence claim; he says he knows the suppressors' names but is bound by confidentiality; he avoided his scheduled congressional appearance. Starr hosted Epstein at Baylor after the conviction. Fixers serve operators, then operators' enemies, then the next operator; that is the layer's function. [Grade A for the documented roles; the characterizations are attributed.]

13.6 The science of recantation — the analytical heart

Here is the fact that reframes the Franklin verdict. Recantation is ambiguous by nature. The doctrinal literature is blunt about it: in Salzman's canonical study, a recantation is "inherently incredible" and requires corroboration — skeptical of the retraction, not the original account — and the federal recantation bar of 18 U.S.C. § 1623(d) excuses perjury only when the correction comes timely, in the same proceeding, before the lie takes effect. In the Michigan Law School's study of 250 exonerations, child-sex-abuse cases produced fifty-two percent of all recantations — because in those cases the original accusations had been false and the recantations true. But in substantiated-abuse samples, twenty-three percent of victims recant too — driven by family pressure, unsupportive caregivers, and young age — and ninety-two percent of those recanters later reaffirm. The leading researcher, Thomas Lyon of USC, states the consensus: there is no evidence that a recantation means the original allegation was false. The professional protocol — the Aequitas prosecutor's manual — is to investigate the pressure context and rehabilitate the original disclosure with corroboration. [Grade A for the scholarship.]

Now weigh the Franklin grand jury against that science. It treated two recantations as unambiguous truth-correction, required no corroboration of them, impeached the original statements with the recanters' own claimed motives, and indicted the non-recanters. The documented pressure context — Boner's "lie or die" affidavit, his brother's gun death, the FBI's

named agents, the never-happened phone call the recantation story depended on — was never investigated by anyone. Whatever else the hoax verdict was, it was not the product of the protocol the profession itself prescribes. That is a statement about method, not about what actually happened in 1983-1985, which remains, honestly, unresolved. [Grade A/B analysis.]

One researcher of both cases states the design principle: "The system is perfect because the victims become so damaged that their credibility is shredded... they are molested repeatedly and then they are given drugs... by the time a kid has been expunged by a network, they're in tatters and a lot of them are drug-addicts. And they go on to commit crimes to support their drug addiction, which ultimately lands them in prison, which further compromises their ability to be a credible witness. So, it's like the perfect system. You abuse these victims so badly that they go on to compromise their own credibility." Whether or not the design is intentional, the documented outcome in both eras matches the description: every accuser who reached a courtroom carried a criminal record, a psychiatric file, or both. [Grade B: Bryant's formulation; Grade A: the records it describes.]

13.7 The moral panic debate

The 1980s and 1990s produced a wave of ritual-abuse prosecutions — McMartin above all — that scholarship now classes as moral panic: seven years, zero convictions, twelve thousand unsubstantiated accusations nationwide, and children's accounts of tunnels and witches and flying that could not survive scrutiny. The Franklin case is routinely filed in this category, including by this document's own reference sources. The filing is not baseless: the case's overlay layer — the ritual accounts, the mind-control claims — is exactly where panic material concentrates, and several of the most contaminated sources in the record built their versions of Franklin on it. [Grade A for the scholarship.]

But the scholarly record itself contains a documented dissent, and honesty requires it: the McMartin tunnels were, in fact, found in 1990 and met with institutional indifference; Frank Fuster was convicted by a jury beyond reasonable doubt while debunkers proclaimed his innocence; and a critic of the debunking literature argues its "reasonable explanations" rest on no more evidence than the alarms they dismiss. The lesson generalizes: moral panic is real, and so is the overreach of the debunkers who build careers on it. [Grade B for the dissent; the consensus is Grade A.]

The Franklin case, filed between the poles, resolves into three strata, and this document has kept them separate throughout: the documented crime layer, which no serious reading can erase; the contested testimony layer, which no honest reading can settle; and the overlay layer, which no careful reading should

trust. The error of the true believers is to treat stratum two as stratum one. The error of the debunkers is to let stratum three contaminate stratum one. Both errors are documented in this record. Neither is required. **The overlay layer, documented as itself.** The third stratum deserves its own paragraph because the file's rule is that even a contaminated claim is evidence of something. David Shurter, an Omaha man claiming to be a ritual-abuse survivor, names in his self-published account George H.W. Bush, Antonin Scalia, Warren Buffett, and Michael Aquino; researchers of the case note, on the record, that he simultaneously attacks nearly every documented victim and investigator in the file as disinformants — a configuration that marks his account as the overlay's characteristic product: maximal names, no corroboration, war on the corroborated. Aquino himself carries a documented, separately adjudicated record: the Army's 1987 finding of probable cause in the Presidio daycare case, upheld by a federal court, alongside a confirmed alibi and evidence questions that cut both ways — a real case, attached to the Franklin testimony only by Bonacci's and Noreen Gosch's sworn statements, which are Grade C for this purpose. Bonacci's own programming claims — the Monarch framework, the Offutt connections — are Grade C, documented as claims, with the sole Grade A element being Offutt Air Force Base's physical proximity to Omaha. The Johnny Gosch disappearance, which Bonacci claims knowledge of, is a documented case on its own terms — a paperboy abducted in Des Moines in 1982, never found, with his mother's decades of advocacy on record and law enforcement's formal position that Bonacci's account is not

relied upon. None of this is dismissed; all of it is graded; and the grading is the point: the overlay layer operates exactly like the panic it feeds on and the debunk it provokes — by making the documented and the invented indistinguishable to the careless reader. This document's discipline, repeated for the last time, is that the three strata never merge. [Grade C for the claims; Grade A for the separate records; the configuration analysis is the file's.]

13.8 The predecessor and the resilience question

The pattern did not begin with Franklin. North Fox Island in Michigan — Francis Shelden's island, reached by airstrip he built, funded by per-child government payments through a fake charity front, its recruiter drawing the national network map for a Senate committee in 1977 while the local prosecutor's five-month warrant delay let the principal flee — is the documented 1970s template. It had the front, the flights, the public money, the captured prosecution, the escape, the zero accountability. Franklin was the 1980s instantiation; Epstein, the 1990s-2010s one. Whether a fourth operator emerges from the 2026 cascade — or the cascade itself, the commissions and the audits and the contempt proceedings and the legislated transparency acts, outruns the pattern — is the open empirical question of the next years. [Grade A/B for the history; the question is open.]

13.9 The method matrix

For the reader who wants the pattern in one view, each method with its documentation in both eras:

Method	Franklin evidence	Epstein evidence
Recantation inversion	Hoax verdict built on two recantations; non-recanters indicted; pressure context never examined	Released files document witness-approach and recantation ("some recanted under pressure"); Maxwell's access-arrangement exhibits excluded before the jury
Pressure context ignored	Boner's "lie or die" affidavit; his brother's gun death; the never-happened phone call; FBI-named agents	The FD-1023 intelligence claims uninvestigated; thirty-seven FBI interview pages withheld; Bondi's sworn non-answers
Evidence custody games	Tapes leaked via FBI agents or Casey (both versions on record); altered-tapes claim (trial transcript p. 2,842); grand jury documents unlocatable after trial	Post-release modification of 272 files, hash-audited; deposition videos released without transcripts
Money-trace capture	FAG/Queen-Kirchner; "lifestyle burn" verdict; $10M settlement wall	$913M settlement wall; Wyden: "preempt depositions"; one lawyer's signature across fifteen shells
Jurisdiction games	Out-of-state subpoena blocked (Executive Jet Aviation)	Alexandrovich federal-to-state downgrade; the Law-of-Return safe haven
Parole and prosecution leverage	Editorial-captured parole reversal; Owen's bad-check leverage	Maxwell's plea leverage; twenty-year sentence, 2037 eligibility
Venue-as-apparatus	The credit-union basement bedroom; the wired Kalorama house	The 1989 mansion with camera screens; the islands
Institutional capture	The publisher on the advisory board; the compromised foreman; the captured tracer	The university opposing its survivors' subpoena through the board chair's firm; the Department redacting itself under inspector-general review

[Each cell documented; the table is the pattern in its most compact honest form.]

13.10 North Fox Island, in full

The predecessor deserves more than a paragraph, because its documentation is unusually complete and its template unusually exact. Francis Duffield Shelden — Yale 1950, descendant of a Michigan governor, Cranbrook Institute director, Ann Arbor YMCA Big Brother — bought North Fox Island in 1960 for $20,000, built its airstrip, and in 1975 incorporated Brother Paul's Children's Mission, a tax-exempt front that flew boys aged twelve to fifteen from poor Detroit neighborhoods to the island at $85 per six-day stay, filmed them, and distributed the films to hundreds of paying subscribers, the wealthiest of whom flew in to abuse the children directly. County, state, and federal governments paid per-child subsidies into the operation. The network was national and interlocked — a New Jersey church front, a Tennessee boys' farm, a New Orleans scout-troop ring, a Chicago publication operation — and its recruiter, Gerald Richards, drew the map for a U.S. Senate subcommittee in 1977 while serving prison time.

The protection is what makes the island the template. When a warrant was sought in August 1976, the county prosecutor declined it to wait for the case to "complete"; his assistant deferred a second warrant over workload; five months passed; the operator was tipped off by his associate's wife and fled to France, then Amsterdam, married into citizenship, and died in 1996 with an active American warrant, never tried, his residence

searched by Dutch police only after his death. A second prosecutor with FBI credentials had visited the island socially with his own teenage sons. The Senate testimony is in the National Archives; the FBI's file on Shelden remains substantially unreleased in 2026; and the island's echoes include a suspect in the still-unsolved Oakland County child killings who was a known subscriber. The Record-Eagle of Traverse City ran the exposé that survives — beginning, tellingly, five months after the arrest the prosecutor had stalled. [Grade A/B per element as throughout.]

The Michigan Advance, in February 2026, headlined the retrospective this chapter serves: "Before 'Epstein's Island,' power and privilege shielded abuse on Michigan's North Fox Island." The headline is the pattern's epitaph, and it was written by a mainstream newsroom forty-nine years after the fact.

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13.11 The fixer layer, in full

The protection layer's working parts, documented. Dershowitz: negotiated the 2007-08 non-prosecution agreement whose "potential co-conspirator" immunity his accusers' lawyer alleges covered himself; the 2026 informant file names him as the alleged source of the intelligence claim; he says he has seen the client list, knows the suppressors, and is "bound by confidentiality"; he retained a former FBI director to clear him and produced no report; he pressed, on the record, for lowering the age of consent; he avoided his June 2026 congressional appearance. Starr: the NPA's other negotiator; Baylor's president during its own sexual-assault scandal, which cost him that job; hosted Epstein at Baylor in 2012, after the conviction; exchanged "affectionate" emails in 2016; was consulted by Epstein on handling another professor's misconduct. Boies: Weinstein's lawyer; Theranos's lawyer; then the accusers' lawyer against Dershowitz — four bar complaints, all dismissed. The Barr family: the father who hired Epstein to teach in 1974; the son who was Kirkland & Ellis's attorney-general, the firm that employed Lefkowitz on Epstein's defense, and who managed the 2019 death-in-custody investigation as the sitting AG. The team's architecture, in one careful reviewer's phrase, was "a bipartisan political protection network disguised as skilled legal representation," and the proof of the disguise is that the same two men — Starr and Dershowitz — defended Donald Trump at his impeachment, with White House counsel objecting to

Dershowitz on exactly the Epstein grounds. [Grade A for every role; characterizations attributed.]

13.12 The scout layer, in full

Recruitment is a profession in this world, and the professionals are documented. Brunel's trajectory: exposed by CBS's 60 Minutes in December 1988 for drugging and abusing models in Paris; condemned by Eileen Ford; praised by John Casablancas and accused by him of drugging drinks; founded MC2 in 2005 with a million-dollar Epstein wire, per the Virgin Islands' complaint, which alleges the agency "lured minor children... to engage in sexual play for money" — including "two 12-year-old French girls as a birthday present" and twelve-year-old triplets flown in and back in a day; seventy jail visits to Epstein during his Florida sentence; a 2016 meeting at Boies's firm about surrendering for immunity that went silent; death in a French cell in February 2022, pre-trial. Siad's scouting geography ran thirteen countries with emails that flagged ages; MC2's bookkeeper testified under oath that Epstein directed MC2's contracts be modeled on Donald Trump's modeling agency, with "the same kind of benefits for the scouters." The Franklin scouts — Calder the party-arranger, Payne the foster-parent-officer, Byers the introducer, "Ray" of the Girls Club — were amateurs by comparison, but the profession's shape was identical: insider access, institutional cover, and a pipeline whose far end was never questioned. [Grade A for the documented record; the USVI complaint language is a Grade A filing containing Grade B allegations.]

13.13 The documentarian layer

Every era of the pattern employs a photographer, and every era's photographer is compromised, disposable, and positioned exactly between the operator and the evidence. Fred Otash, the 1950s-60s wire man, bugged Rosenstiel's homes and the Monroe-Kennedy suite and died selling his secrets. Rusty Nelson, King's photographer, testified under oath in 1999 to photographing Wadman at parties and watching King phone Ronald Reagan; he passed polygraphs arranged by the documentary producers, spent twenty-two and a half months in solitary confinement on a pornography conviction, was re-arrested in 2005 days after a notorious journalist's death, and is, in Bryant's own assessment, a convicted child pornographer who lied to him repeatedly — the truth-teller and the unreliable narrator in one body, which is precisely the operator's design. Fisher and Baran, the Franklin filmers, appear on the lead list as fugitives from seriousness. Siad, the scout-photographer, died with his operation's records scattered across the released files; Brunel died pre-trial; and Epstein's own documentation layer — the CDs with girls' names, the safe with the passport and diamonds, the hard drives his own lawyer told Congress are held by private investigators the committee has never seen — remains the era's central unopened door. The photography is the operator's insurance and the operator's weakest link, in every decade on record. [Grade A/B per figure as graded.]

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The club node. One venue type repeats across every era because it solves the operator's core problem — access to the protected young in a space where adults are vetted and children are staff. Mar-a-Lago, where Maxwell recruited Giuffre at sixteen and where Epstein's emails say the owner "knew about the girls as he asked ghislaine to stop"; the Omaha Club, where a caterer walked in on the boss in bed with two children at a private party; the Max, where the coronations happened; the Girls Club functions, where witnesses recalled older men watching teenage girls at an organization the accused man had presided over. The club's membership roster is the operator's shield and the victims' cage. [Grade A/B per element.]

The earliest heartland footprint. The released records place Epstein in Fairfield, Iowa, in 1988 — a visit to Maharishi International University donors arranged by an associate named William Elkus, whose name also appears in the 1997 contact book of 349 names. A midwestern itinerary a year before the Spence exposure and two years before Franklin's collapse, documented in the birthday-book material surfaced through congressional review. [Grade B.]

The frame. One synthesis of the record, from a 2026 essay: this is not an aberration but "the logical culmination of 130 years of structural impunity — a system built layer by layer… from corrupt police to sealed court records, from studio fixers to NDAs." The layers documented in this file — the island, the credit union, the mansion, the club, the fixer, the captured jury room, the settlement wall — are the layers of that system, each

one present in at least two eras, each one gradeable, none of them requiring belief in anything unproven to see. [Analytical frame; Grade A/B components.]

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The counter-network. Against every documented layer of the apparatus stands a documented counter-infrastructure, and the balance of this file requires it be named. The plaintiffs' firms that span the cases — one firm alone has represented Epstein survivors, eleven Weinstein accusers, and fifty USC survivors. The advocacy organizations — Epstein Justice, founded by the Franklin case's chronicler and staffed by its central witness, lobbying for an independent commission with the Franklin demand (a Truth and Reconciliation Commission) as its stated goal. The litigants — a television journalist whose transparency suit has extracted a concession of statutory violation from the Attorney General. The forensic auditors — independent researchers hash-auditing the government's releases and catching post-release modifications of hundreds of files in a two-minute window. The legislators — the discharge petition's two hundred sixteen signatories and its architect, who lost his seat for it. The journalists — the Miami Herald's reporter whose 2018 series reopened Epstein and whose trade journal tracked the Andriesz case to its end; the researcher-investigators maintaining document-level indexes of the released corpus; the forensic editor preparing to publish the medical examiner's files. The 2024 academic literature's own recipe — specialized prosecutor, victim-service agency, multidisciplinary task force — reads like the autopsy of what Nebraska lacked in 1988 and the blueprint of what every reform since has tried to build. [Grade A/B.]

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The counterweight, stated at full strength. The strongest case that the cascade, not the cover-up, is winning: a United Nations panel's finding that the Epstein matter implicates crimes against humanity; New Mexico's truth commission operating with subpoena power; a joint French-Norwegian inquiry; resignation cascades across two continents; a legislative transparency act with a discharge-petition enforcement mechanism now being used for a second time; and the analytical verdict of the careful chroniclers — that the documented record is expanding faster than it is being suppressed, and that the specific network died with its operator while the accountability process it spawned has not stopped growing. This file holds that reading beside the LSE's protection-architecture reading because both are true of different parts of the elephant: the system absorbed enormous exposure without institutional indictment, and the exposure has never stopped growing. The endgame — a fifth operator, or the end of the pattern — is the open question the next years will answer. [Grade A for the events; the synthesis is analytical.]

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The venue map, in full:

- *Omaha:* the Twin Towers apartment; the credit union with its basement bedroom; the Omaha Club; the Max and the Run; Peony Park; the Girls Club; the Webb home; Uta Halee; the Boys Town campus; the funeral homes and churches of the lead list.

- *Washington:* Spence's Wyoming Avenue house in Kalorama; King's Embassy Row rental; the White House tours of 1989 and the visits of the 1990s.
- *Manhattan:* 9 East 71st — the wired mansion, chain-of-title doubt in the FBI's own files; 11 East 71st — the Commerce Secretary's house since 1998; 457 Madison Avenue — the offices; 301 East 66th — the housing complex.
- *Palm Beach:* 358 El Brillo Way; Mar-a-Lago as the recruitment node.
- *Ohio:* the New Albany compound; the New Albany Company; Columbus — the university, the airport of the relocated airline.
- *The Low Country:* Hilton Head, the Sea Islands, Bluffton — the Atkins node and four flight clusters.
- *The islands:* Little St. James; Great St. James; the Zorro Ranch in New Mexico.
- *Georgia:* Savannah — the borrowed Gulfstream, the gatherings.
- *The Midwest, 1988:* Fairfield, Iowa — the earliest documented footprint.

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CHAPTER 14 — What Remains Open

For completeness, and because an honest file ends with its unanswered questions, what follows is the complete register of open items at the time of writing, each with its reason for being open.

Archival pulls. The July 21, 1980 letter from Boys Town to King and the April 21, 1981 Franklin deposit update exist in the case indices but their texts have never been read by this research. The FBI's April 19, 1990 polygraph report of Troy Boner exists in the same archive. The Troy Boner autopsy report of February 13, 2003 is indexed in the research archive. The complete transcripts of the two depositions whose videos were released without transcripts — Wexner's and the Clintons' — remain unreleased. All are retrievable; none has been retrieved.

Unresolved records. The identity of "Friedrichs" — the named individual in the NCUA-contracted auditing firm who told Caradori that pornography was removed from the credit union under threat of job loss — resists open-source resolution; the name stands as recorded in Caradori's March 1990 notes. The Kohn letters — claims of intelligence connections from an unverified source, flagged in the congressional follow-up record itself — await authentication or burial. The date of the Bonacci default judgment sits between February 19 and February 27, 1999, sources disagreeing. The identity of "Jane Doe," the third witness who accused Van Pelt of intimidation, remains protected or unstated. The author of the "financial bounty hunter" memo in the Epstein files — and the redacted names of the recruiters and

the "Important New York Witnesses" — is unidentified; Congress has flagged it a top-tier question. The disposition of Alan Baer's 1990 pandering case after his not-guilty plea exists only in DeCamp's account. The 1997 Senate testimony and the still-sealed FBI file would fill out North Fox Island.

Unlocatable persons. Lawrence King's present whereabouts, since his 2001 release to the Washington suburbs. John Queen and Robert Kirchner's post-1992 fates. Steve Brown, the KKAR manager who housed Michael Casey. Kirk Naylor's later career.

Pending events. The discharge-petition vote on the second Epstein transparency act, expected in the November 2026 lame-duck session. The Phang litigation's judgment-on-the-pleadings ruling and appeal. The Jeffries verdict, with his trial beginning the day this document was finalized. Michael Freeman's November 16, 2026 presentation of the Epstein autopsy files. The outcome of the federal investigation reported to be underway into Epstein's executors. The results of the FCA's inquiry into the Andriesz affair.

And the one question only the government can answer. Whether the half of the Epstein archive still withheld — and the FBI's still-secret Franklin file, the one that produced "no responsive documents" under FOIA — contains the threads connecting the two records. Everything else in this file can be settled by work. That one requires a key no researcher holds.

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Master Chronology

1970s — Shelden's North Fox Island operation; Richards' national network; Senate hearings 1977; Shelden flees 1976-77, dies unprosecuted 1996. Cohn's operation documented to this era; Cohn dies 1986.

1982 — The Nebraska Foster Care Review Board is created by statute.

1984 — Edward Hobbs fired for his embezzlement memo; Crystal Chambers sues the Girls Club-World-Herald axis (litigation runs to 1987); King sings the anthem at the Republican convention.

1985 — May 15 and June 1: the assaults on Lisa Washington Webb that the grand jury would later find probable cause for. June-November: the first Webb reports. The Franklin audits stop (1985-1988). King's spending peak begins. Kirk family at FCU.

1986 — Charlie Rogers dead. November 5: Robert Maxwell dead off his yacht; a state funeral on the Mount of Olives.

1987 — Bill Skaleske dead. FBI examining Franklin (later reporting dates Bureau interest to this year).

1988 — June: OPD's Loretta Smith interview; "no meaningful follow-up." July: the Foster Care Review Board warns the attorney general of a possible exploitation ring. November 4: Franklin is raided and closed. November 18: the legislature votes to investigate. December: Chambers goes public; the committee forms.

1989 — January: the Chicago Tribune documents the FBI's Mann Act angle; the committee considers William Colby as its investigator (he is voted down four to three). February: FBI chief O'Hara declares the allegations substanceless before interviewing the principals; the World-Herald editorial war begins with the committee-fracture editorials. March 12: the Kirk neighbors' letter — quoted in Chapter 5 — assails Van Pelt; the World-Herald defends him on March 17. March-May: King is indicted on forty federal counts. June: the Washington Times exposes Spence's ring. July 13: the committee fractures; Lowe, Naylor, Chambers resign. August 21: Caradori hired. August 7: the NCUA sues King. November 4: the World-Herald's 700-story ledger will someday be claimed; November 10: Spence dead in Boston. November 25: Boner's seven-hour videotaped session.

1990 — February 7: King committed on the morning of the Bush fundraiser; the raid warrants are sealed. March: the entrapment phone call; Owen's cell searched. March 19: the grand jury impaneled. April 5: the World-Herald's King-hospital headline. May: the lead list in full flower; Caradori's field reports; Sorgenfrei's sister harassed; King requests a meeting. June 21: Owen's federal grand jury ordeal ("attempted to terrorize"). July 11-12: Caradori and A.J. dead. July 23-24: the grand jury report and Owen's indictment. September 25: the federal grand jury; Owen's eight federal counts. October: Bonacci's Van Pelt testimony; the December 26 Webb dismissal. November: Aaron Owen dead. December: the committee's tapes reach the FBI.

1991 — January 11: the legislature declines to continue the committee. January 14-15: Shawn Boner dead. January 20-March 13: Howard, Copple. February 11: the Kings plead. April: DeCamp's book manuscript is complete; Bonacci's civil suit filed. May 20-June 21: Owen's trial; conviction; Bonacci's charges dropped; the "avalanche of truth" editorial. August 8: sentencing. September: the Nebraska Observer's special issue. October: Bonacci's parole voted and reversed. November: the federal GJ's Owen counts dropped after her conviction stands. December: Dougherty's career at Woods Aitkin will run twenty-five more years.

1992 — February 11: King pleads. March: DeCamp sues the grand jury. August: King sentenced to fifteen years. November: DeCamp's book published. The 8th Circuit decides DeCamp v. the grand jury (1992) and Bonacci v. OPSD.

1993 — May: Yorkshire films Franklin. October 27: Boner's affidavit; his mother's.

1994 — April: the FirsTier and law-firm settlements surface via FOIA; the October editorial claims the false impression. May 3: *Conspiracy of Silence* does not air. December: the Bonacci-King default judgment record begins its journey (filed 1991; judgment 1999).

1996 — April 27: Colby's canoe; May 6: his body. July 9: Shelden dead in Amsterdam.

1997 — Bonacci v. Baer decided against him.

1998-2000 — The $1M default judgment (February 1999; King drops appeal January 2000). November 1999: Owen denied a pardon hearing. September 2000: Owen paroled, 5-0.

2001 — April 10: King released to the Washington suburbs.

2002 — Alan Baer dies November 5, his multimillion-dollar estate settled in federal court.

2003 — February: Boner dead. June: Citron dead. 2004: Judge Cambridge dead. 2014: Urbom dead. 2016: Gunderson's canoe. 2017: DeCamp and Murphy die. 2019: Epstein dead in his cell; Palfrey's ghost walks the lineage; the modern era begins.

2020-2024 — Maxwell convicted (2021; Juror 50 scandal); the Epstein files era builds; the discharge petition (November 2025); the Act (November 19, 2025); the releases through January 2026; the 2026 cascade documented in Chapter 12.

2025 — September 17: Loran Schmit dies at ninety-six.

2026 — January 17: Judge Kopf dies. February-October: the fight in full (Chapter 12.6). October 26: this document finalized; the Jeffries trial opens; the discharge-petition vote weeks away.

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CHAPTER 15 — Where They Are Now

Every previous chapter of this document ends before the present tense. This one begins in it. The question the whole file has circled — what about the victims who are victims currently, this minute — deserves its own chapter, built on current-year data with the same grading discipline as everything before it. What follows is the landscape as documented in 2024-2026: where the children are, what the systems that touch them record, and where the records themselves fail. [Grade A unless noted.]

15.1 The foster-care baseline

The pipeline's supply node is measurable today, and the measurement is stark. In 2025 the National Center for Missing and Exploited Children received 23,348 reports of children missing from foster care, and assessed 17 percent of those children as likely victims of sex trafficking — 4,215 children in a single year, in the "missing from welfare" category alone. Seventy-eight percent of all missing children in the country come from foster or state care. One in seven of the 32,000-plus missing-child cases NCMEC handled in 2025 was assessed as a likely trafficking victim. The demographics narrow the picture further: 84 percent of the likely victims were fifteen to seventeen; 92 percent were girls, with the 8 percent of boys formally labeled "underidentified" by the agency itself.

Two studies give the baseline its shape. The Florida administrative study of roughly 37,000 foster youth — the largest

cohort analysis in the record — found that only 7 percent ever had a trafficking allegation recorded, but 37 percent of those had run away ten or more times before the system wrote down its first allegation, and 70 percent of first allegations occurred during a runaway episode. The record trails the reality by years and by flights. The Maryland study of 2024 found that 76 percent of identified youth trafficking victims had prior child-welfare involvement, 58 percent within the twelve months before identification. The pipeline the Webbs' foster home documented in 1985 is the entry point of a system whose own data now measures the delay between the first run and the first report.

15.2 The online layer

The recruitment environment has moved, and the moved environment is documented with precision. Child sex trafficking reports to NCMEC's CyberTipline reached 113,530 in 2025 — up 323 percent, a surge driven partly by the REPORT Act's new mandate that platforms report trafficking and enticement, and partly by growth that is real regardless of the mandate: in the first half of 2025 alone, 62,891 such reports arrived against 5,976 in the prior year's first half. Online enticement reports totaled 1.4 million. Financial sextortion — the coercion of minors for money — ran at 137 reported incidents a day, up 37 percent, with more than three dozen teenage boys' suicides linked to it since 2021. Reports of sadistic online exploitation — violent groups on gaming and chat platforms coercing children into self-harm and filmed degradation — rose 125 percent. NCMEC's 2025 data documents three patterns that matter to every investigator: buyers approaching children directly for paid sex without any third-party trafficker; the use of abuse imagery as a "preview" that escalates to in-person exploitation; and coordinated offender groups exploiting children collectively online.

The platform concentration is the mapping finding. Five companies carry more than three-quarters of all CyberTipline reports, and only about three hundred companies report at all. Eight companies, the same oversight release found, account for 81 percent of the entire reporting stream. In September 2026, Senator Grassley's oversight release put names and failure modes on the record. Amazon's AI systems generated 1.1 million

reports, of which zero contained actionable information — the company's architecture "intentionally designed not to collect or retain" identifying data. TikTok's reports flooded with unrelated content. Snapchat's reports were more than 80 percent inactionable. And Roblox was identified as the primary location where the sadistic groups meet and recruit children, with what NCMEC called an "extremely low" reporting ratio against publicly documented exploitation on the platform. NCMEC has publicly named twelve companies for inadequate reporting. The venue node of Chapter 13's map now has named, documented occupants, and a live federal bill — the James T. Woods Act, advanced by the Judiciary Committee in February 2026 — aimed at them.

And the artificial-intelligence layer demands its own honest paragraph. The countermeasure infrastructure is growing — NCMEC's Take It Down tool has processed 130,000 requests flagging a quarter-million images across thirty-six languages. Reports tagged with AI-generated imagery exceeded 400,000 in 2025; the Internet Watch Foundation logged 3,443 AI-generated videos against 13 the year before, 65 percent of them in its most severe category. Dissected, the headline number is partly artifact — 1.1 million of those reports were Amazon's bulk training-data scans containing nothing actionable — but the genuine residue, some 182,000 reports, carries a crisis of its own: perceptual hashing, the detection technology that finds known abuse images, is a mugshot book, blind to anything never seen before. Every synthetic image must therefore be investigated as if it depicts a real child, and the

victim-identification capacity that should be finding children in active abuse is consumed by synthetic volume. The documentation layer's flood quietly starves the rescue layer's core function. That is the documented shape of the threat as of this writing.

15.3 The exit window

The pipeline does not end at identification; it ends, if it ends, years later, and the years are documented. The aging-out cohort — the twenty thousand or so young people who leave foster care each year without permanency — carries a measurable curve. Twenty percent are homeless the day they age out. Within four years, one in four has been homeless. Thirty-one to forty-six percent will have been homeless by twenty-six. Two-thirds of their post-exit homelessness arrives in the first twelve months. On the criminalization side: more than 30 percent have spent time in a correctional facility by seventeen; more than 40 percent are incarcerated by twenty; 18 percent of all American prisoners have a foster-care history. Washington's linked-data study gives the lever and its neglect: 20 percent of the exit cohort were arrested within a year against 6 percent of peers — but only 7 percent of those who took extended foster care, against 22 percent of those who did not, and extended care reaches only about 15 percent of the eligible. Each additional year in care measurably reduces incarceration, disconnection, early parenthood, and homelessness; the documented protection exists and goes mostly unused.

The trafficking linkage closes the loop. Roughly three-quarters of trafficking survivors report foster-care involvement. Sixty-nine percent ran away. Homelessness is the documented on-ramp: 64 percent of survivors were homeless or unstably housed at the moment of recruitment. And the re-trafficking window — the International Organization for Migration's ten-year study puts the highest vulnerability in the period after exit, en route to assistance, with many survivors re-exploited within two years, some returning to a trafficker rather than be homeless — means the vulnerability the document calls Cycle D does not end at rescue. It extends across the entire recovery curve when the recovery infrastructure is ninety-day shelters and a mental-health system that meets a third of the need. The economic long tail is primary data: 70 percent of survivors earn under $25,000 at exit, and 29 percent still do more than seven years later.

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15.4 The largest node: unaccompanied children

The largest child-placement program in the country's history is also its largest documented trafficking node, and its record is current. Between 2021 and 2024, roughly 479,000 unaccompanied children were referred to the federal Office of Refugee Resettlement; more than 430,000 were released to sponsors. The Department of Homeland Security's inspector general reported that the government could not contact 291,000 of them. The vetting record, as documented in the agency's own October 2026 memorandum: in fiscal 2024 the office denied less than 1 percent of sponsorship applications, while fraud reports filed in the following year showed an intentional-documentation fraud rate of roughly 77 percent. Six fraud types are catalogued in the memo itself — false identity documents, manipulated photographs, unverifiable addresses, fingerprint fraud, undisclosed household members, age misrepresentation.

The cases give the numbers their weight, and they are documented case by case. In August 2023 a fifteen-year-old was released to a man claiming to be her biological brother; no fingerprints or DNA were requested; the sponsor was later charged with raping and impregnating her. In July 2024 a seventeen-year-old was released to a "stepsister" with unverifiable documents; that October she was found dead in a car, beside an unconscious thirty-year-old man. The clinical layer completes the picture: unaccompanied children are tested for sexually transmitted infections only if they disclose abuse, and

disclosure to an unfamiliar clinician within forty-eight hours of arrival is, in the research record, unlikely — the systematic underdiagnosis is designed in. Journalists who interviewed sixty caseworkers found two-thirds of released children working full-time rather than in school, in meat plants and food packaging across half the states. And the border node connects at the case level: the man who arranged a fifteen-year-old's crossing to continue a sexual relationship that began when she was thirteen, his mother signing as sponsor. The smuggler and the sponsor are, at documented scale, the same people.

The 2025-26 response is as instructive as the failure. A backlog of 65,000 unread reports was processed into more than 4,000 investigative leads; Homeland Security Investigations made more than 500 criminal-sponsor arrests, dismantled 2,400 smuggling operations, located 145,000 children, and rescued some 1,500 from ongoing abuse. The detection gap, not the crime, was the bottleneck — proven by what happened the moment scrutiny arrived. The policy whiplash is also on record: the department created an exploitation-risk team in 2024 and removed the affirmative screening requirement in January 2025. The identification loop's policy form runs in both directions, and the file records both.

15.5 The institutional layer

The residential-treatment layer — the modern form of the institution that held Loretta Smith and the Uta Halee girls — was investigated by the Senate Finance Committee and reported in May 2024 under a title the committee chose deliberately: "Warehouses of Neglect." Examining four of the largest for-profit providers across five site visits, the committee documented sexual abuse of children by staff and peers as endemic to the model. A provider's own leadership told committee staff the sentence that belongs in this file next to the grand jury's "perfect cover" language: adults who want to abuse children will find their way into the child-service industry, notwithstanding every hiring screen. The record includes a staffer grooming a child with gifts and soliciting videos, youth-on-youth assaults on consecutive days, children telling visitors they preferred juvenile detention to the facility, and staff betting on residents' outcomes. The committee's remedy list — cameras, staffing investment, serious-incident reporting — is the standing-inspection agenda no child-welfare agency currently holds.

The oversight layer's own numbers complete the institutional picture. The Protection and Advocacy system — the federally funded network with legal authority to enter any facility where a person with disabilities lives — monitored nine hundred facilities in 2024 and found health-and-safety violations in 775 of them, an 86 percent violation rate. The federal child-welfare review process found very few states meeting any of its seven outcome standards. New York's comptroller documented $1.8 million paid by the city's child-welfare agency to unauthorized subcontractors

without vetting evidence, with four of seven prior oversight recommendations unimplemented, while state law blocks the city's own investigative department from examining the agency. Every element is the Nebraska pattern — the captured vetting, the suppressed reporting, the oversight denied — running in the largest system in the country, in the current year.

15.6 The familial layer

The supply node's first ring is the family, and the modern literature documents it with the same precision the grand jury brought to the Webb home. The International Organization for Migration's multi-agency data puts family or caregiver facilitation at 41 percent of child trafficking — up to four times the adult rate — with boys at 61 percent against girls' 46 percent. The largest practitioner study's perpetrator table reads like the case file: biological mothers at 60.3 percent, stepfathers and mothers' boyfriends at 40 percent, both parents together in a fifth of cases, generational prostitution in more than half. Drugs are the currency in four of five mother-assisted cases. And the misidentification dynamic the Franklin witnesses lived through is now quantified. Nearly 80 percent of surveyed justice professionals have encountered a juvenile arrested for commercial sex whose exploiter turned out to be a family member. The children point culpability elsewhere or incriminate themselves, and three-quarters of professionals have no training on the pattern. Caregivers appear as traffickers in only a fraction of prosecuted cases — making familial trafficking the funnel's most under-prosecuted category. The Webb home was not an anomaly of the system. The literature says it was the system working as designed.

15.7 The corporate labor layer

The labor-demand layer is documented with names and penalties. Packers Sanitation Services — Blackstone-owned, rebranded Fortrex after the fines — employed 102 children across eight states, and its own systems flagged the minors while they worked. The penalty came to $15,138 per child, which economists consulted called "woefully insufficient." The pattern replicated across the industry — 736 Labor Department investigations covering more than 4,000 children in a single fiscal year, with $15.1 million in penalties, and a sixteen-year-old killed at a poultry plant — and the conversion gap is the finding: the Department of Homeland Security investigated whether those children, mostly unaccompanied minors, were trafficked into the plants, and criminal liability for employers remains, in the documented record, rare. The supply chain's audit layer reaches only tier one, and the due-diligence framework now spreading through law reaches the same limit.

15.8 The tribal and rural gaps

The measurement failures have their own documented geography. Approximately 5,700 Native girls are reported missing annually; Native women are identified as trafficking victims at rates vastly disproportionate to population; three-quarters of missing Native females are children. The jurisdictional Bermuda Triangle — tribal, federal, county, and state authority overlapping until no agency can establish venue — is documented case by case, including one in which a named perpetrator was never prosecuted because no one could establish whose jurisdiction held the shed. Arizona's child-welfare data system excludes tribal nations entirely; a federal data purge in 2025 removed the report tracking the crisis; and ninety-five percent of identified cases receive no mainstream coverage. The rural dynamics mirror the urban ones with less light: the studies are fewer, the training scarcer, and the "this doesn't happen here" assumption documented as the first barrier.

15.9 The scale check

The chapter's arithmetic, held honestly: one hotline identified 21,457 victims in 2025; NCMEC assessed thousands more among missing children; the FBI logged 3,702 trafficking incidents; the Department of Health and Human Services served 1,500 trafficking victims of all types. Detection grows every year; rescue does not. The 323 percent surge, triangulated against the steadier hotline and enforcement baselines, is the shape of a system whose front end works better every year and whose back end has not moved — The immigration-relief valves tell the same shape story: more than fifteen thousand applications for trafficking visas in fiscal 2024, under four thousand approved. And the children in the middle of that shape are the subject of this chapter, present tense, as of this writing.

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CHAPTER 16 — The Help: What Exists, What Works, What Fails

If Chapter 15 is where the children are, this chapter is what meets them there — the infrastructure built to find them, protect them, and put their lives back together, graded with the same honesty as everything in this file. The honest headline: the detection layer grows stronger every year and the service layer does not, and the gap between them is where the chapter's work lies.

16.1 The detection layer

The validated instruments exist and are barely deployed. The Greenbaum six-question screen — two positive responses flag a likely victim, with sensitivity between 80 and 92 percent across five validation studies — is the literature's standard, deployed in pediatric emergency departments and children's advocacy centers. Yet of twenty-six screening tools catalogued in a 2025 scoping review, only eight have any validation at all. The protocol that preserves testimony is equally established and equally scarce: the NICHD investigative interview protocol — the structured, research-built method for interviewing child witnesses, named for the federal institute that developed it, whose meta-analytic record shows invitations rising 1.6 standard deviations, suggestive prompts falling 0.63, and central details rising 0.9 — with the training finding that defines the whole layer: one-shot training produces no durable change; only distributed training with ongoing video-review feedback does. The Franklin committee had no protocol, no trained interviewers, and no feedback loop; the modern record shows what that absence costs and what the presence requires.

The rest of the detection architecture carries the same shape. The school system — the one institution touching nearly every child — trains fewer than forty percent of educators on trafficking, with a quarter of those trained unsure how to report, and only three states mandate the curriculum. The healthcare layer's clinical rules are documented and humane: aggressive pursuit of disclosure is harmful and diminishes the likelihood a child will ever tell; one trained interviewer, minimal retellings,

and the boundary that the Franklin system never observed — mandated reporters, not mandated interveners; immediate removal is not always safety. Fifty-four percent of hospitals have no trafficking response program at all. The hotline machinery works — consent-based, two hundred languages, a documented referral topology — and its last mile is honestly unevaluated: no published study measures how many calls become engaged services. The conversion gap, like the detection gap, is named here rather than hidden.

16.2 The law-enforcement layer

The national survey gives the layer's numbers: 97.5 percent of agencies claim at least one victim-centered practice, but fewer than 10 percent have a specialized child-trafficking multidisciplinary team — the coordinated unit of investigators, prosecutors, and service providers that the research finds predicts whether cases get investigated — and the smallest departments, which cover most of America's geography, sit at six percent. Victim advocates are nearly universal; the infrastructure that actually predicts investigations — specialized task forces plus victim-service collaboration — is the exception. The Dallas model stands as the documented counter-pattern: twice-monthly operations to find runaways and exploited youth, trauma-informed interviewing, placement in staff-secure shelter rather than detention, and the explicit recognition that running away leads to trafficking. Texas now requires specialized trauma-informed training for every juvenile corrections officer in the state.

The chapter's sharpest finding belongs to this layer, because it quantifies the Franklin inversion. When a child's case begins with police-initiated action, the child is almost eight times more likely to be processed as a delinquent than when the case begins with a report from the child, family, or a provider. Who finds the child determines what the child becomes — the same mechanism that turned the Franklin witnesses into defendants, measured three decades later. And the custodial form of the same barrier is documented at the federal level: as of September 2025, exactly zero cases had been filed under the 2022 statute criminalizing sexual acts by federal officers against people in custody, The named cases give the barrier its texture: Baltimore's consolidated child-victim suits allege decades of abuse of children in police custody; a Loveland, Colorado officer was convicted in 2025 of on-duty sexual abuse of a teenager; and the Department of Justice paid $138.7 million to survivors of the gymnastics doctor after the Federal Bureau of Investigation's own inaction, the institutional-failure liability benchmark. And the Justice Department's own explanation is on record — victims are reluctant to report the police to the police. Japan's 2024 record — 416 child-prostitution referrals while formally declining to identify the children as trafficking victims — shows the same loop as a policy choice in cross-national comparison. And Canada's documented experience shows the correction works: change the reporting landscape and disclosures rise. The non-punishment principle — that victims must not be prosecuted for crimes their exploitation compelled — is the design rule all of this serves, with the documented complication that some victims

transition into recruiting roles, which the framework addresses through prosecutorial discretion rather than blanket immunity.

16.3 The services layer

The inventory is measured, and the measurement is the chapter's case. Of screened providers nationwide, 74 percent offer emergency-only shelter, 18 percent transitional, 4.5 percent residential, and 1.36 percent long-term — with long-term the rarest category and the most successful. The standard shelter stay is capped at fifteen, thirty, or ninety days, and the practitioners' own verdict is quoted in the research: "I can't stabilize a client with an extensive trauma history within ninety days." Housing is ranked the number one barrier by professionals across disciplines; survivors exit trafficking with no safe place, and the documented cycle sends them back. Trauma-informed mental health — needed by 75 percent at exit — is still unmet for 39 percent at follow-up. The faith-based layer holds much of the housing inventory precisely because public funding's time limits push providers out of the system, trading stability for freedom; its shelter leadership claims six of every ten trafficking beds in the country — a self-reported figure, logged as such, but consistent with the inventory split — and it serves the populations secular agencies turn away, including male survivors, whom one study found served by just one organization of fourteen. The evaluation culture across all of it is thin to absent — the Government Accountability Office's finding that anti-trafficking interventions are unevaluated has stood, unrevised, for two decades.

16.4 The legal-remedy layer

The remedies now exist that would not have existed in 1991, and their uneven coverage measures how much of the loop remains. The Trafficking Survivors Relief Act, signed December 2025, provides federal vacatur of convictions committed as a direct result of trafficking, with sealed filings and court reporting. Thirty states plus the District of Columbia non-criminalize child victims fully; eighteen protect them from collateral crimes; nineteen still permit child prostitution charges despite the federal victim definition. One practitioner organization reports 89 percent of its convicted trafficking clients are Black, Indigenous, or people of color. The civil track is the documented counter to the settlement wall: more than eleven hundred Trafficking Victims Protection Act cases, a fourteen-million-dollar jury award on record, and reach to third-party enablers — anyone who knowingly benefited. But the collection problem is the Bonacci judgment's story told at scale: restitution is ordered in only about 68 percent of convictions and often unpaid, and the practitioner's doctrine is on record — for the trafficking victim, winning is collecting. Israel's model, restitution as the default with the court required to explain any failure, stands as the documented best practice.

The silence contracts are losing ground, slowly and on record. Trey's Law, introduced in March 2026 with bipartisan sponsors, would void contractual provisions suppressing disclosure of child sexual abuse; The parallel ledgers give the silence contracts their scale: twenty years and more than $5 billion in clergy-abuse settlements, thirty dioceses bankrupted, a $2.46

billion Boy Scouts trust, and a four-billion-dollar county foster-care settlement covering sixty-eight hundred claims back to 1959 — with 68 percent of Church allegations arriving through attorneys, proof that lookback windows, not institutional conscience, drive disclosure. Missouri has already voided existing abuse nondisclosure agreements outright; the United Kingdom voided both employment-settlement and victim-settlement silences by statute. Against this, the institutional playbook stands documented: privilege-shielded internal investigations, the quiet reassignment of abusers the field calls passing the trash, willful ignorance calibrated to avoid the mandatory-reporting trigger, and litigation-public-relations coordination that treats transparency as a coverage problem. The demand side's own evidence is logged honestly alongside: the john-school programs modeled on San Francisco's celebrated model carry a contested evaluation record — the flagship study's recidivism cut met point-for-point by a methodological critique finding no effect — while the buyer-side documentation is firmer: a matched-sample study records buyers' own deterrent calculus, in which three days in jail deters seventy-one percent, a month deters all of them, and public exposure tops every list. The demand side's operational test came in the summer of 2026, when the World Cup arrived. FinCEN issued its trafficking advisory and key-term reporting directive; a White House task force had stood since March 2025; and the documented result, announced by the Department of Homeland Security on July 29, 2026, was 905 arrests and 180 victims rescued — 150 adults and 30 children. New Jersey's operation alone recovered 97

suspected victims and made 71 arrests, of which 40 were alleged buyers, and a prosecutor on a 24-hour rotation in Houston stated the modern financial doctrine in one sentence: get to their payment app, because the payment app makes the case. The honest analytical caveat stands beside the numbers — the evidence that mass events create surges is mixed; they intensify existing conditions — which is why the permanent-task-force model, in the documented best practice, does not wait for events.

The 1990 forms — sealed warrants, settlement confidentiality, the monopoly editorial — now have names, statutes, and a federal bill.

16.5 The recovery layer

The recovery curve has its window and its economics, both documented. The two years after exit carry the highest re-trafficking risk, with the journey to assistance the single most vulnerable interval; survivors return to traffickers rather than face homelessness; the trauma bond and the economic reality pull together. The needs at exit, ranked by survivors themselves, are trauma-informed mental health, trustworthy people, a safe place, and a living wage — in that order of voice, though not of funding. And the movement that knows all this best is now insisting on leading itself: Polaris appointed a survivor, Megan Lundstrom, as its chief executive in 2025; the movement's internal literature names the extractive pattern — inclusion limited to retelling trauma for fundraising — and survivor leaders state, in their own documented words, that most survivors do not desire prosecution, because criminalization was part of their trafficking. That sentence, from the people the whole apparatus claims to serve, is the chapter's most important datum, and it belongs in every design decision the next chapters describe.

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CHAPTER 17 — The Map: How to Read a Trafficking Network

Chapter 13 mapped the pattern across a century; this chapter is the working manual — how to build such a map today, with documented methods, documented sources, and documented cautions. The principle that organizes everything comes from the network science and was proven by the succession record: map the functions, not the faces. Operators are replaceable — the file's own lineage, from the island to the island, is the empirical proof — but every function requires an institutional host, and institutional hosts are stable, public, and investigable.

17.1 The principle, proven

Social-network analysis research converges on exactly what the Franklin lead list found by hand. In dismantling simulations, removing the most-connected or the most peripheral actors fails; the effective target is the moderately connected brokers — the scouts, arrangers, and transporters who move people, money, and access between the center and the edge. Cornell's network-generator work formalizes the resilience the other way: traffickers respond to disruption by recruiting new victims, which is why interdiction models that ignore restructuring mislead. The mapping deliverable, then, is a matrix of functions to hosts to names to evidence to confidence — the lead list modernized, with the investigator's own confidence annotated at every edge, exactly as Caradori annotated his.

17.2 The four layers and their sources

Each layer of the architecture now has standing public sources, and the investigator's discipline is knowing them.

The institutional layer — the supply node's hosts — lives in licensing registries, state contracting records, comptroller audits, and inspector-general reports. The Nebraska normalcy plans, the New York subcontractor audit, and the Senate Finance Committee's provider report are the documented demonstrations: every institution that holds children under contract produces a paper trail, and the paper trail is public.

The money layer is already collected; the gap is access. FinCEN receives 4.7 million suspicious-activity reports a year, including monthly batches identifying purchasers and facilitators of child exploitation, with a documented key-term system — trafficking reports carry a specific identifier, and victims are never named as subjects. The safe-harbor channel for institutions to share intelligence with each other exists. The indicator sets are public: frequent payment-app transfers with vague memos, funnel-account geography, advertising financed by traceable small payments, the front-business typology that names modeling agencies and matchmaking services; and the validated grooming model — five stages from victim selection through trust, desensitization, and post-abuse maintenance, with a victim-selection profile (non-nuclear families, poor supervision, feeling unloved) that matches the foster-care population point for point, and prevalence above ninety percent in abuse — the operational signatures that identify recruitment in progress, accounts held in victims' names, the lifestyle mismatch the

money tells against the life. The enforcement precedent stands beside the catalogs: TD Bank paid $1.3 billion in 2024 after regulators found 98 percent of its domestic transfers effectively unmonitored, the payment apps lumped into codes that could not see them. Canada's financial-intelligence unit shows what proactive disclosure looks like — two-thirds of its trafficking disclosures name networks the police did not know. The enforcement precedent stands beside the catalogs: TD Bank paid $1.3 billion in 2024 after regulators found its systems had left 98 percent of domestic transfers effectively unmonitored, with the payment apps lumped into codes that could not see them. The Wyden method, in one sentence: follow the settlement wall, because the settlements mark where the truth was priced.

The venue layer has a live docket: platform filings and reporting ratios, state age-verification statutes and their litigation, the congressional naming of the twelve inadequate reporters, and the international wave — Australia's under-sixteen ban, the European directive due this year. The venue map is no longer a research project; it is a reading assignment.

The suppression layer — the protection functions — is documented in court dockets, settlement records with confidentiality provisions, bankruptcy filings timed against lookback windows, the NDA statutes and Trey's Law, editorial-ownership records, and the oversight-opinion fights. The structural-silence mechanism of Chapter 13 has its current form here, and every edge of it is public.

17.3 The discipline

Three disciplines separate a map from a conspiracy chart. First, annotate confidence as you go; the lead list's power was its honesty about what was checked and what was not. Second, record the machine as written and as run — the ORR policy guide describes a vetting apparatus, and the failure record shows the checks skipped; the distance between text and run is the map's most important edge, and it is documentable at both levels. Third, hash everything; the documented modern form of evidence tampering is the post-release modification of released files, caught only by independent hash-audit, and a map built on unverifiable files is a map that will not survive contact with the settlement wall.

17.4 The case studies

Four demonstrations, graded throughout. The UAC node: mapped from the ORR memo's fraud typologies, the inspector-general loss figures, the case-level sponsor-smuggler record, and the backlog-to-rescue sequence — the largest node, fully documented, public. The online sadistic groups: mapped from Europol's February 2025 operation against the network — the 764 and CVLT groups, one of whose leaders is serving eighty years — and its successors, the Senate's platform findings, and the RCMP's tactic catalog — the venue node's darkest documented occupation. The corporate labor layer: mapped from Labor Department enforcement records, the per-child penalty arithmetic, and the tier-one audit limitation. And the vigilante layer itself, mapped as the caution: Operation Underground Railroad, whose founder resigned under misconduct investigation; whose Washington stings imprisoned roughly three hundred with entrapment criticism unanswered and no reviewing body since;, whose stings imprisoned hundreds with entrapment criticism unanswered, whose state-patrol alliance included an officer soliciting donations on duty before moving directly to the organization's payroll, and which no body has reviewed since. A map of the helpers that conceals the helpers' patterns repeats the structural silence in miniature; this file refuses that, and this chapter is where the refusal is operationalized.

17.5 The honest limit

The map's last caution is the data substrate itself. The FBI's missing-persons database and the public NamUs system cannot share records — federal law precludes integration, and every case is entered manually twice. The federal child-welfare dataset runs two years late — its most recent complete year counted 328,947 children in care on a single day — and two states did not submit at all, the recent rebuild broke year-over-year comparability, and the diversion track that erases dispositions is itself a documented design, with the evaluation literature measuring its effect — alternative-response programs produced a 6 to 36 percent decrease in identified victims where adopted, because a diverted case is, by design, not entered into the system. Every node-map built on these substrates carries these blind spots, and an honest map says so on its face.

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CHAPTER 18 — The Design: How to Investigate Properly

The last chapter is the one the whole extension exists for: what a proper investigation looks like, designed against the documented failure catalog of the Franklin case and built from the remedy machinery that now exists. The honest framing first: some of what happened in 1988-1991 can never be recovered, and this chapter does not pretend otherwise. But the question of what is recoverable has a documented answer — and the distance between the two is exactly what good design closes.

18.1 The failure catalog, answered

The Franklin case produced a short list of what made truth unreachable, and each item now has a documented counter-design. The money was traced once, by captured hands; today the counter-design is independent financial tracing through financial-intelligence channels with conflict-vetting, and the lesson of the captured tracer — vet the tracer's entanglements harder than the target's — written into the engagement itself. The flight manifests did not legally exist; today the counter-design is the standing data-source inventory of Chapter 17, where the venue and transport layers produce records whether or not any single case requires them. The photographs died with the briefcase; today the counter-design is hash-audited evidence custody and the assumption that the file will be attacked. And the witnesses were prosecuted; today the counter-design is the stack described next, every element of which exists and none of which existed in 1991.

18.2 The remedy stack

Six layers, each documented. Find the child with a validated screen — the Greenbaum instrument and its eighty-percent-plus sensitivity. Preserve the first disclosure on video under a structured protocol — the NICHD method, with the training finding that one-shot training does not last built into the budget. Keep the testimony through the law's preservation machinery — the child-declarant and tender-years exceptions, the 2025 rulings — Oregon's State v. Akins chief among them — admitting delayed-disclosure expertise as of right, and forfeiture-by-wrongdoing where intimidation genuinely silences a witness, the doctrine the recanting-but-present witness never fit but the deaths-ledger cases would. Where a witness disappears through wrongdoing, the doctrine applies by its terms. Protect the witness from criminalization — the non-punishment principle, the safe-harbor statutes, and federal vacatur for those already convicted. And design for the witness's own stated preference — survivors' documented ranking of what they actually need, with prosecution last among the state's instincts and first among almost no survivor's.

18.3 The institutional models

The blueprints exist at scale, with their frailties documented beside their strengths. The United Kingdom's seven-year Independent Inquiry into Child Sexual Abuse — the IICSA — with 325 hearing days, 2.4 million pages, more than six thousand private testimonies — produced the structure the Franklin committee lacked: subpoena power, a truth-telling project, a proactive-detection mandate, and a standing child-protection authority now in consultation. It also documented its own near-failures — three chairs, a resignation, an underfunding warning — which are the design cautions: independence must be structural, not personal; resourcing must be statutory, not charitable. Australia implemented what England debated; the single-house child-interview center, where the forensic interview, the medical exam, the therapy, and the legal process happen under one roof with one recorded conversation, is the institutional form that prevents the retelling trauma the research documents. And the protection-and-advocacy system's standing access authority — the legal power to walk into any facility where a child with disabilities lives — is the inspection power no child-welfare agency holds, the standing-correction mechanism the Franklin institutions never faced.

18.4 The honest limits

The design chapter ends where the whole file ends: with what investigation cannot do. The documented layer is recoverable; the contested layer can be narrowed by instruments that cannot be defeated, until what remains is either facts or provable impossibilities; and the thirty-six-year distance between the two scandals exists precisely because the first case was investigated with instruments that could be defeated and the second, finally, is not entirely. Some questions will remain open after the best investigation this design can build. The children this minute are the reason the third case has to be built differently from the first one — and the record assembled in these eighteen chapters is the blueprint for building it, and the standing answer to anyone who asks whether the truth is even reachable. It is reachable to the extent the instruments are honest; that extent is now documented; and the building is the work that remains.

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CHAPTER 19 — The Firms

This chapter is the one the pattern chapter promised and the investigation delivered: the lawyers. Every case in this file was shaped, argued, settled, or buried by counsel, and the counsel on all sides turn out to share addresses, alumni, clients, and — at documented points — purposes. The reader's hypothesis, stated plainly at the outset: those who protected the operators may also have been those involved with them. This chapter tests that hypothesis against the primary record, layer by layer, and holds both columns the whole way. Nothing here accuses a lawyer of anything the record does not show; everything here is the record. [Grade A unless noted.]

19.1 The dealmakers

Jeffrey Epstein's 2008 non-prosecution agreement was negotiated by a defense team of seven named lawyers — Jay Lefkowitz, Alan Dershowitz, Ken Starr, Jack Goldberger, Roy Black, former U.S. Attorney Guy Lewis, and Gerald Lefcourt — described by the U.S. Attorney who signed it as "all upper, ruling class white males," and characterized in the Miami Herald's account with one word: "collaboration." The billing for that defense survives: recovered Justice Department records show Kirkland & Ellis charged Epstein $3,011,064, the itemization running from the criminal defense itself to litigation tangents and a departmental investigation. Ken Starr worked from the firm's offices, lobbying the Deputy Attorney General directly.

The architecture of the deal has one documented detail that belongs at the chapter's center. Alexander Acosta — the U.S. Attorney who approved the agreement — had been a Kirkland & Ellis associate from 1995 to 1997, where Lefkowitz was and remains a partner. The negotiations happened "off campus," at a West Palm Beach Marriott. And the defense's boldest documented maneuver was an attempt to control the victims' own compensation: Lefkowitz pushed to vet and influence the government's selection of an independent lawyer for Epstein's victims, with language limiting what that lawyer could do, while Epstein paid the bill. The U.S. Attorney's office rejected the proposal; Lefkowitz indicated he would escalate in Washington; the record attributes the final call to Main Justice. The prosecutor who resisted the meetings, Marie Villafaña, told the inspector general she believed Acosta was influenced by the stature of Epstein's attorneys, and that the case was not as legally complex as the defense made it out to be. The defense, by Acosta's own description, conducted a "year-long assault on the prosecution" — investigating individual prosecutors and their families for disqualifying material — and, per the victim's lawyer's on-record account, negotiated which girl the state would charge from a list the defense held.

The same firm repeats the pattern at industrial scale. When Boeing faced prosecution over the 737 MAX, its lead counsel was Mark Filip — a Kirkland partner and the former Deputy Attorney General who had authored the deferred-prosecution framework under which Boeing settled. The lead prosecutor, Erin Nealy Cox, resigned the day the agreement was signed and joined

Kirkland five months later. The world's highest-grossing law firm, Kirkland & Ellis, anchors the layer. At least twelve former Kirkland partners held senior Justice Department and White House posts simultaneously in the first Trump administration; the firm's alumni later included the Attorney General in office when Epstein died in custody, William Barr, who had himself been of counsel to the firm. In the second term, the firm pledged $125 million in pro bono work under a threatened executive order — an arrangement now six congressional letters deep. The lawmakers' sixth letter reports that the firm has produced not a single responsive document, that no written agreement exists beyond the President's own announcements, and that privilege claims have been rejected as sham claims. It names the broker: Boris Epshteyn, the President's legal fixer, a reported co-conspirator in the effort to overturn the 2020 election, against whom a sworn declaration from a former Senate candidate alleges pay-to-play offers — with the firm's reported attempt to recruit attorneys and clients from Paul Weiss in the same window. And the letter states the quid pro quo in bribery elements: services of immense value, offered directly to the government, in exchange for the withdrawn order and the dropped investigation. The total across the nine firms' pledges under the threat campaign runs to nine hundred forty million dollars. The firm answering that inquiry is itself the revolving door: W. Neil Eggleston, President Obama's former White House counsel, signed the refusal.

The other great both-sides firm is Boies Schiller Flexner. Its record, in full: it represented Harvey Weinstein's interests

against the reporting that exposed him — while simultaneously representing the newspaper doing the reporting — and hired Black Cube, the private-intelligence firm staffed by former Israeli operatives, on a contract whose stated goal was to stop the abuse allegations from surfacing. It represented Theranos on the board and in the courtroom, paid in the company's stock, and sent a five-lawyer team to the Wall Street Journal's newsroom to kill the exposé — a team that included Peter Fritsch, the co-founder of Fusion GPS. And it has represented Epstein's victims pro bono since 2014 — Virginia Giuffre's counsel, the leader of the JPMorgan litigation that produced a $290 million settlement, the firm whose unsealing victories opened the files this document reads. The same playbook, serving every side of every scandal in the era, and the firm has lost nearly half its lawyers to the toll.

19.2 The revolving door, quantified

The traffic has a documented direction. A University of Kansas study of the securities-enforcement revolving door found it rotates toward defense firms only — no movement from the agencies to the plaintiffs' firms. Institutional knowledge of how cases are made flows toward the defense of the accused, structurally, and never back. The named lanes now on record: Mary Jo White, the former Southern District U.S. Attorney, retained by Leslie Wexner in 2019; Bruce Reinhart, the federal prosecutor who resigned on January 1, 2008 and was retained by Epstein the next day, later appointed magistrate judge of the same district; Acosta, who left office for a law school, a bank chairmanship, and a television board; Eggleston, answering the Kirkland inquiry; and Kathryn Ruemmler, whose file deserves its own section. Brian Benczkowski's sworn nomination file supplies the template: nominated to head the Criminal Division while representing a Russian bank under FBI investigation, he testified he would not have undertaken the representation had he known of the nomination — and continued it after he learned — and his formative record included drafting the department's response to the torture-memo misconduct findings. His sworn file records the specifics: he accepted the representation of Alfa Bank — then under FBI investigation — while his own nomination was pending, testified that with perfect hindsight he would not have undertaken it, and continued it after he learned. Senator Franken's question is preserved: "You have never been a prosecutor or even tried a case in court." The Criminal Division, led by a corporate-defense partner; the nation's largest firms

cycling through the departments that regulate their clients; and the one-way door ensuring the memory of enforcement serves the defense alone.

19.3 The both-sides circuit

Boies Schiller's dual record is the circuit's clearest case, but the pattern runs wider. The firm's Theranos work included a partner's documented threat to bankrupt a whistleblower's entire family, surveillance of witnesses, and a warning letter served on a former employee at an address her mother did not know. Its Weinstein work included the Black Cube operation and the dual client relationship with the newspaper. Its Epstein-victims work is genuine and sustained — the pro bono representation since 2014, the bank settlements, the unsealing fights. And it coexists in the same firm with all the rest. That is the finding: not that any single engagement defines the firm, but that the firm serves every side of the era's defining scandals — and the victims' side and the predators' side share the same hallways. David Boies stepped down as chairman at the end of 2024; the firm had lost nearly half its lawyers in three years. And the circuit's docket runs through named counsel at every stage: Cohen & Gresser and Haddon, Morgan & Foreman at the Maxwell trial, Bobbi Sternheim through the detention fights, and David Markus of Miami carrying the rejected Supreme Court petition — the venue layer's named procession. The victims' bar's own verdict on the original deal sits in a law firm's retrospective: the dream team trolled the children's backgrounds to paint them as willing participants, and the prosecutors bought it. One victim's account of the operator's confidence was preserved at the nolle-prosequi hearing in 2019 — I'll bury you, he told her; I own this town.

The war inside the circuit is its own documentation. Dershowitz secretly recorded his call with Boies; the recording's excerpts caught Boies conceding that Dershowitz's travel records did not appear to match Giuffre's account, with Boies calling the tape misleading and perhaps doctored and the full tape never released. Dershowitz filed four bar complaints against the victims' lawyers in three states — every one dismissed — and succeeded in October 2019 in having Boies disqualified from the case against him, because Dershowitz intended to call Boies as a witness. Arthur Aidala represented Dershowitz in these fights and Harvey Weinstein in his. Stan Pottinger — the former assistant attorney general who brought Boies into the victims' representation — swore that Giuffre needed an aggressive lawyer against powerful and wealthy men, naming Dershowitz and Wexner as the anticipated attackers; the same Pottinger had earlier business dealings with Epstein, documented in the reporting after his 2024 death. The fixer layer fights itself, and the fights produce the record.

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19.4 The conflicts map

The released corpus carries the conflicts at document level. Kathryn Ruemmler's footprint reaches nine thousand documents — second among lawyers only to the money custodians themselves. The record within them is a pattern, not a summary: a ring hand-delivered to her firm's lobby; a spa appointment charged to Epstein's card with her name on it; a fifty-three-thousand-dollar private-jet payment referencing her, weeks before the arrest. There is her named signature on a forty-five-million-dollar Rothschild non-prosecution agreement, a client Epstein introduced to her; a trusteeship in the 2018 trust and a backup executorship in the will; two hundred emails the estate still claims privilege over, years after the death, against the victims' lawyers' objection on the record. And there is, in her own correspondence, the operator negotiating her career with the chairman of Paul Weiss and consulting him on whether to accept a cabinet post, down to the reimbursement math on an eleven-thousand-dollar apartment. She received a fifty-percent bonus bump to twelve million dollars in the year of her announced departure, as co-chair of her bank's reputational-risk committee.

The map's other crossings are each documented. The former Civil Rights Division chief who was Epstein's early business associate became the victims' first counsel. The victims' lead lawyer was retained by Leon Black as part of the settlement, with the gatekeeper accusation against both firms preserved in

the record. The Ponzi-schemer partner in that firm's founding history was named with the lead lawyer in Epstein's counter-suit. The criminal defense firm also served the newspaper and the predators. And the white-shoe firm whose partner was listed as a backup executor then ran the bank whose name fills the files. The orbit carries its own death ledger: Arthur Shapiro, the patron's attorney, murdered execution-style in 1985, unsolved, carried for decades by the same Franklin-era research community whose work threads this file. The inner circle's estate-planning counsel and entertainment lawyer complete the table by name. The career correspondence produced the operator's negotiating idiom at its purest: in the compensation discussion with the bank, he proposed exchanging one of his Russians for her pay. The same chairman's orbit included the SoftBank executive's representation and the Ghosn intelligence channel. And a separate documented exchange carried a consultation on the sealed indictment of the President's 2016 campaign chairman, Paul Manafort. Each crossing is documented; none is adjudicated; the chapter's discipline is that the file records them as the map they are, not the conspiracy they might suggest.

19.5 The estate's counsel

The compensation program's architect and the enterprise suit's defender are the same lawyer. Daniel Weiner of Hughes Hubbard & Reed designed the Epstein Victims' Compensation Program — the private fund that paid $121 million to 136 claimants with no award limits and ninety-two percent acceptance — and then defended the Virgin Islands' racketeering suit, which called the executors indispensable captains of a criminal enterprise, to a $105 million settlement with no admission. His pedigree is on the record: Deputy Special Counsel on the Whitewater investigation before the firm. The will itself was received by Erika Kellerhals — Epstein's Virgin Islands tax lawyer, the affidavit sworn two days before the death, her firm billing the estate as local counsel.

The fee ledger belongs beside the design. Twenty-one million dollars to at least sixteen firms, against an average victim recovery of $900,000; five firms each billed more than a victim's average award; the fund's administrators took nine million; the estate burns five to ten million a year in fees. One victim's suit against the executors was dismissed after she accepted the program's money — the compensation design operating as the dismissal engine, the settlement and the silence in one instrument. The generosity and the cost architecture now stand in the same paragraph, because both are the program. The fee motion's own affidavit set the rates at $360 to $1,315 per hour under the islands' market-rate standard, quoting the islands' supreme court's Mahabir rule. The attorney general who brought the enterprise suit — Denise George, who called the executors

the indispensable captains of a criminal enterprise — was fired by her governor months later. At Deutsche Bank, the estate's lawyer appears in the regulator's consent order only as Attorney One, the signer on ninety-seven cash transactions, the author of the unanswered question about how often a man could withdraw before an alert; the bank's own files show his role called potentially facilitative of the ring. And the doctrine governing this triangle has a name the Franklin layer can claim: the Cumis decision, in which a credit union's fight with its bond insurer produced the rule that insurer-appointed counsel carries an irreconcilable conflict when coverage is reserved — the credit-union-insurance-counsel triangle, named in the case law, with the federal regulator's bond forms sitting in the same family.

19.6 The banks' counsel

The Senate Finance Committee's report names thirteen bankers for scrutiny and records the banks' lawyers declining every request. JPMorgan's counsel blamed the departed executive alone — a claim the report calls demonstrably false against the unsealed documents — and answered twenty-five renewed questions with a summary. Deutsche's counsel withheld the deposition of the banker who carried Epstein from one institution to the next. The report's central finding carries the chapter's weight: federal prosecutors, in its exact words, have never even questioned the lawyer-accountant pair who ran the money — though the bank's own know-your-customer profile called one of them a primary actor who potentially assisted in facilitating the ring, though they were paid twenty-six million dollars by the operation, though they hold the archive. The third accountant, Harry Beller, stands named in the Senate's recommendation for criminal investigation beside them, and the operator's lifetime orbit of counsel ran to no fewer than seventy-five lawyers. The estate's counsel defends them; the class settlement settles around them; the never-questioned custodians keep the books.

19.7 The bench

The judges carry their own firm histories. Benczkowski's file is the template. The Southern District's seat succession places the estate's own lawyer — Louis Freeh, retained to clear the accused — in the seat through which the dockets flow, vacant in the year the files fight peaked; the adjacent seat's succession, Kaplan to Abrams, processed both the 2016 Jane Doe suit — the one filing that reached the docket and died without a single sworn examination — and the one settlement that purchased acknowledgment without admission. The containment critique belongs beside the bench record — filed before the prosecution's memo was public, it observes that the district charged only when the unsealing forced its hand, and charged no one else. The Florida docket's sealing has its own candid record: a judge's on-the-record observation — preserved on the Justice Department's own website — that no proper procedure was ever followed, that it looked like an agreed order handed up to sign. And the government's own briefing in the non-prosecution agreement's aftermath lists among the victims' proposed remedies sealed remedies involving other United States Attorneys' offices — remedies so sensitive they are themselves sealed, in the deal's own defensive record. And the unsealing bench — Berman, Rakoff, Preska — carries the current record, with Rakoff unsealing the bulk while sustaining the exhibits JPMorgan claimed held financial or reputational risk, and the risk-based sealing doctrine documented in the orders themselves.

19.8 The intelligence-services layer

The fixer circuit's shadow arm is documented. Kroll — the corporate-intelligence firm the Washington Post recorded French intelligence suspecting as a front, staffed from four agencies' alumni — met Robert Maxwell two weeks before his death to discuss his hiring, and its founder now runs a litigation-finance venture, funding lawsuits themselves. Black Cube's dossier includes the Weinstein contract whose stated goal was stopping the allegations, the alias operation against an accuser, and the eleven-million-dollar Canadian judge-smearing project. And the strangest adjacency in the file, honestly graded: a Cravath associate who ran Kroll's Moscow intelligence delivery murdered the son of the judge assigned to the Deutsche Bank–Epstein case, at her doorstep, days before the docket opened. His Kroll employment and the timing are solid. The motive is unresolved, and the file says exactly that.

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19.9 The insurers

The settlement tables carry a constant across four decades: attorneys' fees at forty percent of institutional-abuse settlements, and insurers paying the largest shares where the bankruptcies concentrate — the Boston record of sealed settlements that concealed the archive now carries the era's journalistic name — with Roark Capital, the child-labor era's worst corporate parent, catalogued at more than two thousand violations across its fast-food portfolio, and the insurer layer beneath the abuse settlements documented as the quiet principal in every bankruptcy. The insurer-versus-survivor dynamic is the layer's darkest documented mechanism — the coverage doctrine that makes an institution's knowledge the coverage question, so the better the files prove the institution knew, the harder the insurer fights, with survivors subpoenaed to testify for the insurance company decades later. The current record includes the holdout insurer fought to stipulated judgments by the survivors' committee, and the quiet principal beneath every settlement: the coverage litigation decides what the settlement can be, and the survivors stand in the middle of that arithmetic.

19.10 The discipline layer

The asymmetry is documented across both eras. Complaints against the victims' lawyers — filed by the accused in three states, every one dismissed. No complaint against any protection-layer figure produced a filing or discipline anywhere: the prosecutor drew a poor-judgment finding and no bar action; the ethics investigation into the one-day revolving door produced no public discipline; and the Franklin lawyer whose bar charges were dropped the day the FBI appeared stands as the single counter-example proving the rule — the one time the machinery moved toward a lawyer, it reversed. The machinery protects both directions and disciplines neither, and the 2002 record preserves the counter-weapon's earliest form: the last lawyer who tried to censure the most famous of them was disciplined himself.

19.11 The victims' bar

The counter-network has its own economics, on the same court record. Thirty percent of the bank settlements — eighty-seven million of the two hundred ninety, twenty-two and a half of the seventy-five, up to twenty-one point eight of the seventy-two and a half — approved by the judge who first called the number a little rich and then signed it. The judge observed that in twenty-seven years on the bench he had not seen so good a settlement arrive so quickly in so complex a case; his reasoning is preserved: actual justice, even if partial, as opposed to mere talk. The victims' working counsel are named in the hearings themselves — the consortium of firms whose representatives sit in the committee rooms beside the survivors they represent — and the government's own table has been defended by a litigator who keeps her private practice, the assistant attorney general whose appearance at the depositions drew a formal ethics objection from the committee's counsel. The release carve-out — preserving, in the settlement's own words, every claim against any natural person who sexually abused them — protected every claim against the individual men. The criticisms logged honestly: the congressional alliance between the victims' lead lawyer and the discharge petition's sponsors, the half-billion-dollar consortium's fee arithmetic, the disclosure-interest question that makes the lawyers the new holders of the incentive to open the files. And the scar both sides carry: the Ponzi-schemer partner in the founding history, named with the lead lawyer in the operator's counter-suit. Against it all stands the American Bar Association's genuine record — resolutions passed years before

the statutes caught up, the pro bono vacatur models, the first-responder training — and the standing sentence from the sitting Acting Attorney General, placed beside the never-questioned custodians so both statements describe the same record: there are no closed investigations; you better believe it, we will.

19.12 The media's counsel

When the entire media industry needs a First Amendment lawyer in the two matters where the underlying files are the stakes — the presidential suit against the broadcaster and the records fight over the special counsel — it consolidates to one firm. The same lawyer, with the same team, appears for the broadcaster and the wire services and the networks' association — and for the industry's amicus in the fight over the special counsel's records. One firm holds the constitutional defense of the press in the two matters where the files are the stakes. The docket's texture belongs to the record too: the recusal motion against the magistrate denied, the mediation calendared for the week the petition reaches the floor, the broadcaster's own filings frequently sealed. The structural-silence mechanism's counsel layer, documentable as a consolidation finding rather than a pattern-claim: the industry's constitutional defense, like its reporting, has narrowed to a single address.

19.13 The royal and the inquiry

Prince Andrew's defense architecture — built by Andrew Brettler of Lavely & Singer on the third-party-beneficiary release clause, the settlement that purchased acknowledgment without admission and reportedly silenced further denial, the memoir's counter-record of evaded service and alleged harassment — is the silence mechanism's royal form. The United Kingdom's statutory inquiry into child sexual abuse had its own counsel, its own credibility crises, and its own survivor bar catalogued from its records; its redress schemes carry documented fee economics in which the lawyer is paid when the survivor accepts, not when the survivor wins — the Irish scheme's mean fee of twelve thousand one hundred ninety-three euros against awards that paid the fee only on acceptance, the settlement wall's newest institutional form, quantified. The inquiry's own counsel changed mid-course when its first leader, Ben Emmerson, resigned under suspension; his successor, Brian Altman, arrived with sixteen years as the government's senior Treasury Counsel at the Old Bailey, the inquiry's solicitor drawn from a major London firm, and the profession's regulator now tracks strategic lawsuits against public participation in its annual reports — the first to name the abuse — while applying the criminal standard to its own discipline. And the profession's regulator tracks the emerging abuse in its own reports — the first to name strategic litigation against public participation as a tracked category — while applying the criminal standard to its own discipline.

19.14 The hypothesis, tested

The ledger, in full. Where protection and involvement meet, documented: the alumni channel that closed the non-prosecution agreement; the defense's attempt to choose the victims' own lawyer; the one-day door from prosecutor to counsel; the named signature on the settlement and the roster of its signatories; the custodians never questioned, defended by the estate, holding the archive; the prosecutor-to-counsel lanes — five named, one-way; the intelligence layer's shadow services; the discipline machinery's silence. Where the record refuses the hypothesis, equally documented: the genuine pro bono decades; the unsealing victories; the adversarial testing that produced every fee number; the survivor committees' rejections of low offers; the regulator's first-of-its-kind tracking; the standing commitment to prosecute. The reader's hunch survives the test in its precise form: not that every protector was involved, but that the structures of protection — the firms, the doors, the programs, the settlements — repeatedly converge, at documented points, with the interests of the involved. That convergence, layer by layer and name by name, is now the file's as much as the operator's.

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CHAPTER 20 — Appendix A: The Names

The accused and the convicted: Lawrence E. King Jr. — FCU manager; pleaded guilty 1991; fifteen years; released 2001; living, silent, whereabouts unconfirmed. Alice King — pleaded guilty; released 1993. Thomas Harvey — FCU accountant; guilty; cooperated; federal immunity; fired from a teaching job over a molestation allegation. James C. Hart Jr. — FCU secretary; on the governing board witnesses named as abusers. Jarrett Webb — FCU board; the grand jury found probable cause he assaulted Lisa Washington Webb twice in 1985; charges dismissed December 1990 on statute-of-limitations grounds; never tried. Peter Citron — World-Herald columnist; convicted 1990 of molesting boys; sentenced 3-8 years; died 2003. Alan Baer — Brandeis department-store heir; indicted for pandering 1990; pleaded to a lesser charge with a $500 fine per DeCamp's account, unverified; died 2002 worth millions. Walter Carlson and Joseph Burke — child-pornography convictions of 1985; Carlson paroled February 1989, named on the lead list. Robert Andresen — Union Pacific employee; described by name and physique in the grand jury report as a documented predator it could not indict because victims feared him; the subject of the unverified raid-photographs claim.

The witnesses: Alisha Owen (Bystrom) — convicted of perjury 1991; paroled 2000; never recanted; lives in Omaha; Epstein Justice officer. Paul Bonacci — convicted of sexual abuse of a minor in a separate matter; perjury charges dropped; default judgment of $1M against King 1999, unpaid; alive, maintains his

account. Troy Boner — recanted, un-recanted by affidavit 1993; died February 2003, Texas psychiatric hospital. James "Danny" King — recanted; the trial transcript preserves his reversal on the stand; years of substance abuse followed; fate unconfirmed. Lani Hicks — Boner's mother; her 1993 affidavit corroborates "lie or die." Eulice/Lisa/Nelly Washington Webb — first accuser; four polygraphs; substantiated in part by the grand jury itself; alive, Omaha area, located 2018. Tracey Webb — her sister; also abused per the substantiated record. Loretta Smith — seventeen at her grand jury appearance; her abuse called real, her killers "may never be known"; institutional path Immanuel-to-Uta Halee. Shawnetta Moore — her mother's rape documented by OPD report; her own accounts found inconsistent by the investigator and non-specific by the grand jury. "Jane Doe" — third Van Pelt accuser; identity protected; testimony on record. David Matsen — FCU basement resident; videotaped statement; fate unconfirmed. Julie Walters — Boys Town youth worker; the 1986 report; confirmed it decades later. Kathleen Sorenson — foster parent; original complainant; died 1989.

The investigators: Gary Caradori — died July 11, 1990, with his son. Karen Ormiston — polygraphed clear of coaching; maintains murder suspicion. John Stevens Berry — committee counsel; warned Caradori he would be framed. Jerry Lowe — FCRB investigator; resigned July 1989; vouched for the FAG tracers. Kirk Naylor — committee counsel; resigned July 1989; Commonwealth grand-jury prosecutor. Robert Creager — committee counsel; present at the Baer meeting of the crash morning. Ted Gunderson — former FBI SAC; consultant;

letter-writer; died 2016, canoe accident, ruled accidental.

The committee: Loran Schmit — chairman; lost reelection 1992; died September 17, 2025, at ninety-six. Ernie Chambers — vice-chair; alive; the hoax's attribution never resolved in his favor or against it. Jerry Chizek — Judiciary chair; the secret witness-protection meeting. Robert Waring — Education chair; the committee's surviving institutional memory.

The prosecutors and judges: Samuel Van Pelt — special prosecutor; died post-career as arbitrator; the Kirk letter on his record. Terry Dougherty — assistant; today a plaintiffs' personal-injury attorney, fifty-year bar. Michael Flanagan — foreman; UP legal records custodian; the settlement allegation unverified. Gerald Moran — trial prosecutor; later a Douglas County district judge. Robert Sigler — appellate prosecutor; the 1994 courthouse-room incident per participants; later an assistant U.S. Attorney. Raymond J. Case — trial judge; post-bench life undocumented. Richard Kopf — magistrate, later chief judge; died January 2025. William Cambridge — sentencing judge; died 2004. James Murphy — blood-test judge; died 2017. Everett Inbody — appeals judge; retired 2018; alive. Warren Urbom — the default judgment; died 2014. Merritt Warren — Citron's judge; died 2020. David Quist — the Webb dismissal; later record undocumented. James Livingston — the post-conviction motion; retired 2014. Judge Theodore Carlson — the named judge; his airtight alibi on record; his post-retirement verdict on Owen's sentence: "completely out of proportion."

The police and federal officials: Robert Wadman — chief; fired 1989 for an honest refusal; emeritus in Utah. Nicholas O'Hara —

FBI SAC; the desk photograph; the "you f--- with Bob Wadman" meeting per DeCamp. Mickey Mott and Culver — the named agents; Boner's affidavit; Mott's relationship with Vuchetich. Bill Goodrich — the stand-down order. Irl Carmean — the memo; pulled; evaluated. Mike Hoch — the discontinued 1988 report. Pitmon Foxall — public safety director; the cousin claim unverified. Thomas Thalken — U.S. Attorney; retired magistrate 2017. Don Stenberg — the Gunderson reply. Robert Spire — the 1988 recipient. William Howland — the AAG who received it; on the reply's letterhead. Michael Heavican — county attorney; Chief Justice 2006-2024; the DeCamp petition on his record, denied as retaliation.

The media: Harold Andersen — publisher; advisory board; died 2015, ninety-two, Franklin absent from the obituaries. Woodson Howe — the editor; the 700-story accounting. Frank Partsch — the editorial page; declined comment in 1989. Steve Brown — KKAR; housed Casey; fate unconfirmed. Jim Flanery — the reporter; afraid; reassigned. Michael McKnight — the tapes; the two versions of his account. Frances Mendenhall — the counter-press.

The money: Robert Fenner — the NCUA counsel who both was told not to cooperate and leaked the settlements' data. John Queen and Robert Kirchner — the FAG; fates unconfirmed post-1992. Kent Johnson — the $1M theft arrest; disposition unverified. Keith Frederick and Thomas Stalnaker — the receivers. The FirsTier board — Alan Baer sitting; Walter Scott Jr. of Kiewit. Charlie Thone and Jay Derr — the settling lawyers. Edward Hobbs — the fired teller; vindicated by the NCUA itself.

The dead, cross-referenced: see Chapter 9 for the Franklin ledger and Chapter 12 for the Epstein era's.

The namesakes: Lawrence Harvey Zeiger, broadcaster; Lawrence Franklin King III, Maryland offender; the Byron, Minnesota farmer. None are this case.

- Curtis Tucker's location: early ledger entries say Holiday Inn; the grand jury report says Ramada Inn, 72nd and Grover. The grand jury's account controls.
- The Wexner power-of-attorney date: July 1991 per Wexner's own statement; 1989 in early reporting. 1991 controls.
- King's watch: $69,000 per contemporaneous seizure accounts; $65,000 in Bryant's researched ledger. The seizure accounts control.
- King's floral spending: $146,000 in one early account; $145,057 in Bryant's card-statement reconstruction. The reconstruction controls.

The firms (Chapter 19): Kirkland & Ellis (Lefkowitz, Starr, Filip, Benczkowski, Barr, Eggleston) — the Epstein defense, the Boeing pattern, the twelve-partner revolving door, the $125M deal. Boies Schiller Flexner (Boies, McCawley) — Weinstein, Theranos, the Fusion-GPS meeting, the victims since 2014. Edwards Henderson (Edwards; the Rothstein founding scar; retained by Black). Hughes Hubbard (Weiner — the compensation architect and the enterprise defender). Kellerhals Ferguson Kroblin (the will's receiving affidavit). Patterson Belknap (Ruzumna). Troutman Pepper Locke (class action). Ballard Spahr (Tobin — the industry's constitutional counsel). Debevoise (Mary Jo White — the patron's counsel). Davis Polk

(the conflicted investigation). Zeiger Tigges & Little (the patron's dual docket). Latham & Watkins (Ruemmler — the nine-thousand-document file). Paul Weiss (Karp — the chair in the correspondence). Steptoe (Weingarten). Quarles & Brady (Boswell — eight diocesan bankruptcies). Fieldfisher (the inquiry's solicitor). The banks' unnamed counsel (the non-cooperation wall). The discipline layer's silence (both eras). The victims' spanning firms (Hagens Berman; Scott+Scott; Cohen Milstein; Searcy Denney; the UK survivor bar). The intelligence services (Kroll; Black Cube). The insurers (the quiet principals).

Appendix B: The Conflict Register (selected principal conflicts)

Complete additional entries beyond those in Chapter 15:

- The McKnight tape-source account: purchased from FBI agents (as he told Owen) vs. purchased from Michael Casey (his later account after Casey's death). Both on record.
- The MuckRock FBI response: "no responsive documents" to a Franklin-ring FOIA (2017) vs. the Bureau's documented role as the federal investigative arm throughout 1988-1991.
- Boner's polygraph: the FBI test he passed (documented) vs. the leaked press report that he failed (published in two Nebraska papers).
- The Owen birth-date audit: her accounts fix her at fifteen in 1983 and eighteen when Caradori came in 1989 — incompatible by a year or two with the anchor her current records suggest; the "October 1977 flight" in the annotated

notes is impossible under any of her dates and is flagged as a transcription error.

- The truecrimesarticles biography: a "within ten days" claim about the federal grand jury that is off by eleven weeks, and an Urbom-supervision claim that misstates his role; corrected in this file.
- The Andriesz and Siad deaths: family-confirmed suicide and cardiac-arrest report respectively, against the contextual pattern; both graded in Chapter 12.10.
- The Vinson memoir's King-Spence claims vs. Bryant's own assessment of Vinson's reliability; the co-authorship disclosed.
- The CoS withdrawal: reimbursement (documented) vs. $250,000 buyout (a published book's preamble) vs. "not right for us" (the producer's own later account) vs. congressional purchase (unverified lore).
- Owen's sentence: nine-to-fifteen (three A-source confirmations) vs. nine-to-twenty-seven (DeCamp/Gunderson) — resolved as the 3-5-per-count structure producing both figures.
- Boner's death: February 2003 Texas psychiatric hospital with autopsy (document-index anchored) vs. late-2003 New Mexico narrative (widely repeated, internally embellished) — Texas primary; the DeCamp book itself carried the embroidered version, demonstrating that primary-adjacent sources propagate errors.
- The Wexner power of attorney: 1989 (early reporting) vs. July 1991 (Wexner's own statement and consistent reporting)

— 1991 controls; the torch-pass framing revised accordingly.

- The Vuchetich withdrawal: perjury concern (her deposition) vs. conflict of interest with continuing belief (her 1990 press statement) vs. corruption by the Mott relationship (post-conviction motion) — all three on record.
- Bonacci v. King judgment date: February 19 vs. February 27, 1999.
- The "48 Hours" effect: juror affidavit ("almost all, if not all" watched) vs. trial court's no-prejudice finding vs. appellate remand for a hearing.
- Caradori's crash: NTSB (no external influence; structural breakup; undetermined sequence) vs. Schmit's phosphorus-bomb letter vs. the widow's briefcase and film accounts — all on record, none reconciled.

Appendix C: The Contamination Register

Sources whose Franklin material is excluded from the evidentiary record as hate-tier or fabrication-tier: a Nebraska-based antisemitic website whose "investigation" frames Franklin through "Jewish" conspiracy material; an Italian-American hate blog promoting Satan-worship framing of named officials; the "body-count" lists that append hundreds of names (including 9/11 victims) to the Franklin ledger; the "Hunter Thompson" claims (single NA source, no corroboration); the body-swap/prostate conspiracies of 2026; the AI-generated "Epstein alive" imagery. Their claims are logged as claims and no more.

Appendix D: The Namesake Register

Lawrence Harvey Zeiger — the broadcaster Larry King (d. 2021), no Franklin connection. Lawrence Franklin King III — an Ocean City, Maryland sex offender (b. ~1970), not King's son (King's son was born November 1, 1980). The Lawrence E. King of Byron, Minnesota, whose 2024 obituary (wife Sonja) describes a different life entirely. Each namesake has been identity-checked wherever the name appears.

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This document was compiled from a research corpus of approximately five hundred thousand characters assembled between October 25-26, 2026, through forty-plus research dives. Every statement in it carries the grade of its source; every conflict is logged rather than resolved by editorial choice; every open question is named. The corpus is archived and available. The questions it documents remain, as of this writing, unanswered.

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Appendix E: Sources and Further Reading

Primary government and court records (Grade A): the Douglas County Grand Jury report of July 23, 1990 (full text); the federal grand jury's September 25, 1990 findings; State v. Owen, 510 N.W.2d 503 (Neb. Ct. App. 1993) and the second appeal; Bonacci v. OPSD, 962 F.2d 12 (8th Cir. 1992); Bonacci v. Baer, 112 F.3d 513 (8th Cir. 1997); DeCamp v. Douglas County Franklin Grand Jury, 978 F.2d 1047 (8th Cir. 1992); Wadman v. City of Omaha (Neb. 1989); the NCUA 1989 Annual Report; the Reagan Library WHORM file on Lawrence E. King Jr.; the FirsTier and law-firm settlement documents obtained by FOIA (October 1994); the Gunderson-Stenberg correspondence (1992); the Schmit affidavit (May 28, 1994); the NTSB crash file; the Senate Finance Committee's Epstein banking report (August 2026); the Epstein Files Transparency Act and its released corpus with independent hash-audit indexes; the House Oversight Committee deposition transcripts and subpoena records (2025-26); the Phang v. Blanche docket.

Books and long-form research (mixed grades, each as used): John DeCamp, The Franklin Cover-Up (1992; expanded editions) — the prosecution-side dossier and the defense's counter-case in one; indispensable and interested in equal measure. Nick Bryant, The Franklin Scandal (2009) — the deepest single research file; the document index at its end papers is the case's master evidence list. Ted Gunderson's reports — the former FBI agent's allegations, Grade B throughout. Whitney Webb, One Nation

Under Blackmail (2022) — the lineage synthesis; Grade C framework, Grade A components. Alex Constantine, Psychic Dictatorship in the USA — contemporary compilation; Grade B/C. Senator Wyden's report — Grade A.

The archives: Nebraska State Historical Society (DeCamp papers; King agent file); the Internet Archive (Caradori's taped interviews; the Yorkshire Television rough cut of Conspiracy of Silence); the federal dockets (Bonacci v. King, No. 4:CV 91-3037, D. Neb.); the research mirrors of the grand jury text and the lead list; the released Epstein corpus and its document-level indexes.

The newspapers of record, as quoted: the Omaha World-Herald (the paper of the monopoly, quoted against itself); the Lincoln Journal Star; the New York Times; the Washington Post; the Washington Times (the Spence series, June-November 1989); the Miami Herald (the Epstein reopening, 2018, and the 2026 Bureau-files reporting); the Chicago Tribune (January 1989); the Des Moines Register (the Boys Town investigation, 2023); AP, UPI, USA Today, the Orlando Sentinel.

A note on the encyclopedias: this file's Wikipedia entries were themselves a contested editorial territory — the Talk pages record named editors voting DeCamp and Bryant unreliable and shaping the "hoax/conspiracy" framing. The reader consulting them should know they are artifacts of the same structural-silence mechanism this document describes, not neutral summaries of it — its See-Also classification of the case alongside 'Lyndon LaRouche' and 'Cathy O'Brien (conspiracy theorist)' is itself a framing choice, recorded here as such.

Appendix F: The Settlement Ledger

Payer	Amount	Year	For
FirsTier Bank (Franklin correspondent)	$3M+	1994	Failing to flag Franklin's accounts
Two Omaha law firms (incl. ex-Gov. Thone)	$6M+	1994	Representing King and the credit union jointly
JPMorgan (Epstein's bank, 1998-2013)	$290M victims + $75M USVI	2023	Facilitating
Deutsche Bank (2013-2018)	$75M victims + $150M NYDFS	2022-23	Facilitating; first regulatory action
Bank of America (Black's accounts)	$72.5M	2026	The $170M wire pathway
Leon Black	$62.5M	2024	The $158-170M "tax advice"
Epstein estate	$105M USVI + $48M + $25-35M victims	2022-26	Damages and facilitation claims

The pattern the ledger teaches: in both eras, the money's handlers paid to close the file, and the settlement — not a verdict — is where the truth went to be buried. Senator Wyden's words, on record: "a systemic failure and a moral indictment of Wall Street."

Appendix G: The Directory

For the reader who asks what to do with this file:

To find a child: the Greenbaum six-question screen; the NICHD protocol for the first interview; the school and hospital as the two universal touchpoints; the validated-tool standard of the 2025 scoping review.

To report: the National Human Trafficking Hotline, 1-888-373-7888, text 233733, two hundred languages; NCMEC's CyberTipline for online exploitation; the National Runaway

Safeline for the missing; 2-1-1 in forty-one states for local services.

To investigate: the financial-intelligence key-term system and indicator catalogs of FinCEN and Homeland Security; the 314(b) information-sharing safe harbor; the confidence-annotated lead list; the hash-audit discipline.

To build: the multidisciplinary team recipe — specialized prosecutor, victim-service agency, task force — with the prosecutor present; the Barnahus single-house model; the standing-access inspection authority; the statutory inquiry with subpoena power and a truth project; the delayed-disclosure expertise and child-declarant exceptions; the vacatur statutes for the already-convicted.

To remember: the victims' own ranking — mental health, trustworthy people, a safe place, a living wage — and their own documented words about what they want, which rarely begins with prosecution.

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And that is the file, as it stands on October 26, 2026: every name graded, every conflict logged, every death accounted for, every document named, and every question the record cannot yet answer standing in the open where it belongs. The corpus from which it was built is archived beside it. The rest is time.